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PREFACE

Rampant, seemingly endless wars, both hot and cold. Widespread and wide-ranging environmental catastrophe. Unparalleled levels of global wealth and income inequality. And, in response to these and other symptoms of system breakdown, increasingly repressive and authoritarian regimes, playing upon virulently divisive rhetoric. Conditions that characterize everyday life for billions on the planet at this moment. This book is based on a course that we have co-taught at the University of Arizona over the past three years that has attempted to connect this set of existential conditions to their underlying, systemic causes. The course has also endeavored to make these connections in ways that point to coalitional politics and efficacious actions.

The principal aims of the course, and now of this book, are to think about the predominant way society is organized socially, politically, economically, culturally, and then to make the theoretical, historical, and practical connections between that way of organizing society and the kinds of consequential outcomes that are produced by doing so. And secondly, by demonstrating the systemic structural underpinnings of these seemingly disconnected issues, we hope to provide a set of rationales for political cohesion and coalition among the numerous and diverse groups that are working toward economic, social, political, and environmental justice. Particularly as presented by the major mechanisms that shape widely shared worldviews, these phenomena almost always appear, on the surface, as though they are completely unrelated to each other. This predominant characterization is true even for practitioners and activists, and therefore rarely elicits the kinds of political cohesion and coalition that are necessary for effective, coherent, and progressive responses.

Clearly, a great deal has changed on the US and international political stage since we first offered the course in 2017, but our goal, over the past three years, has been to try to emphasize the continuities in the issues that are of concern to us. That is, while we are interested in reflecting on changing conditions, we are principally focused on contextualizing such change within a broad sweep of historical, political, economic, and social phenomena. We want to make these changes explicable and highlight their inherent connections, rather than simply leave them, as often is done, as unrelated and distinct events. We endeavor to illuminate some of the new forms and emphases these issues have taken over the past several years, but again in a manner that demonstrates their linkages and grounding in longstanding systemic and institutional frameworks.

We begin, both in the course and in this book, by asking a very basic question: How do we know what we think we know about the world? In this initial inquiry, we take up a set of questions that examine the ways in which people come to understand how the world works. This set of processes, usefully understood as the production, reinforcement, and changing of common sense, is a constant project. Those who are advantaged by the status quo are continually at work to make us understand that the way things are is the way things should be. And thus, the ways in which we understand the world are very much connected to the ways in which we interact with the world. We are also intent on elucidating the complex linkages between common sense and power. Here we take up the Gramscian notions of hegemony, the definition and role of intellectuals, and the ways in which the economy (broadly understood) and other dimensions of society interact to produce the varied experiences of everyday life for different classes and categories of people.

In the second chapter, we undertake an examination of what we think about as the predominant, current common sense in much (though not all) of the world. If, as we contend, common sense is a very useful notion for understanding how we think and understand the world, what is the current common sense? We, along with other analysts, call the prevailing common sense capitalist realism. We interpret this term to be not merely descriptive of the dominant political economic framework, but also to highlight proponents' additional assertion that there is really no meaningful alternative to organizing society along the lines of late-stage industrial state capitalism. Clearly, much of society, certainly US society but many other societies as well, is organized along these lines. This is the basic framework within which we will attempt to understand the resultant issues and consequences. Again, there have been substantial changes within and among the variants of late-stage capitalism over the past several years, and our assessment situates these changes within appropriate continuities and contexts.

In the third chapter, we begin to examine some of the more consequential effects that have resulted (as would be expected, we argue) from organizing societies along the lines of a capitalist realist political economy. We begin with the multipronged relationships between capitalism and the various historical and contemporary mechanisms that

capitalists (and their vital partners within state systems) have used to spread this form of political economy around the globe. These processes have been known most commonly as colonialism or imperialism (in either their historical or neo-forms), and have often been accompanied by the often-necessarily related processes of militarism. In this chapter, we will think very carefully about how capital, when uninhibited by constraints against mobility, goes around the globe looking for the conditions that will maximize surplus value and profit. Historically (and contemporaneously as well), these have often included cheaper labor or resources, and/or more lucrative markets. More recently, alluring conditions have also included more desirable regulatory (e.g., environmental or labor), monetary, or fiscal environments to maximize profit accumulation. These adventures, quite often necessitating incursions on the prerogatives and sovereignties of others, have produced a long and bloody history and present, and a likely calamitous future.

In chapter 4, we move on to examine the most significant effects of the relationship between a capitalist political economy and the environment, which, we would argue, now constitute a second set of existential crises. While there are certainly variants of the abstract capitalist model, one persistent and typical tendency is to assess the planet as either storehouse (of needed resource inputs, including energy resources) and/or sink (for waste products of all kinds, due in large measure to a continually sought novelty, and the concomitant obsolescence of the old). As a consequence of this orientation, nature, as both inherent worth and utilitarian guarantor of sustainable life, must be subjected to the ruthless calculus of costs and benefits. In such evaluations anything that fails to maximize profits or minimize losses must be discounted, ideally to a value of zero. In combination with an intensifying focus on shorter and shorter time frames for a maximum return on investment, a competition-driven imperative to externalize all costs that do not contribute to the bottom line has produced the by-now exhaustive litany of environmental woes, including the climate catastrophe that now threatens life on the planet as we have known it.

In the subsequent chapter (chapter 5), we begin to examine the more mundane, everyday violence of capitalism in its present neoliberal, globalized, and financialized form. Though not necessarily as dramatic in some ways as militarism or environmental catastrophe, these quotidian issues are emblematic of the kinds of impacts that are being produced for billions of people in their everyday lives on the ground around the world. Beginning largely in the late 1970s and flourishing in the early 1980s (though the original ideas actually date back much further), especially in the US and UK, neoliberalism has been an ongoing project of elites to claw back the few gains made by other classes in the immediate aftermath of the Second World War. The central tenets include the elimination (or preferably the privatization) of government services of all kinds, an all-out assault on the ability of labor to organize, the massive deregulation of every segment of the economy, and the absolute faith in market-based principles to adjudicate all elements of social, political, cultural, and economic life. The results have been staggering levels of wealth and income inequality, the disappearance or significant shredding of even the most grudging social safety net provisions, the loss of the "commons" in virtually all sectors, and the truncation (ideally to zero) of public expectations for anything that might be provided by something called "society."

These then are three broad categories of consequences that we take up below: militarism (and threats of war and "terrorism"), environmental catastrophe, and the seemingly more mundane suite of neoliberal effects. But these phenomena produce reactions. Once these effects are out in the world, we need to think about the way in which social movements cohere around them, and demands for progressive change are asserted. But at the same time, we want to think about the ways in which elites (who are advantaged by maintaining or reinforcing the status quo) respond to those reactions. These are the matters that we take up in chapter six. Over the past several years (as in the many decades before), we have seen an enormous panoply of social movements for social, political, and economic justice: anti-austerity movements, environmental activism, human rights promotion (including expansions of the definition of "human" and the list of rights themselves), criminal justice reform, poverty elimination/reduction, and many others. One disheartening continuity has been the successful ability of elites to keep these movements separated from, and often, in fact, antagonistic to each other. One of our key objectives here is to demonstrate the fundamental linkages among these seemingly disparate issues, in order to provide the rationale and impetus for coalition and unity.

In the face of rising resistance, elites have been able to exploit present discontent in order to pit elements of society against each other. We also take up this side of the question in chapter six. Often this set of strategies is delivered in the guise of so-called populism (or nationalism, or patriotism, or nativism, etc.), in which blame for present conditions is placed on the most vulnerable segments of populations (immigrants, non-dominant communities, the old, the young, the differently abled, "deviants" from sexual or other norms), who are then relentlessly scapegoated

for the sake of the “virtuous” and deserving elements of society. This has (at least) the twofold effect of vesting additional power in the hands of authoritarian “populists” who will protect the worthy from the unworthy, and of diverting attention and blame away from those in the society who really make the decisions that produce the unwanted consequences.

In the final chapter, we examine some concrete elements involved in working toward progressive change, as well as some of the obstacles that constrain those efforts. It is crucial to bear in mind, as we try to convey to students in our courses, that these issues and problems do have solutions. There are people working on answers and implementing them. Their work demonstrates that useful change can be accomplished, but also that there are barriers, almost always quite significant barriers. Many of these obstacles are institutional and built into the systems of power. As an important part of any remedial work, we have to try to understand these barriers, and configure ways to overcome them. Despite such impediments, however, strenuous attempts at remedies cannot be avoided.

That, then, is the arc of the book. We begin by examining how we think we understand the world: thinking about how the world is principally organized, at least for the purposes we want to talk about; some of the most crucial consequences of that organization; and then thinking about the ways in which movements organize around those kinds of impacts. Each chapter is composed of (rather lightly and somewhat amended) edited versions of the lectures we have given over the past three years, but relying principally on those we delivered in the spring of 2019. Reflecting their differing, though linked, intentions, the two parts of each chapter are quite distinctive stylistically. In the first part of each chapter (based on Waterstone’s lectures), we endeavor to elaborate a theoretical, conceptual, and historical overview of the particular topic. The more formal style, therefore, generally elaborates this analytic and deliberately abstract emphasis. In the second part of each chapter (based on Chomsky’s lectures), we present a set of quite concrete historical and contemporaneous illustrations to drive home the more abstract points. Here, the tone and style, driven by the grounded empirical nature of the material, take on a more narrative and conversational tenor. Though in the course these two components have actually comprised separate lectures, in our delivery of them, we have been able to point out their most important linkages quite explicitly. Based upon extensive feedback, for the more than one thousand students who have taken the course over the past three years, this combination and integration of content and style has proven to be both provocative and productive. At every opportunity, here, as we hope to broaden the circulation of these ideas beyond the classroom, we will repeat that approach of drawing out the connections between the two complementary parts of each chapter.

One final word about organization and content. In order to substantiate and reinforce the points about the necessity and possibility of progressive change, and to help relieve some of the doom and gloom of the lectures, in the most recent version of the course, we included twice-weekly visits (with two exceptions, when we only had one visitor in a particular week) from activists and practitioners working on the issues under discussion during that week. Some of these were local guests who visited the class in person; others were virtual visitors who came in electronically from around the country. As part of a section for each chapter on further resources (located all together at the end of the book), which will include all of the required and suggested readings for each chapter as well as a few key, additional references, we will also present a very brief overview of the presentation by each of our visitors, as well as links to their organizations. Again our sense, from student feedback, is that these visits accomplished our intended purpose of providing class participants with hope that change is possible, and with some entrée into that sphere of activity.

The younger generation in our courses, and those reading this book, are facing problems that have never arisen in human history, in all of history. Will the species survive? Will organized human life survive? Those questions cannot be avoided. There is no way to sit on the sidelines. If one takes that option, it is essentially making a choice for the worst. This book is our attempt to articulate what more efficacious actions might look like and how they might be undertaken.

Chapter 1

COMMON SENSE, THE TAKEN-FOR-GRANTED, AND POWER

Waterstone Lecture, January 15, 2019

How do we know what we think we know about the world? How do we navigate through our day-to-day lives, and how do we negotiate novel situations? In this first chapter, we are interested in taking up questions about the mechanisms involved in producing, reinforcing, and sometimes changing the interpretive processes through which people come to conclusions (sometimes correct, but often incorrect or inaccurate) about: (1) how the world does operate in specific circumstances; and (2) how the world might or should operate. While we begin this discussion at a somewhat abstract and general level, we are concerned throughout with thinking about such matters within the contexts that are of foremost interest to us; that is, in public social, political, and economic contexts rather than in predominantly private spheres of thought and activity. As a beginning shorthand, we will term what many people in a particular time and place believe common sense.

THE NOTION OF COMMON SENSE

“Central to the notion of common sense is that its truths need no sophistication to grasp, and no proof to accept. Their truth is agreed to by the whole social body, and immediately apparent to anyone of normal intelligence.” This definition, from Kate Crehan’s book (2016), includes a number of very slippery concepts, things that we should be very troubled by whenever we see them, things like “the whole social body,” “anyone of normal intelligence,” and things or ideas that we accept simply on their face without proof. All of those things should be alerts to us. But they are elements clearly of what we think we understand about the notion of common sense. In fact, that’s part of how common sense works, through these kinds of unexamined, taken-for-granted mechanisms.

There are several different senses of common sense. The first one from Aristotle is that common sense is actually a sixth sense that organizes the other five senses and allows us to understand the world. In other words, we experience all kinds of sensory input, whether it’s through hearing or through sight, smell, touch, or taste, but there is a sixth sense, which, according to Aristotle, allows us to integrate all of that and make things that come into our brain meaningful. That’s one notion of common sense, a kind of mechanistic notion.

Second is what people in a particular time and place know about the world and how it works. Scale actually matters here; that is the closer you are, the more proximity you have to others, the more common is your common sense (at least as posited in this sort of framing), and the more distinguished from distant others. This notion is where we get a phrase like, “Well, it’s only common sense. Of course that’s how things operate.” That’s another sort of notion of common sense.

A third one is one that actually puts a normative valence on some common sense and gives it a kind of positive inflection. This notion of common sense makes it the equivalent of good sense. This variant is sometimes characterized as street smarts versus book smarts. You know what your gut tells you. We have many people who operate in society that way. This is where a phrase like “Use your common sense” is employed. In other words, “You know how the world works, right, so use your good sense.”

Now let’s turn to a formulation that characterizes all of this a little bit differently: British sociologist and social theorist Anthony Giddens and his notion of practical consciousness (1984). This is related to common sense. The first two of the framings of common sense just described (the Aristotelian notion and the notion of what everybody sort of knows about how the world works) are related to what Giddens thinks of as practical consciousness, which he describes as an accumulation of learned behavior for navigating the situations that confront us in our everyday lives. He calls it practical consciousness, and he distinguishes it from what he defines as discursive consciousness (1984).

When utilizing discursive consciousness, one must have an internal conversation that tells you how to operate in the world. You have to think about things very carefully. Practical consciousness doesn’t work that way. You actually sort of know, under many circumstances, how to behave, what to expect, what will happen in the world if you behave a particular way, which is why last year I opened by yelling at people because it’s not what we think we understand about a situation like this. It’s not part of the decorum. It’s unexpected.

But practical consciousness is rarely raised to this kind of discursive internal conversation level. This is essential. The fact that we don’t have to think about every single thing we do and how we operate in the world is a very good thing. Otherwise, we would essentially be paralyzed. If we had to relearn every instance in which we operate in the world every day, we would in fact be constrained from behaving at all. So it’s a good thing that much of what we do in our interactions is routinized in this way; that is, that it is, in fact, a practical rather than a discursive consciousness.

There are some circumstances where we become aware that we are operating in a rule-bound way. One of those circumstances is when we are in novel situations. For example, when we travel and come into settings where we don’t know the rules. A couple of things happen then. If you’ve had this experience, you know this is the case. One thing, you have to think a bit about how to behave, what’s the proper behavior, what will keep you in a safe zone rather than encountering things that become uncomfortable. So that’s one of the things that happen: you begin to think about how things work in unfamiliar settings. If they work differently than how they work where you usually operate, well, you might wonder how will I find out how things work? That’s one thing that happens.

The second thing that happens if we're at least conscious of that process, is that we begin to understand that much of behavior is in fact rule-bound. It's rule-governed, even if in most situations we don't have to think about those rules, or even the fact that there are rules.

This is a very important kind of step, to think about the fact that much of behavior is rule-bound, and this is what Giddens is thinking about when he says that practical consciousness works for most everyday situations, but there are circumstances in which we begin to become aware that we have internalized a whole number of rule-governed behaviors (1984). In fact, to use a phrase that I want to emphasize, we take things for granted.

A second circumstance in which we might move from practical to discursive consciousness is when we are operating in situations where we think we know the rules, but something unexpected happens. Either something unpredictable occurs, or we don't like the consequences. But again, this kind of situation produces in us this notion that life is rather rule-bound and that we need to understand how things work.

One important question that Giddens asks about all of this, and that we'll come back and think about, is where do all these rules come from? How do these rules of behavior come into play? I'll come back to this in a little bit more detail in a minute, but just for the moment, let me introduce this very unfortunate word that Giddens coined. This is a process that he calls structuration (1984).

What he means by that is that people through their practices make and reinforce the rules, but then forget about the fact that they are people-made rules. The rules begin to take on a character that looks like they simply operate independently of society. That issue where we forget that we are the rule makers is what makes the status quo so persistent to some degree. Again, we come to take the rules of everyday life for granted. This is how things work; this is how things should work. It's just common sense. I'll come back and talk about that. I also want to make clear, at this point, that not everyone is in an equal position in making these rules and making them stick, and we'll come back and think about that.

Where does our common sense come from? How do we learn these rules? One quote from Kate Crehan again: "In a sense, we all have our own particular stock of common sense. Much of this will be shared by others in our immediate environment [that is this proximity issue], diverging as those others become more distant. So we're acculturated into understanding these rules" (2016).

The earliest influences clearly, and this will be fairly prosaic, are our parents and immediate family. There is some notion that some of this learning actually occurs in the womb, but not going to get into that at the moment. After our immediate family, our extended family, our friends, the educational system, including religious education if that's part of our background, the media, very broadly defined, the culture apparatuses, the kinds of things that get our attention, and then our own accumulated experience.

I just want to note here a little caution, which again I'll say a bit more about in a bit. Our own accumulated experience becomes increasingly solidified over time. That is, we start to think we know how the world works, and things that accord with that evolving viewpoint we take in much more easily than things that seem to contradict how we think the world works. This evolution is a kind of ongoing process to the extent that we need to understand further and further how the world works.

It's also important here to distinguish between what's possible to know and understand firsthand from information that must be delivered second-, third-, fourth-hand by a various media; that is, mediated information, which is more and more the case. I mean, we know less and less about the world firsthand than we do through other sources of information.

It is also critical to point out that nothing enters our brains or minds unfiltered. Going back to the idea from Aristotle, the first definition of common sense (i.e., the extra sense that allows us to make meaningful what other senses tell us about the world) sidesteps the very important question of how this additional sense is itself built. What I'm suggesting is that part of our acculturation, part of the way we develop a sense of the common sense, is to develop a set of filters that tells us what's important, what's not important, how we should interpret what we get as stimuli. Some of that can be right, some of it can be wrong.

So the issue of taken-for-grantedness, and reinforcement of common sense, is a very important phenomenon. This is,

in fact, what I just described, that is that we begin to filter those things that don't really accord with how we think the world works, and we reject those things that really are contradictory. This is especially the case, I would suggest, and is becoming increasingly the case, through what we think about as either this bubble or silo effect. This is where we're channeled in many of our media interactions, particularly into things that we seem to have already accepted.

So anytime you see a prompt, "If you liked this, you will love that," know that this tactic works according to algorithms that produce this channeling effect. This is happening in all kinds of ways on social media and even in the mainstream media. People are CNN people, or they're MSNBC people, or they are Fox News people. So there's a tendency to sort of silo ourselves or put ourselves in these bubbles, and that's becoming increasingly the case.

Now, an important question: Are we thinking about common sense (singular) or are we thinking about common senses (plural)? All too often, one rational being's obvious fact is another's questionable or flat-out wrong assertion. There is more than one common sense, and even seemingly incontrovertible facts have a way of shifting over time. Even for ourselves, something that we may have believed at one point in time, if we are open-minded, we might believe something quite different at a later date. But quite clearly, there are different common senses operating simultaneously. These are the sources of controversy and argumentation.

The notion of the single common sense, "[w]hich all men have in common in any given civilization is quite foreign to the spirit of the [Gramsci prison] notebooks. For Gramsci as for Marx, any given civilization is so fractured by inequality that understanding it requires us to begin with that inequality. Those most elementary things which are the first to be forgot, the fact that there really do exist rulers and ruled, leaders and led. Common sense in all its multitudinous confusion is the product of a fractured world" (Crehan 2016).

Yes, there are multiple common senses operating at any particular time and place. There are always competing common senses at play, which tells us several things. Immediately, it tells us that common sense is unstable. It changes over time. It changes from place to place, from one group, for example a social class, from one setting to another, and so on. This also tells us that common sense is both malleable and subject to manipulation. It's not a stable thing. Common sense can shift.

Let's begin to tie those notions of what common sense is about to political action. Ultimately, as Kate Crehan argues, "what interests Gramsci is the knowledge that mobilizes political movements capable of bringing about radical transformations" (2016). This is what Gramsci was interested in. One of his central questions was trying to understand how the Italian people came to accept Mussolini and fascism. So he was very interested in coming to grips with that kind of question.

The most important knowledge would seem to be precisely knowledge that when embodied in self-aware collectivities has the potential to act in the world. For Gramsci, the primary such collectivities as a good Marxist were class, classes. He was interested in class struggle.

The webs of intelligibility in which our socialization wraps us from the day of our birth are a reality from which we all begin. We are all to some degree creatures of popular opinion, and yet of certain historical moments, there is radical social transformation. When and why does this happen? Running through the Gramsci notebooks is the question, what is the relationship between popular opinion, another phrasing of common sense, and social transformation? How are these things tied together, if they are tied together at all? This was a central question for Gramsci and one that Marx really did not take up to any significant degree. So Gramsci is thought of in many ways as a cultural theorist of Marxism.

"Despite all his criticisms" of common sense—and Gramsci was quite critical of it; he thinks of it as a kind of hodgepodge, and he thinks of it as very unsophisticated in many ways—"Gramsci's attitude wasn't wholly negative. Embedded within the chaotic confusion of common sense, that is both home and prison, he identifies what he terms buon senso [good sense]" (Crehan, 2016). That is, we feel comfortable in our notion of common sense, but we're also bounded by it. That's home and prison in this case. And there's a kernel of good sense in common sense.

The phrase "being philosophical about it," in addition to calling for patience or resignation, can also be seen, and it was for Gramsci, as an invitation for people to reflect and to realize fully that whatever happens is basically rational and must be confronted as such. This is the way in which good sense can be extracted out of common sense, but it's a process. It's a process that Gramsci says has to be extracted, made coherent by intellectuals, that this is the role of

intellectuals for Gramsci.

But he has a very ecumenical notion of intellectuals. Anyone, in Gramsci's view, given the opportunity, could be an intellectual, that is, a person who could reflect on the conditions of their own material existence and think about why that existence has the characteristics that it does. So for Gramsci, anyone could be an intellectual.

The role of intellectuals is to extract the good sense out of the hodgepodge of common sense. Gramsci thinks about intellectuals as falling roughly into two categories. Organic intellectuals are those that remain connected to their class and further class interests. Now by saying that, that doesn't necessarily mean of one sort of political stripe or another. Adam Smith, the classical economist, I would argue, is an organic intellectual for his class, the bourgeois class.

Traditional intellectuals, as Gramsci describes them, are people who are interested in being apologists or explainers or supporters of the status quo. The traditional intellectuals are also what Marx would have called the vulgar economists, with whom he was engaged in conversation and contention. So the role of intellectuals is to extract the kernels of good sense out of common sense.

Okay. Now, let me turn from the abstract for a minute and think about a concrete example of something that we think about as common sense, which we will come back to in certain ways through other parts of the course. So as common sense, the American dream. If I say that phrase, do you get a picture in your mind immediately? What does it look like?

The American dream, here it is: In America (and this is not just confined to America of course), if you work hard, play by the rules, you will succeed. Work hard, play by the rules, you will succeed. That's part of the dream. Typically, it also includes a metric for what constitutes success. It almost invariably takes a commodified form, success. Since that's the kind of reward a capitalist system can and must deliver.

For example, a recurrent formulation is a home of one's own. Now, I don't want to go very far into a discussion of why this particular measure of success, that is, a home of one's own in the suburbs and so forth, was the preferred form of connoting and illustrating the American dream. But it had a great deal to do with the rise of mass consumption. The phrase itself, the American dream, was coined in the '30s basically in the heart of the Depression. Much of this framing was pointed at the need to keep the economy rumbling at a great pace when World War II ended. So one of the ways in which industry could keep going was to promulgate not collective consumption, but individual consumption. So everybody had to have their own house. And, consequently, everybody had to have their own Kelvinator, their own appliances. You couldn't share these things in common. That wasn't enough market. So the American dream takes a particular, that is, a commodified, form.

The American dream, as common sense, also has some taken-forgranted presumptions underlying it. The first is that America is a meritocracy. That is, a system in which people's success in life depends on their talents, abilities, and efforts. This is one of the presumptions underlying the notion that if you work hard, play by the rules, you will succeed. There's an ethos of individual achievement. You get this on your own—the self-made man, the self-made woman.

This translates into a number of other societies. Some of you may remember the iron lady, Margaret Thatcher. One of her many, many quotable quotes was "There is no such thing as society," spoken as she was dismantling British society at the time. There is no such thing as society. There are only individual men and women, and then it's kind of, after that, and their families, okay, if you can keep them together under those circumstances.

Another tacit presumption is that the rules are fair and are known or knowable to all, that is, that we operate on a level playing field. If these presumptions are violated, then the formulation of the American dream is very much in jeopardy. But if we presume that these things are the case, then we might be persuaded that the American dream is in fact a viable conception of society.

But I'm going to suggest … I'm not going to suggest. I'm just going to say, there's an obverse meaning to take away from the common sense understanding of how our society operates. That obverse meaning is this: In America, if you don't succeed, you are either not working hard enough, or you are not playing by the rules, or both. So if you don't succeed, and this is the obverse of thinking about the American dream as it's laid out, essentially, your failure is

your own fault. This is another corollary of the individualized notion of how society works. All the opportunities are there. If you fail, it is your fault. There is nothing structural or systemic or unfair getting in your way, either historically, contemporaneously, or into the future.

Let's think about these presumptions and the obverse for a minute. How can you work hard if there are no jobs for you? Which is increasingly the prospect, as we think about the export of jobs that has occurred; as we think about automation taking jobs away; as we think about productivity going up but the demand for labor going down. One of the problems might be, "Well, I'd like to work hard, I just can't find work." Or what if your job pays so poorly that despite working very hard, and sometimes at more than one job at a time, you still can't make ends meet? So the pay structure doesn't allow success, despite hard work.

Anybody who's interested in this kind of thing, I'd recommend any of the works by Barbara Ehrenreich, either Nickel and Dimed or some of her more recent works, in which she talks about the fact that many people are working really, really hard and simply can't get by. What if the rules are rigged against you in some way and are unfair?

I know we are in a post-racial society, but I suspect there are still a few impediments. We are also now in the feminist utopia. So fifty-nine cents on the dollar should go just as far as a dollar on the dollar, right? Or what if there are unwritten or unspoken rules that discriminate against some people? Or what if there are early impediments to equal educational opportunities or family connections or other factors that make the playing field anything but level, which, as I suggested, should be the hallmark of a meritocracy?

An interesting study was done by the Center for Budget Priorities called Born on Third Base. This is an analysis of people who are on the Fortune 400. This is not the Fortune 500, which charts companies, but the Fortune 400, which lists the richest individuals in the world. This study does an assessment of how those people started out. Third base means you've inherited at least $50 million. So our current president wouldn't qualify at least in his first six years of life. But then they go all the way down to first base, which is still pretty substantial. A first-base person would be someone like Bill Gates, who's one of the poster children for the self-made person. He had the opportunity to go to Harvard and by his own admission was not a self-made person, and has really been helped by society a great deal, including all the infrastructure paid for by public R&D upon which the computer industry itself was built.

But in any event, they go through this list, and it turns out that only 35 percent of people on the Fortune 400 were born anywhere but first base (itself a space with substantial material advantages). Most people don't even know there's a ball field, okay, let alone come anywhere close to be on-deck circle or anything else like that. But these early advantages or impediments, either to educational opportunities or family connections, may have something to do with your success, no matter how hard you work, or how much you play by the rules.

So the American dream is like that. But if we let the common sense notion of the American dream stand just for a moment, here are a couple questions that we should ask of any taken-for-granted elements of the political, social, and economic status quo. The first is who benefits from this view of society? That is, if we believe the American dream, that to succeed, people must work hard, must play by certain rules that are written not by them, but with which they must comply. If we believe that, who benefits from that kind of orientation to society and who loses? We should always be thinking about who are the winners and the losers here.

It also suggests some questions about the political, social, and economic implications of such an understanding. For example, what does it mean about the role of government? If everything is by your own bootstraps, does government have any role in helping people out? Or what about civil society? Does anything require the intervention of civil society? Or should we just let the tender mercies of the market tell us how things ought to operate? But taking the American dream in its typical formulation has very serious implications for what we think about the role of any of these institutions. So we need to think carefully about that. And it's one of the reasons we can see assaults on things like welfare, unless it's called a subsidy, assaults on entitlement programs, so-called, even though we've paid for them.

But if your belief is that people just make it or don't make it simply on their own by their own dint of activity and effort, then there really is no role for society. People simply make it or they don't make it. But as I say, thinking about this has some implications for that.

If you have a high tolerance for obscenity, I would urge you to find this on YouTube. The late George Carlin. I'd

urge you to take a look at “The American Dream. You Have to Be Asleep to Believe It.”

All right. Now let’s turn to the relationship between common sense and power. Here’s a quote from the late cultural theorist Stuart Hall. It’s a little bit long but it’s worth going through:

Why then is common sense so important? Because it is a terrain of conceptions and categories on which the practical consciousness of the masses of the people is actually formed. It is the already formed and taken for granted terrain on which more coherent ideologies and philosophies must contend for mastery, the ground which new conceptions of the world must take into account, contest and transform if they were to shape the conceptions of the world of the masses and in that way become historically effective. (Hall 1986)

Basically, what Hall is talking about here is that we have embedded within us very heavily cemented notions of how the world works. If we want to change people’s minds and think about the world operating differently, we have to contend with those deeply embedded and vitally held conceptions of how the world operates. He uses this language quite deliberately. We have to contend. This is a struggle.

So “popular beliefs, the culture of a people,” Gramsci argues, “are not matters, are not arenas that can be left to look after themselves. They are themselves material forces. Common sense is a field of struggle and contestation” (Hall 1986). That is, for Hall, this is an arena for very fierce battles. The reason for this, of course, is that to have one’s view of how the world operates become predominant is a very potent form of political power. If you can convince people that your sense of how the world ought to operate is the way it ought to operate, this is an extremely powerful political tool.

This form of power is also related to Gramsci’s important concept of hegemony. One definition of hegemony, and there are other definitions, I mean, we have some definitions of hegemony in common parlance, like the US is the world’s only hegemon, which is a debatable point no matter what, but that’s not exactly the meaning I’m using here. Hegemony, as I’m using the term here, is governance with the consent of the governed.

The alternative form of governance is coercion. Now think about it, if you’re an elite and you want to govern people, which of these forms is preferable? Well, of the two, hegemony is much more desirable for the governors since governance with consent does not produce opposition and resistance by definition. If people are consenting to be governed, why would they object? Why would they resist?

It should also be noted, though, that these two forms are never mutually exclusive, but rather they exist on a continuum, since governance structures invariably reserve to themselves the exclusive and legitimate use of coercion when necessary or when consent fails. These forms are related to each other. But given the option, governors would prefer the hegemonic form rather than the coercive form, which does produce resistance.

But why do people consent to be governed? This is the way in which we’re going to now begin to tie this back to questions of common sense and so forth. It’s a question of legitimacy. The ruled must believe that the rulers are operating in their interest. This is the basis upon which people cede consent or give consent to be governed. They think the governors, their rulers, are operating in their interest. So they accord those rulers legitimation. In fact, the failure of this form of governance is often referred to or often is contained in a legitimation crisis, that is, when legitimacy begins to fail.

How is this belief developed, that governors act in the interest of the governed? By the rulers promulgating and constantly reinforcing a particular common sense about the world, not only is the way they are operating the way the world is, but it’s the way the world should be. I just want to emphasize that this is a constant project. Rulers have to constantly promulgate and reinforce this idea that they are operating in the public good on behalf of the governed. It is a constant project.

In the second half of this chapter, we present a number of cases, both from recent history and from contemporary situations that illustrate the ends of this continuum. We make the point that for societies that purport to be democratic, consent, based upon a constantly reinforced common sensical understanding of the legitimacy of the rulers, is not only the most desirable form of governance, but is necessary to maintain the veneer (whether thick or thin) of democracy itself. For more dictatorial or despotic regimes, even the pretense of consent is less necessary, at least for a time.

By definition, everything in opposition to that common sense becomes quite literally unthinkable and becomes—and I use this term advisedly—nonsense. It is not sensical to object to the governors, if they're acting in your interest. This is the fundamental idea that underpins the way in which this form of governance works. And many, many philosophers have articulated it, but it is that the governors are acting in the interests of those who are being governed, and therefore have legitimate control over the reins of governance.

Again from Kate Crehan's book, "the narratives that become hegemonic are those that reflect the world as seen from the vantage point of the rulers rather than the ruled typically" (2016). We'll come back to this. Again from Stuart Hall: "First, hegemony is a very particular historically specific and temporary moment in the life of a society. It's rare for this degree of unity to be achieved, enabling a society to set itself a quite new historical agenda under the leadership of a specific formation or constellation of social forces [with a critical part here]. Such periods of settlement are unlikely to persist forever." There's nothing automatic about them. They have to be actively constructed and positively maintained. Otherwise, such hegemonies risk falling apart.

We can see this when we see schisms even within the ruling class, and there are many times when that occurs, and those may be moments of interesting opportunity. But hegemony is unstable and begins to break down when rulers lose their legitimacy. This can happen when the ruled no longer believe, for a whole variety of possible reasons, that governance is in their interest. This is what I refer to as a legitimation crisis. It's at that point that governance structures even lose the ability to wield coercion uncontested.

Gramsci makes a very clear argument that before coercion can be legitimately utilized, governance structures have to have won a war of position, that is, they already have to be seen as legitimate before they can legitimately wield even coercive forms of government. So when this begins to break down, and you can begin to think about all kinds of reasons why people would start to lose faith that their leaders are, in fact, acting in their interests. We're at a particularly fraught moment right now [winter 2018–2019], I would say. I mean, I don't know how many of you were thinking of not coming tonight in sympathy with the government shutdown. I thought about it momentarily, but I decided I'd come in and do this.

But in any event, there are moments clearly when the seeming solidity of the governance structures are revealed to be rather fragile. And when they are, this is a moment when people begin to call into question all kinds of things about the way in which their society operates. So legitimation crises are extremely troubling moments for governance structures and for elites. As Hall is arguing here, this is invariably the case. And people who want radical change need to be prepared for those moments.

Also from Creehan's book: "For there to be fundamental social change therefore, there needs to be cultural transformation. That is to say a new common sense, and with it a new culture that enables subalterns, that is those who are ruled or governed, to imagine another reality" (2016). Part of the potency of common sense, and this is why I used the alternative word "nonsense" a moment ago, part of the potency of the common sense, is to rule out our thinking any differently about the world. That is, to subjugate our own mental capacity to imagine the world otherwise.

It's why I used that phrase, which I took from Mark Fisher (2009), which he took from an unnamed and unclaimed source about capitalist realism. It is now easier to imagine the end of the world than to imagine the end of capitalism. That's an emblematic form of this kind of notion of the constraints on our own imagination. We know we're hurdling over several different cliffs, as Noam talked about last Thursday, and yet we can't seem to imagine our way out of this form that is so genocidal, suicidal, planet-cidal, right?

As Crehan is arguing, based on Gramsci, we need to be able to formulate a new common sense to combat the existing one and open up the possibilities of different imaginaries. "The value of Gramsci's concept of common sense is that it offers us a way of thinking about the texture of everyday life that encompasses its givenness [that is, the way in which we're thrown into it at birth]—how it both constitutes our subjectivity, the way we think about ourselves, and confronts us as an external and solid reality" (2016). This is back to Giddens's notion of structuration (1984).

The way the world works doesn't seem to have been created by us. It simply seems to confront us as a kind of materiality that we have no say in changing. This is what we really need to be combating. "But that also acknowledges its contradictions, fluidity and flexibility. For all its apparent solidity, it [that is, common sense] is

continually being modified by how actual people in actual places live it" (Giddens 1984). So it's important, it's vitally important, to understand the sort of fluid nature of common sense, that it is not solid in the way that it's constantly being told to us.

In a work by Edward Bernays there is, in fact, a conversation about how all of this actually works. This is Edward Bernays: "Propaganda is the executive arm of the invisible government" (1928). So Bernays, interesting character, he was twice, and in two different ways, a nephew of Sigmund Freud and fancied himself a kind of amateur psychologist of the popular mind. Very early on, he was the self-described father of public relations. He invented the form, according to himself. He was involved in a whole number of early activities, some of which we'll talk about a bit later. He was involved in the Creel Commission, which was organized with Walter Lippmann and others to motivate a very reluctant US public into supporting the US entry into World War I under Woodrow Wilson. We return to this effort in a bit more detail below.

So he was involved in a number of those kinds of things. One of his most famous and longstanding sets of efforts had to do with tobacco. He really was very, very influential in getting people to smoke. Later in life, in an autobiographical kind of mea culpa, he regretted that activity. But one of the things that he did (and this is just by way of illustration of the sort of mental attitude he had about public opinion), one of the last impediments to the market for cigarettes was getting women to smoke, and particularly getting women to smoke in public.

So one of the large grandstand events that Bernays organized was a liberty march in the Macy's Thanksgiving Day parade in New York. He hired about thirty debutantes. I don't know if that word draws any resonance. These were young women of society who were going to be introduced to society. He had them march in the parade, each of them holding aloft a little torch of freedom. That little torch of freedom was a Lucky Strike cigarette. This was the kind of thing he was engaged in.

But here are some of his views: "The conscious and intelligent manipulation of the organized habits and opinions of the masses is an important element in democratic society. Those who manipulate this unseen mechanism of society constitute an invisible government, which is the true ruling power of our country." Some people might now call that the deep state. I wouldn't, but some people might. "We are governed, our minds are molded, our tastes formed, our ideas suggested largely by men we have never heard of" (1928). He is referring to himself and other people who are behind the scenes manipulating public opinion, which is another phrase for common sense.

"In almost every act of our daily lives, whether in the sphere of politics or business, in our social conduct or ethical thinking, we are dominated by the relatively small number of persons … who understand the mental processes and social patterns of the masses. It is they who pull the wires which control the public mind" (1928).

Now for Bernays, this was a very good thing. I mean, in his mind, this was a good thing, and this is the reason for it: "Truth is mighty and must prevail. And if anybody, and any body of men believe that they have discovered a valuable truth, it is not merely their privilege, but their duty to disseminate that truth. If they realize, as they quickly must, that this spreading of truth can be done upon a large scale and effectively only by organized effort, they will make use of the press and the platform as the best means to give it wide circulation" (1928). So he was engaged, remember, in the onset of public relations and mass marketing. So he's starting to use these levers that had become recently available for disseminating these truths.

"Propaganda becomes vicious and reprehensible only when its authors consciously and deliberately disseminate what they know to be lies, or when they aim at effects which they know to be prejudicial to the common good" (1928). But of course the common good is defined by these people, so it's almost invariable that they will not be defined as the common good. But the danger is there, and he's warning people about it.

"The imaginatively managed event can compete successfully with other events for attention. Newsworthy events involving people usually do not happen by accident, they are planned deliberately to accomplish a purpose to influence our ideas and actions" (1928). And many of the things that Bernays was engaged in were these kinds of grandstanding, large-scale public events. So as I say, he sort of describes himself as the father of public relations. This is part of the mechanism that he used. We return to Bernays in the second part of the chapter in order to connect some of his work in "public relations" to projections of US political and military power.

All right. Let's bring this a little bit up-to-date. This is in a piece by Chris Hedges called "The Permanent Lie," and

it will now start to resonate in slightly different ways with the contemporary moment. “The most ominous danger we face comes from the marginalization and destruction of institutions, including the courts, academia, legislative bodies, cultural organizations and the press that once ensured that civil discourse was rooted in reality and fact, helped us distinguish lies from truth, and facilitated justice” (2017).

“The permanent lie is not circumscribed by reality. It is perpetuated even in the face of overwhelming evidence that discredits it. It is irrational. Those who speak in the language of truth and fact are attacked as liars, traitors and purveyors of fake news” (Hedges 2017). So this is what Hedges is concerned about happening at the moment. Then he quotes Hannah Arendt from her book The Origins of Totalitarianism: “The result of a consistent and total substitution of lies with factual truth is not that the lie will now be accepted as truth and truth be defamed as a lie, but that the sense by which we take our bearings in the real world—and the category of truth versus falsehood is among the mental means to this end—is being destroyed” (quoted in Hedges 2017).

So it’s not that a particular lie is believed, or that a particular truth is devalued, but the mechanisms that we have for discerning one from the other are themselves under assault. This is what Arendt was concerned about and what Hedges now sees coming back around.

The press and the media more generally are often described as the enemy of the people, which has some very long … There’s a long history of such attacks as part of authoritarian regimes, which we’ll discuss further a little bit later on. Assaults on journalism and journalists. So the pieces that are in today’s readings describe a very significant uptick in the sort of ways in which journalism, journalists, and facticity and evidence are really being very much undermined by activities.

Finally, Edward Bernays again. “Freedom of speech and its democratic corollary, a free press have tacitly expanded our Bill of Rights to include the right of persuasion” (1947). Again, he’s justifying this activity of his. “This development was an inevitable result of the expansion of the media of free speech and persuasion. All these media provide open doors to the public mind.” So he’s saying that this is just … it’s a kind of technological determinism. Once you have the platform there, of course people are going to use it for these purposes. “Anyone of us through these media may influence the attitudes and actions of our fellow citizens.” I’ve added those emphases just so you’ll know which words are again a little bit suspect and slippery.

So we’ve already established the fact that common sense is malleable. Now we have to look at the very uneven power landscape on which such contests, over the common sense, are waged. This discussion will focus mostly on the US media landscape, but the basic points apply quite well to many other media environments (with some exceptions for state-owned media, for better or worse). It’s clear from the Bernays piece that even at that time, 1947, particular actors in society are in much more advantageous positions to influence public opinion than others, another name for common sense. What’s happened since that time?

This a quote from Katherine Graham, the former publisher, during the Watergate episode, of the Washington Post: “News is what someone wants suppressed; everything else is just advertising.” What’s happened since that time? Mass media, and I’ll talk about social media in a minute. At the moment, and this is always in a little bit of flux and a little bit confusing, six corporations control 90 percent of what we read, watch, or listen to. Six corporations. It’s a little bit mystifying for me to put it that way. When I say six corporations, it makes it sound as though there’s nobody there really making decisions, but in fact corporations don’t decide, people in them decide things. We’ll talk about the ways in which these corporations decide things in a minute.

In 1983, 90 percent of what Americans saw, watched, heard, and so forth, was controlled by fifty corporations. By this point in 2012, six corporations. And the number six is a little bit misleading, because all of the cross-linkages among these companies make it even fewer than the apparent six in some ways. There are all kinds of joint ownership operations, and all kinds of cooperative agreements, so that any particular cultural or media entity or product has very few hands on it.

Another way to look at it, same six corporations. If you follow the business news, you will see mergers being suggested all the time even among these six corporations of various sorts. Some have gone through in the last couple of years; some have been thwarted. I would also suggest, and we’ll talk about this when we talk about neoliberal financialized, globalized capitalism, this is not unique to the media industry. That this kind of merger, this kind of consolidation of ownership is now system-wide. And there are lots of very good reasons why this makes sense to the

corporations themselves.

So these six corporations, and more precisely, the key decision makers within them, set the boundaries on acceptable debate on what's socially, politically, economically possible. They make their decisions on those things based on profit maximization, both short and long term. If you think they're making their decisions on anything else, you are mistaken. I'll just put that out as a very bald assertion, okay? But, as we discuss in the second half of the chapter, even these kinds of decisions are bounded by the prevailing common sense, in terms of what is permissible, in any particular time and place, to say, or even to think.

Now, I'm hedging on that a little bit by saying short and long term. Short-term, they want to maximize profits in the immediate sense for their investors, who are always looking for the next best thing. And with electronic financial trading now, that means in basically nanoseconds. So big funds jump from investment to investment on the marginal returns that they think they will get in the next not quarter, but maybe quarter of a minute. So they make their decisions based on that.

But these decision makers also make their decisions as being part of the governance structure, the hegemonic governance structure, on what will maintain their legitimacy. So they think about that a little bit. But when they have to make a trade-off between short and long term, they decide short term, otherwise the CEO and the board of directors are out fairly quickly.

All right. They make their decisions that way. Let me just go back for this for one second, and ask you to think a little bit about what the media's products are, which I put out as a question before. Are they selling an entertainment thing? Are they selling news? Are they selling information? No. They're selling you. They're selling you to advertisers. You are their product. There's no question about that.

So when they make a decision about what to put in the newspaper, or what to put on television, or what to put on any other platforms, or put into movies or whatever, they're making decisions on how they will garner the most of you. That's the basis for the decision. Don't be deceived by the fact that they make claims about being representatives of the First Amendment, and their duty to the public, I mean which is partly … okay, it's not really even partly true, except for performing a legitimation function. Virtually entirely, they make their decisions based on what will sell the most.

Do the media companies engage in censorship? Yes. They certainly do. At a minimum, they engage in censorship of this kind, of selection bias. So how many of you know the motto of the New York Times?

Crowd:All the news …Female:That's fit to print."All the news that's fit to print," right, which in fact should be modified to "all the news that fits, it prints." And how much news fits? It depends on the advertising space that's taken up in the paper. What's left over is the news hole, which is how it's described, and maybe has a kind of negative connotation.

The news hole grows or shrinks depending on how much advertising space is taken up. So at a minimum, they engage in a selection bias. Of all the things that happen in the world on any particular day, they have to make judgments about what to either print or to broadcast or to put on the air, and so forth. How do they do that? They do it by determining which things out of the panoply that's available are likely to attract the most eyes, the most readers, the most viewers. That's how they do it.

It's one of the reasons why if you flip around, and you can try this at home, from channel to channel on the network news, not only will you see the same stories out of the thousands and thousands of things that happen in the world that day, but you'll see them basically in the same order with the same presentation. It's not because the editors are sitting in a room colluding, I know that's a very bad word, with each other, but they are in fact using the same kind of lens to think about that panoply of events, which things are likely to produce the most number of viewers or readers or whatever.

Now, do you remember this: 658? Any idea what this is? I haven't given you any hints whatsoever. But now, I'm going to give you a hint, a big hint. What if I said 658 days?

Female:Till the next elections.There are 658 days to the next national election. The reason I'm asking about this at

this point is I want you now to think about as you look at media, what they cover over the next 658 days, and the way they cover it. There are many, many issues that could be covered. How can we possibly at this point, 658 days out, be thinking about the relative merits of Joe Biden versus Julian Castro versus Elizabeth Warren? Yet, if you look at the news hole on NBC, MSNBC, CNN the horse race is already well underway.

Now, that means of course that there are opportunity costs. The more that the horse race is covered, the less actual issues and policies will be covered, not to mention stories outside of the endless election cycle. Again, think about, as we proceed through the course and as we proceed over the next interminable number of months to the election, how much time and energy is devoted, and not to the issues that the candidates are raising, but simply to their relative strengths and weaknesses vis-à-vis their electability: the personalities, the horse race, not the issues and so forth. Just think about that. Now you can use this and stump your friends, but remember to change it every day by one day.

I'm coming to the very end. Up to this point, I've been talking about mass media, and mostly in the US context. Now I want to turn to the internet and social media. They have tremendous democratizing potential. They also raise very serious issues about privacy and surveillance, as many of you know. This has been in the headlines. These kinds of media impose censorship of a different kind. So much information that truth and credibility are very difficult to determine. How do we know what we see on the internet is real? Where's the validation? Where's the corroboration?

These social media are subject to increasingly stringent gatekeeping by internet service providers. And this raises the very serious issue of net neutrality. Right now, things are relatively unimpeded. You can access any website and download information. What ISPs would like to do is be an intermediary between you and that content. They will make determinations on speed and accessibility, again based on profit maximization for themselves, since many of the companies who are involved in this are also content providers. They want to charge differential rates for different sites and different content and so forth. That's a very different view of how the internet would operate than the way it operates currently.

Now we're back to the starting point regarding filters that we use to make sense of the world. Because we take certain things about the world for granted when we encounter new data, we accept it or reject it based in large part on whether it corresponds with or contradicts what we think we already know. This is what I had said earlier. This is being increasingly reinforced by the so-called bubble or silo effect in which computer algorithms channel our online behavior so that we rarely encounter views with which we disagree.

Unless we train ourselves to be open-minded and skeptical, which is actually what critical thinking and learning are all about, we continue to accept the status quo even when we are disadvantaged by it. We are also diminished in our capacity to imagine alternatives to the taken-forgranted status quo, and we come to accept its inevitability.

Being open to new views is a very difficult and destabilizing proposition, since we have a stake, a very potent stake in thinking we know how the world operates. That practical consciousness that I described at the beginning is extremely useful for us. We have to have it. So we abandon it very, very reluctantly, and we abandon it in large measure depending on what's at stake. But it's necessary to break down the taken-for-granted common senses that are not in our interest, and that's partly what this course is about. We're going to think about what is the prevailing common sense in the next chapter and then begin to think about what are the consequences of accepting that as inevitable.

Chomsky Lecture, January 17, 2019

The main topic that we're discussing this week is Gramsci's concept of hegemonic common sense, and how it plays out in practice. The assigned reading for today was chosen in part because it provides many striking illustrations of the effective imposition of hegemonic common sense. But also, in part, because it quotes an early and perceptive commentary on this concept, in the mid-eighteenth century, by Scottish philosopher David Hume, one of the great figures of the Enlightenment and a founder of classical liberalism. The quote is from a study of his called "Of the First Principles of Government"—a very important work on democratic theory. In the background is the first modern democratic revolution, in England in the preceding century.

In the opening paragraph, Hume gives a brief exposition of something like the Gramscian concept. Hume writes that

he found nothing more surprising “than to see the easiness with which the many are governed by the few; and to observe the implicit submission with which men resign their own sentiments and passions to those of their rulers. When we enquire by what means this wonder is brought about, we shall find, that as Force is always on the side of the governed, the governors have nothing to support them but opinion. ’Tis therefore, on opinion only that government is founded; and this maxim extends to the most despotic and most military governments, as well as to the most free and most popular.”

Words worth pondering.

The maxim applies with far more force to governments that are free and popular—governments like ours—than to despotic and military governments. These can freely resort to violence, which often suffices, whatever public opinion may be—at least as long as those who exercise the violence, the security forces, remain loyal.

I discuss Hume’s essay in my book Deterring Democracy. The book opens with Hume’s remarks on consent and goes on to discuss the exercise of violence in despotic and military governments. For quite substantial reasons to which I’ll return, it concentrates on the US-supported military dictatorships in Central America in the 1980s, which carried out a brutal war against their populations. Hundreds of thousands were killed; huge numbers hideously tortured and mutilated. The countries were ruined. The trauma persists.

The book was published thirty years ago, so the examples might seem no longer pertinent. But that’s a mistake. In fact, they’re quite relevant today. They provide a crucial background for front-page news as Trump demands a “beautiful wall” to protect us from the invasion of rapists, murders, Islamic terrorists, and the like. The reality of the invasion is very vivid in our immediate experience here in Tucson, not far from the harsh desert where miserable people fleeing from our destruction of their countries are dying in the searing heat—and sometimes being given some succor by the heroic activists of No More Deaths. All happening right here. Many are fleeing from the horrors of the 1980s and the brutal legacy that they left, others from more recent US crimes to which we’ll return.

As many of you know, there’s an ongoing trial of volunteers from No More Deaths at the federal court in Tucson—in one case, a felony charge that could bring twenty years in prison. The trials are for such crimes as leaving food and water in the desert for desperate people who are fleeing the results of our crimes.*

In the past, No More Deaths had a tacit agreement with the border patrols, which allowed them to carry out their humanitarian work with a certain degree of impunity, but that’s changed. Enforcement has sharply increased under the Trump administration’s hardline immigration stance. Hence the trials, and also a lot of sadistic acts, like border patrols destroying food and water so that people will die of thirst and starve when they wander in the desert. Sometimes helicopters hover over groups of refugees and scatter them into the desert so that they’ll get lost and be more likely to die in agony and join the many corpses that are constantly being found.

We cannot emphasize too often that these rapists, criminals, and Islamic terrorists are fleeing from the wreckage of US crimes in Central America, some of which are discussed in today’s reading. Now, these days, that reading should probably have trigger warnings. For example, Father Santiago’s vivid description of the hideous scene he witnessed with his own eyes, just an instance of what was happening throughout the region (Chomsky 1991).

In the last year or two, the flight of refugees is mostly from Honduras. There’s a caravan being formed right now in Honduras. You’ve probably read about it. There’s a reason why the refugee flow is now coming from Honduras. In 2009, a mildly reformist government came into office in Honduras, breaking with a brutal history of terror and repression. The president, Mel Zelaya, proposed some measures to overcome the horrors of the traditional Honduran system, in which the US had been directly involved, particularly during Reagan’s wars in the eighties, when Honduras was turned into a base for US-run terrorist operations in the region.

Zelaya’s efforts didn’t last long. He was thrown out by a military coup, which was condemned throughout the hemisphere, throughout the world. With an exception. The Obama-Clinton administration refused to call it a military coup because if they had, US law would have required that they stop sending arms to the military junta that had restored a brutal dictatorship. Washington would not agree to that, so it endorsed the coup regime under the ludicrous pretense that it was restoring democracy.

The military dictatorship ran what they called “an election,” which was mostly ridiculed and dismissed. Again, with

one notable exception. The Obama-Clinton administration praised it as an encouraging step toward democracy, so we could continue to support this promising new regime as it instituted a reign of terror.

Honduras, which was always dangerous enough, became maybe the homicide capital of the world. There were huge atrocities, and soon people were fleeing in desperation. Honduras was the source of the plurality of the refugees fleeing from Central America in the last few years, and that's where the caravans are starting from. The US role in the flight of refugees is not secret. It's all public. You can easily find out about it—except on the front pages of newspapers, where it should be highlighted.

Throughout the hideous decade of the 1980s, there was never any secret about what was happening. It was reported extensively by church sources and all the major human rights and aid groups, by solidarity organizations, and by the thousands of Americans who flocked to Central America to help the victims—something entirely new in the gruesome history of imperialism, and a tribute to important strains of American society and culture. Like No More Deaths today, right here in Tucson.

The earlier role of the US in Central America, Latin America altogether, is terrible enough. We'll come back to that later. But the crimes escalated sharply under Reagan in the 1980s. The terrible decade opened with the assassination of Archbishop Oscar Romero, recently designated as a saint. He was known as the "voice for the voiceless." He was a simple man, of remarkable integrity and courage, who understood well that the course he was following would probably lead to martyrdom. He was assassinated while reading mass, by close US allies, as was known at once and reported by US ambassador to El Salvador Robert White—who was withdrawn, because he was considered a little too open about what was happening. The voice for the voiceless was stilled by the assassins shortly after sending a letter to President Carter urging him to withhold military aid from the governing junta, which, he warned, will use it to "sharpen injustice and repression against the people's organizations [struggling] for respect for their most basic human rights." Exactly as happened.

Right after the assassination, the Reagan administration came into office, and sharply escalated the war. Archbishop Romero's successor, Bishop Arturo Rivera y Damas, described the US-backed crimes as "a war of extermination and genocide against a defenseless civilian population." That was El Salvador. They were sort of lucky. It was still worse in Guatemala in those years.

In both countries, the crimes go back much earlier. In Guatemala they intensified after the overthrow of a popular democratic government by a CIA coup in 1954. That initiated decades of state terror and repression, raised to new horrors under Reagan. What was taking place in Guatemala in the eighties was so horrendous that Congress intervened and imposed constraints on the US supply of weapons to the mass murderers who were running the country. Undeterred, Reagan created an international terror network to replace direct US participation in the slaughter.

There are others who create international terrorist networks, highly publicized and bitterly condemned for their crimes. They hire killers, like the infamous Carlos the Jackal. The US is a much bigger player, so we hire terrorist states, not just individual killers. They're much more effective. The primary component of Reagan's terror network was the Argentine neo-Nazi regime that was the worst of all the Latin American monsters of those years. The competition for that honor is pretty fierce, but they were the winners.

They were also the favorite of Henry Kissinger, Ronald Reagan, and their associates. So it's natural that they should be picked to direct the slaughter and torture in Guatemala when Washington had to pull out directly. But that didn't last long; the Argentine military dictatorship was overthrown. A democratic regime was slowly introduced, so Argentine neo-Nazi killers were no longer available for service in Guatemala. Washington's international terror network had to turn to others: Taiwanese mercenaries, but primarily, Israel, which provided direct support and weapons for horrifying crimes, using its considerable expertise in repression and violence. To this day, the Guatemalan military, which continues its rampages, is supplied with Israeli weapons, standard issue for their forces.

In the early eighties, the atrocities amounted to virtual genocide in the Mayan highlands of Guatemala under a killer later sentenced for genocide. While it was underway, he was lauded by Reagan as a fine man, "totally dedicated to democracy" and given a "bum rap" by human rights organizations. People are still fleeing from that bitter legacy.

The decade of the eighties began with the assassination of the archbishop and closed in 1989, symbolically, with the

assassination of six leading Latin American intellectuals, Jesuit priests, in their rooms at the Jesuit university of San Salvador. The assassins also murdered their housekeeper and her daughter to make sure there would be no witnesses. This was right at the time of the fall of the Berlin Wall and the celebration of the liberation of Soviet satellites. The murderers were from a US-trained brigade, the Atlacatl Brigade, known as El Salvador's finest, which had already compiled a horrible record of murders and atrocities.

We can find out more about this from the foreign press. Several years ago (November 21, 2009), a major Spanish journal, El Mundo, published facsimiles of official documents showing that the assassination was undertaken on the direct orders of the Salvadoran High Command, which was, of course, always in close contact with the US Embassy. As far as I can determine, the media here never published that crucial information, but you can find it. I published it, the only reference here to my knowledge. The Free Press has other priorities.

A good bit has been learned about the wars in El Salvador and Guatemala since Deterring Democracy was published thirty years ago. As the wars wound down, Truth Commissions were established in both countries. Their research revealed that the overwhelming majority of the crimes were carried out by the security forces that were armed, trained, directed by the Reagan administration. I'll come back to all of that and its backgrounds, particularly since the Kennedy years. This is bipartisan. It's highly instructive.

There has never been a Truth Commission here. That's unthinkable, a violation of common sense.

Truth Commissions often have a considerable impact, in Argentina, to take one case. So does their absence. The most important country in Latin America, Brazil, did not have one. They had a brutal military dictatorship, but there was no reckoning. Actually, the Catholic Church did publish an inquiry, but there was no real Truth Commission. The effects are in the headlines right now. In Brazil, something similar to military dictatorship is taking shape. It's tolerated, even supported, in part because people don't even remember the military dictatorship and its many crimes. Younger people may not even know about it. The new Bolsonaro administration even denies that there was a military dictatorship. Rather, the military coup and the brutal National Security State it imposed were a rescue operation, saving the country from a (mythical) communist plot to destroy Brazilian democracy.

Bolsonaro himself—a Trump favorite, not surprisingly—does criticize the military dictatorship. It was too soft. It should have killed thirty thousand people, as in neighboring Argentina. This softness in Brazil goes far back. He also criticizes the nineteenth-century Brazilian military, which did not duplicate what its counterpart was doing in the US, virtually exterminating the indigenous population. Therefore, Brazil is stuck with these Indians who, Bolsonaro has made clear, must be driven from their reservations in the Amazon—for their own good—while the great tropical forest is handed over to agribusiness and mining, and foreign investors, to exploit and destroy. Incidentally, a serious contribution to the dire threat of global environmental catastrophe.

Going back to the failure to establish a Truth Commission in Brazil, and the consequences of failure to remember even the very recent past, we might recall a comment of Gore Vidal's, who once described the United States as the "United States of Amnesia." It's a useful trait. But Vidal was unfair. It's not only the United States. It's every other great power as well. Britain, for example, is just barely beginning today to face some of the horrible atrocities carried out under British rule since the seventeenth century. Better than most. It is useful to have a state of amnesia. It contributes to imposing the required hegemonic common sense.

Let's go back to David Hume. He was concerned primarily with the more free and popular governments. That's the most interesting case. Especially his own country, Britain, which was unusually free and popular by the standards of the day. But Hume was surely aware of the limits of that freedom. They were discussed quite eloquently by his close friend, Adam Smith, who along with Hume was a leading Enlightenment figure and a founder of classical liberalism.

Smith, of course, is greatly revered as the founder of modern economics. But he also had a good deal to say about political systems in his classic work The Wealth of Nations, published in 1776, a date that means something here, too. Smith writes that in England, the "merchants and manufacturers [are the] principal architects" of government policy, which they design to ensure that their own interests "are most peculiarly attended to," however "grievous" the effect on others, including the people of England, but especially those who suffer under "the savage injustice of the Europeans" in their colonies.

British India was the main target of his charges. But more generally, he wrote, “the masters of mankind,” the merchants and manufacturers of England, pursue their “vile maxim: all for ourselves and nothing for anyone else.”

Smith’s vile maxim should be familiar to us. It has considerable resonance today. We’ll look into its theoretical background next week. But as you should be aware, the vile maxim has become a leading idea of what’s called “libertarianism” in the United States. It was popularized by Ayn Rand. Greed is great, all for ourselves, nothing for anyone else. She was the guru of prominent figures, among them Alan Greenspan, the much-admired chair of the Federal Reserve for many years. Another acolyte is Paul Ryan, former Speaker of the House, the main intellectual architect of the domestic programs of the Trump administration—which are, in fact, motivated by the vile maxim. We’ll come back to some of them.

One of the leading intellectuals of the libertarian movement, Nobel laureate in economics James Buchanan, outlined the guiding principle lucidly. In his major work Limits of Liberty, he pointed out that the ideal society should accord with fundamental human nature, which makes good sense. And then went on, reasonably, to ask the next question: What is fundamental human nature? He had a very simple answer:

“In a strictly personalized sense, any person’s ideal situation is one that allows him full freedom of action and inhibits the behavior of others so as to force adherence to his own desires. That is to say, each person seeks mastery over a world of slaves.”

That’s libertarianism, the ultimate in liberty. And it’s your fondest dream, in case you hadn’t noticed, fundamental human nature. That’s the vile maxim in modern terms. Actually, it’s a thought that Adam Smith would have regarded as pathological, as would David Hume or John Stuart Mill or Thomas Paine or Abraham Lincoln or anyone at all close to the classical liberal tradition.

It’s an interesting indication of things that have been happening here—of how remote classical liberalism is from the moral basis of what’s called libertarianism in the United States. Something else to think about.

Well, let’s go back to the main theme. Hume’s insight, developed by Gramsci, explains why elites are so dedicated to indoctrination and thought control. You have to make sure to “engineer consent” as Edward Bernays explained in work that Marv talked about in our last meeting (Bernays 1947). They’re pretty frank about it, which is useful, because then we can find out what they have in mind. I’ll keep to the left-liberal end of the spectrum, which is in many ways the most revealing because it sets the limits on what’s admissible. It says you can go this far, not a millimeter farther. Therefore, it’s always quite interesting to look at the liberal extreme of opinion. So let’s do so.

Bernays is an important figure, a founder of the huge public relations industry, which spends hundreds of millions of dollars a year to engineer consent. Bernays was a Wilson-Roosevelt-Kennedy liberal. As Marv mentioned, one of his first great successes, which propelled him to fame and fortune, was getting women to smoke. The lethal effects of that were well known but effectively suppressed for a long time. We’ll come back to that.

Another notable achievement of Bernays’s liberal record was in the early 1950s when he was employed by the United Fruit Company, which virtually owned Guatemala, in fact much of Central America. In the early ’50s they were threatened by a new reformist democracy in Guatemala, which overthrew the dictatorship and intended to take unused lands owned by the fruit company and distribute them to poor peasants, along with other reforms.

Bernays was hired to do something about that. He developed a very successful propaganda campaign to engineer consent among the American public for a military coup, the 1953 military coup, which ended these heresies and protected the power of the Fruit Company under the new military dictatorship. The theme of his campaign was, of course, a Soviet base not far from our borders, a communist threat, which was derisory, but worked. The military dictatorship was firmly established. That led to decades of terror and destruction, ending any threat of democracy and social reform, escalating in the Reagan years as I mentioned. And still a major factor in the flood of refugees fleeing here to the border.

Edward Bernays is actually a liberal hero. That’s particularly true in Cambridge, Massachusetts, where I spent most of my life. The heartland of American liberalism. He’s honored because one of his achievements was to carry out a pro bono propaganda campaign to stop a real atrocity that was going to happen in Cambridge. There’s a highway that goes by the river, Memorial Drive. Valeria and I lived there for a while. It has lovely old sycamore trees along

the Drive. A very pleasant place, we can testify to that. The city was thinking of widening the highway and cutting down the sycamores. Bernays intervened and organized a campaign that got the city to back off. So the sycamores are still there. And that apparently effaces the rest of the record, as far as liberal opinion is concerned.

Bernays explained his principles in 1947, in the Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science.

He informed the world of science that

leaders, with the aid of technicians in the field who have specialized in utilizing the channels of communication, have been able to accomplish purposefully and scientifically what we have termed 'the engineering of consent.' This phrase quite simply means the use of an engineering approach—that is, action based on thorough knowledge of the situation and on the application of scientific principles and tried practices to the task of getting people to support ideas and programs…. The engineering of consent is the very essence of the democratic process, the freedom to persuade and suggest…. A leader frequently cannot wait for the people to arrive at even general understanding … democratic leaders must play their part in … engineering consent to socially constructive goals and values…. The responsible leader, to accomplish social objectives, must therefore be constantly aware of the possibilities of subversion. He must apply his energies to mastering the operational know-how of consent engineering, and to out-maneuvering his opponents in the public interest (Bernays, 1947).

Bernays's conception was given scientific endorsement in 1971 by B. F. Skinner, the leading figure in the behaviorist movement that became highly influential in the post–World War II period. As Skinner put it in his book Beyond Freedom and Dignity, keeping to careful scientific concepts, "Ethical control may survive in small groups, but the control of the population as a whole must be delegated to specialists—to police, priests, owners, teachers, therapists, and so on, with their specialized reinforcers and their codified contingencies." The "responsible leaders," dedicated to the public interest.

Since democratic leaders can't wait for the people to arrive at even general understanding and have to engineer consent to socially constructive goals and values, some obvious questions arise. Who makes the decisions about these goals and values? What factors enter into the decisions of "democratic leaders"? How is their "responsibility" and dedication to the public interest established? Bernays avoids the questions, but when we look into them we find that very much as in Adam Smith's day, the decision makers are primarily the "masters of mankind," who have far higher priorities than "the public interest," much as Smith described. They are the ones with the power to exercise the freedom to persuade and suggest, the essence of the democratic process—power that is not exactly equally distributed. And they are the ones who judge what is socially constructive. These days, it's not just Smith's merchants and manufacturers. Nowadays, it's huge conglomerates, multinational corporations, and financial institutions and other centers of economic power.

It's important to bear in mind how deeply rooted these ideas are among the intellectual classes, across the spectrum. I'll still keep to the liberal extreme of the spectrum. One important example is perhaps the most prominent and respected public intellectual of the twentieth century, Walter Lippmann, also a Wilson-Roosevelt-Kennedy liberal, like Bernays. Wilson, like Bernays, had been a member of the Creel Commission, which Marv mentioned in our last session, the commission that Woodrow Wilson set up to try to convince the American population to join the First World War. Wilson was elected in 1916 on the slogan "Peace without victory." But he quickly changed that to "Victory without peace."

There was then a problem of getting a pacifist population to become raving anti-German hysterics. It was achieved. So, for example, the Boston Symphony Orchestra couldn't play Beethoven, and similar things were happening around the country. It was achieved very quickly by a grand propaganda campaign, and it greatly impressed the people who were involved, including Lippmann and Bernays. As Lippmann wrote afterward, this achievement shows that what he called "manufacture of consent," Bernays's engineering of consent, is a "new art" in the practice of democracy.

Lippmann was a major figure in many domains, including political theory. The main collection of his political essays is called "political philosophy for liberal democracy." In these essays he explains that the "public must be put in its place" so that "the intelligent minorities" may live free of "the trampling and roar of the bewildered herd," the public. Members of the bewildered herd are supposed to be "spectators of action," not "participants." They do have a function, however. Their function is to show up periodically to push a button to vote for a selected member of the

leadership class. Then they are to go away and leave us alone. That's progressive democratic theory.

I won't talk about the harsher versions.

Another influential liberal figure, Harold Lasswell, one of the main founders of modern political science, also had something to say about these matters. In the Encyclopedia of the Social Sciences, he explained that we should not be deluded by "democratic dogmatisms about men being the best judges of their own interests." They're not. We are.

Continuing, "The modern propagandist, like the modern psychologist, recognizes that men are often poor judges of their own interests, flitting from one alternative to the next without solid reason or clinging timorously to the fragments of some mossy rock of ages…. The older democratic doctrines allowed the nominal leader to escape his task of leadership by some procedural rigmarole: a 'general will' was supposed to be 'out there,' and the leader's duty was to watch carefully for it to manifest itself through the machinery of balloting and legislative discussion." But we must put such nonsense behind us in the modern age of scientific psychology and political science. "With respect to those adjustments which do require mass action the task of the propagandist is that of inventing goal symbols which serve the double function of facilitating adoption and adaptation. The symbols must induce acceptance spontaneously and elicit those changes in conduct necessary to bring about permanent adaptation. The propagandist as one who creates symbols which are not only popular but which bring about positive realignments of behavior is no phrasemonger but a promoter of overt acts."

Note the free use of the term "propagandist," as with Bernays. This was in the '30s. In those days, the term did not have the negative connotations it has since assumed (in English; other languages still use the term neutrally).

Putting aside the pseudo-scientific gobbledygook, we're back to the same principles. In a democratic society, we, the intelligent minority, have the duty of directing the "ignorant and stupid" masses to what we decide are proper goals, using whatever deception is required. All for their own good.

These points were elaborated by Reinhold Niebuhr, a highly respected liberal political analyst and theologian, often described as "the theologian of the (liberal) establishment." He explained that because of "the stupidity of the average man," enlightened leaders have to construct "necessary illusions" and "emotionally potent simplifications" to ensure that the best interests of the general public are served by the "responsible intellectuals." From a different perspective, the responsible intellectuals are what Gramsci called "experts in legitimation," whose task is to somehow legitimate what's happening.

Henry Kissinger, who was a master in the art, explained it a little differently. Paraphrasing one of his insights, the "expert" is someone who can "articulate the consensus of the powerful," and thus, by implication, can manage their affairs for them.

Not everyone qualifies as an expert or responsible intellectual. There are also "the wild men in the wings"—the phrase used in a major article in the major establishment journal Foreign Affairs in 1968 by Kennedy–Johnson national security advisor McGeorge Bundy, former Harvard dean, later head of the Ford Foundation. He was referring to people who are so remote from reality that they don't just question the government's tactics but even raise questions about motives. Specifically, he had in mind critics of the Indochina wars that he had been conducting. Plainly total insanity. Insanity that is incidentally well documented in the Pentagon Papers released by Dan Ellsberg shortly after Bundy wrote. It contains ample material on motives, sometimes quite explicit and not too attractive, to put it mildly. And not just confirming but substantially extending the lunacy of the wild men.

Well, every society has its wild men in the wings. In the old Soviet Union, the wild men in the wings, from the point of view of the rulers, were the dissidents. They were harshly treated in the Soviet Union but of course greatly honored here. We all know their names. When we come back home, the values are reversed. The dissidents are wild men, condemned or more often simply ignored. Who, for example, even knows the names of the leading Latin American intellectuals assassinated in 1989 by the elite forces that we armed and trained? Anybody here know their names? Or even that it happened?

There's a long list of others—often suffering the "martyrdom, which, in an infinite variety of shapes, awaits those who have the heart and will and conscience to fight a battle with the world," to quote Nathaniel Hawthorne's House of the Seven Gables.

We don't have time to go through the history, which is a revealing one. But in brief, the pattern goes way back to the earliest recorded history. So go back to classical Greece and ask who had to drink the hemlock and commit suicide. It was the guy who was corrupting the youth of Athens by asking too many questions, Socrates. Roughly at the same time, if you look at the biblical record, there were people who are called prophets, a misleading translation of an obscure Hebrew word. They were what we might call dissidents. They were criticizing the evil acts of the kings, giving geopolitical analysis, warning of what was going to happen as a result of these terrible policies, calling for mercy for widows and orphans, clearly wild men in the wings. They were not welcomed. They were treated harshly —imprisoned, driven into the desert, condemned as haters of Israel, in this case, the prophet Elijah. That's the origin of the phrase "Jewish self-hatred" used today to condemn Jewish critics of Israeli policy by prominent Israeli political figures like Abba Eban and, commonly, by defenders of these policies here.

Centuries later, the prophets were honored. But not at the time. At the time, the people who were honored were the flatterers at the Court, those who were later called false prophets. The experts in legitimation. And so it goes right through history. An interesting story.

Take Gramsci. When he was condemned to prison by the Mussolini dictatorship, the prosecutor said that we must stop this brain from functioning for twenty years. Now that was fascism. We are a little harsher. Romero and the Jesuit intellectuals—and a long list of other religious martyrs—simply had their brains blown out and were silenced forever, not just for twenty years.

And you have to make sure that they're unknown forever. It's very interesting to see how this works in detail. So let's go back to Boston, the most liberal city in the country. In 1990, shortly after the assassination of the Jesuit intellectuals, the American Psychological Association had its conference in Boston. There was a series of panels. I was participating in one, which was devoted to the work of one of the murdered Jesuit intellectuals, a prominent social psychologist. The conference was covered by the Boston Globe, at the time I think the most liberal newspaper in the country, which had excellent Latin America coverage, probably the best in the country.

The Globe covered the conference, but not this section. Instead the journal preferred a paper on male facial expressions that are attractive to women. That was much more important. You have to have your priorities straight. It's necessary to cultivate the right kind of intellectuals.

I don't mean to blame the reporter, who had probably never heard of the massacre of the Jesuit intellectuals a few months earlier.

Well, I'll leave to your imagination what the reaction would be if things like this were going on in the old Soviet Union under the Kremlin dictatorship.

The essential point was made by the acute and often bitter critic H. L. Mencken, referring to an Irish American writer who was in and out of jail on trivial charges: "If [he] were a Russian, read in translation, all the professors would be hymning him."

All too accurate.

Actually, George Orwell had some interesting things to say about this. You've all read Animal Farm in school, I'm sure. But it's pretty unlikely that you've read Orwell's preface to Animal Farm, which was not published. It was discovered many years later in his collected papers. It sometimes appears in contemporary editions, but was probably missing from the book you read.

You'll recall that Animal Farm is a satirical critique of Bolshevik Russia, the totalitarian enemy. But the preface, directed to the people of free England, says that they shouldn't feel too self-righteous about it. England too has literary censorship, of a kind appropriate to free societies in thrall to hegemonic common sense. "The sinister fact about literary censorship in England," Orwell wrote, "is that it is largely voluntary. Unpopular ideas can be silenced, and inconvenient facts kept dark, without any need for any official ban." He did not explore the reasons in any depth, merely noting the control of the press by "wealthy men who have every motive to be dishonest on certain important topics," reinforced by the "general tacit agreement that 'it wouldn't do' to mention that particular fact." As a result, "Anyone who challenges the prevailing orthodoxy finds himself silenced with surprising effectiveness." Relegated to the category of wild men in the wings, if noticed at all.

An essential mechanism of censorship, in Orwell's view, is a good education. If you've gone to the best schools, you have instilled into you the understanding that there are certain things it wouldn't do to say, or, we may add, even to think. It all becomes part of your being. And if you're a good student and have properly absorbed the lessons, you can become a responsible intellectual.

That's the unpublished preface to Animal Farm. But what are the kinds of things it wouldn't do to say? Or to think? I've just given a number of examples. US crimes in Latin America, for example, and also the very interesting comparison of Latin America, US domains, with Russian domains in Eastern Europe. There are some quotes in the reading.

Latin American intellectuals recognized that Eastern Europeans are "in a way, luckier than Central Americans," one wrote—the publisher of a journal that was blown up by US-backed state terrorists, arousing no interest in the United States. "While the Moscow-imposed government in Prague would degrade and humiliate reformers," he continued, "the Washington-made government in Guatemala would kill them. It still does, in a virtual genocide that has taken more than 150,000 victims … [in what Amnesty International calls] a 'government program of political murder.' … One is tempted to believe that some people in the White House worship Aztec gods … with the offering of Central American blood." The White House installed and supported forces in Central America that "can easily compete against Nicolae Ceausescu's Securitate for the World Cruelty Prize," referring to the most bloodthirsty of the East European dictators (and, incidentally, a US favorite because he was somewhat independent of the Kremlin).

That happens to be a rather typical voice of victims. But they are not alone. It's also the assessment of Western scholarship. The standard scholarly source on postwar political history is the multivolume Cambridge History of the Cold War. The chapter on Latin America was written by John Coatsworth, a respected Latin American expert, former Dean of Columbia University's School of International and Public Affairs. He writes that from 1960—remember the date—from 1960 to "the Soviet collapse in 1990, the numbers of political prisoners, torture victims, and executions of nonviolent political dissenters in Latin America vastly exceeded those in the Soviet Union and East European satellites."

Again, you might ask yourselves how many of the Eastern Europeans you've heard of? And how many of the Latin Americans? An interesting study, never undertaken as far as I know. I mentioned that you should think about 1960. I'll come back to the reasons, if not today, later.

Well, let's turn to some further examples of what it wouldn't do to say today. So take the New York Times, a couple of days ago, a front-page story. It's about how National Security Advisor John Bolton asked the Pentagon to draw up plans for an attack on Iran. Bolton is already on record in an article in the New York Times calling for immediate bombardment of Iran. That's one story.

Another story is about the gentleman recently appointed attorney general, William Barr, who holds that the president has "unfettered power to start a major land war on his own, not only without Congressional permission but even if Congress voted against it" (Savage 2019).

The unsophisticated might think that Barr's pronouncement violates Article I of the Constitution, which vests the power to declare war in the Congress—a crucial break from common practice of the day that assigned this role to the monarch. This revolutionary innovation was motivated by the opposition of the Founders to unconstrained centralized power and their concern that such serious decisions should be based on the considered judgment of Congress. But Barr is too good a lawyer to violate the Constitution so blatantly. He therefore talks about launching a war, not declaring it. He is thus violating the clear intent of the Founders, but not their actual words.

Adopting the role of wild man, let's ask what is missing in these two front-page stories, because it wouldn't do to say.

One of the things that remains unsaid is that there is indeed a document called the US Constitution, which we're supposed to revere. It's precious, particularly among "conservatives" like Barr, who worship it. We can put aside the chicanery of violating Article I, and take a look at Article VI. There we discover that "all treaties made, or which shall be made, under the authority of the United States, shall be the supreme law of the land; and the judges in every state shall be bound thereby."

Presumably the chief executive too (though Barr and Trump might disagree).

So let's take a look at treaties that have been made under the authority of the United States.

The most important since World War II is the UN Charter, established on US initiative, the foundation of modern international law. So let's take a look at that, in particular Article 2(4). Here we discover that "the threat or use of force" is banned in international affairs. Not just the use, but even the threat. There are some exceptions, but they are transparently irrelevant here.

In passing, we should recall that there is a category of professionals, called "international law scholars," who can learnedly explain that words don't mean what we say. But we wild men are simpleminded folk who don't appreciate these subtleties, so let's accept the plain meaning of the text.

Among the things it wouldn't do to say is that the leading figures of the administration are violating the US Constitution, the supreme law of the land. Does anybody care? Apparently not. It seems to be of no concern to responsible intellectuals.

In extenuation, it is only fair to observe that Barr is not entirely breaking new ground. Though his contempt for the Constitution in these remarks is extreme, it is normal for political leaders to violate the Constitution by threatening force. It has been normal for years, for example, for the president and others to say that all options are open against Iran. "All options" means all options, up to nuclear attack.

More generally, all of this is pretty standard. So take the invasion of Iraq, 2003, a textbook example of aggression without credible pretext. It's criticized. By President Obama, for example, who is greatly respected for having criticized it as a strategic blunder. Did we praise Russian generals when they criticized the invasion of Afghanistan as a strategic blunder? Or Nazi war criminals who criticized Hitler's two-front war as a strategic blunder, because they should have knocked out England first? I don't recall any such thing. Is there a difference in this case? If so, what is it—apart from us versus them? Worth thinking about.

Obama's criticism of the Iraq war is as far as you can go. Try to find somebody who said that it wasn't a mere blunder, it was the supreme international crime. That's the judgment of Nuremberg where Nazi war criminals were condemned. Many of them hanged. It described aggression—and again, the Iraq invasion is a textbook example—as "the supreme international crime differing only from other war crimes in that it contains within itself the accumulated evil of the whole": in the case of Iraq, the accumulated evil is a long list, all the way to ISIS and beyond.

The US prosecutor at Nuremberg, Robert Jackson, gave an interesting talk to the Tribunal. He said that we are handing the defendants "a poisoned chalice," and if we sip from it—if we are guilty of similar crimes—we have to suffer the same fate. Otherwise, we should concede that the judicial proceeding is a farce, victor's justice. Well, you can draw your own conclusions. But these are all things that it wouldn't do to say or to think about—under the reign of hegemonic common sense.

Let's take a look at the worst international crime since the Second World War, the US invasion of Vietnam, then all of Indochina, leaving many millions of corpses and three countries in ruins. Sometimes the assault was undertaken with explicit directives reaching to such levels of criminality that they defy words, such as the infamous orders that Kissinger obediently transmitted to the US Air Force calling for "a massive bombing campaign in Cambodia. Anything that flies on anything that moves" (Becker)—a call for genocide that is hard to duplicate in the historical record. Orders that were carried out, providing a major stimulus for the creation of the Khmer Rouge, as revealed by scholarship (Ben Kiernan and others) but hardly penetrates to common sense.

The wars ended in 1975, and of course everyone of any significance had to write a comment about it. There were basically two groups. The hawks said that if we'd fought harder, we could have won. Maybe we were stabbed in the back by antiwar protesters. The second group was the doves. At the extreme critical end in the mainstream, perhaps, was Anthony Lewis of the New York Times. Again, it's always useful to look at the establishment Left, marking the limits of what it is OK to say.

Lewis wrote in New York Times (May 1, 1975) that the war began with "blundering efforts to do good." How do we

know that? Because it's an axiom, a necessary truth. If the United States did it, it was an effort to do good. You don't need any evidence for that. That's hegemonic common sense. Why "blundering efforts"? Because it didn't work.

So the war began with blundering efforts to do good, "but by 1969 it was clear to most of the world—and most Americans—that the intervention had been a disastrous mistake…. The argument [against the war] was that the United States had misunderstood the cultural and political forces at work in Indochina—that it was in a position where it could not impose a solution except at a price too costly to itself."

That's the extreme left criticism expressible in the mainstream.

There was another view expressed at the same time: that the war was "fundamentally wrong and immoral … not a mistake" (Rielly 1987). But that's of course the kind of anti-American hysteria you expect from the wild men in the wings, so it was quite reasonable to deny it expression.

Except that the wild men in the wings in this case were the large majority of the population.

There are regular studies of US public opinion on international affairs. The major monitor of public opinion on such matters is the respected Chicago Council of International Relations. They had polls in 1975, and, of course, among the questions posed were questions about attitudes toward the war in Vietnam. There were various options available. One of the options was that the war was "not a mistake," it was "fundamentally wrong and immoral." That option was selected by 70 percent of the population. The "wings" must be pretty broad to cover all of these wild men. One can sympathize with the contempt of the liberal intellectual elite for "the stupidity of the average man," who doesn't even realize what it wouldn't do to say.

That question continued to be asked in the polls for many years, with about the same result. Roughly two-thirds or more said the war was fundamentally wrong and immoral, not a mistake. You would be hard put to find one comment by left-liberal intellectuals who made it into the mainstream who could express the views of the population.

There is, of course, a lingering question. What did people mean by this?

That question was finally raised by the academic director of the studies, political scientist John Rielly. He wrote that the responses show a "preference to avoid undertaking major burdens in foreign interventions." Possibly. Or possibly they show that the public thought that the war was fundamentally wrong and immoral, not a mistake. It wouldn't have been hard to determine the answer, but apparently the inquiry was never undertaken. Perhaps it was considered superfluous since the right conclusion is so obvious.

All of this raises quite interesting questions about the hold that hegemonic common sense exercises over the responsible men as compared with the stupid and ignorant masses. Quite interesting questions. It wouldn't be too surprising to discover that the experts in legitimation are more deeply indoctrinated than those who are not subjected constantly to streams of propaganda and are not its purveyors. There is some evidence to this effect on a number of issues, but it's never been investigated systematically, as far as I know.

Since I still have a few more minutes, I'd like to say a few words about how the issues we are discussing arose in the first modern democratic revolution in seventeenth-century England, along with the problem of "putting the public in their place"—Lippmann's problem three centuries later. That's the immediate background for Hume's observations on engineering consent.

The mid-seventeenth-century conflict is usually presented as a war between king and Parliament, the latter representing the rising merchant and manufacturing classes. The final "glorious revolution" established the primacy of Parliament. And also registered victories for the rising bourgeoisie. One not inconsiderable achievement was to break the royal monopoly on the highly lucrative slave trade. The merchants were able to gain a large share of this enterprise, a substantial part of the basis for British prosperity.

But there also were wild men in the wings—much of the general public. They were not silent. Their pamphlets and speakers favored universal education, guaranteed health care, and democratization of the law. They developed a kind

of liberation theology, which, as one critic ominously observed, preached “seditious doctrine to the people” and aimed “to raise the rascal multitude … against all men of best quality in the kingdom, to draw them into associations and combinations with one another … against all lords, gentry, ministers, lawyers, rich and peaceable men.” Particularly frightening were the itinerant workers and preachers calling for freedom and democracy, the agitators stirring up the rascal multitude, and the authors and printers distributing pamphlets questioning authority and its mysteries. Elite opinion warned that the radical democrats had “cast all the mysteries and secrets of government … before the vulgar (like pearls before swine),” and have “made the people thereby so curious and so arrogant that they will never find humility enough to submit to a civil rule.” It is dangerous, another commentator ominously observed, to “have a people know their own strength”—to learn that power is “in the hands of the governed,” in Hume’s words.

The rabble did not want to be ruled by king or Parliament, but “by countrymen like ourselves, that know our wants.” Their pamphlets explained further that “it will never be a good world while knights and gentlemen make us laws, that are chosen for fear and do but oppress us, and do not know the people’s sores.”

These ideas naturally appalled the men of best quality. They were willing to grant the people rights, but within limits. After the democrats had been defeated, John Locke commented that “day-labourers and tradesmen, the spinsters and dairymaids” must be told what to believe; “the greatest part cannot know and therefore they must believe.”

The second modern democratic revolution, the American Revolution, launched a century later, exposed somewhat similar conflicts, which entered crucially into the framing of the Constitution. It’s a very important topic, with many crucial lessons and consequences. Too late to talk about it now. We’ll return to it.

* As an important update, as of November of 2019, one member of the group, Dr. Scott Warren, was acquitted of the only felony charges levied against No More Deaths volunteers.Chapter 2

THE CURRENT COMMON SENSE: CAPITALIST REALISM

Waterstone Lecture, January 22, 2019

Welcome to the second week of What Is Politics? Tonight, I have a small task. I’m going to summarize Marx’s Capital, Volume 1, which will help refresh your memory of your K–12 Marxism classes, just in case you’ve forgotten a few things. Remember, this is only Volume 1 of three volumes of Capital, and I’ll try to get through all those, plus a few of Marx’s other works. Tonight’s topic: capital and capitalist realism, which is the title of Mark Fisher’s book Capitalist Realism. This phrase, which I’ve used before, I think captures in an interesting way this notion of capitalist realism, which is Fisher’s term for a capitalist common sense. That is, “it’s now easier to imagine the end of the world than to imagine the end of capitalism.”

This is appropriate, I think, the day after MLK Day, as Martin Luther King Jr. said, “I’m convinced that if we are to get on the right side of the world revolution, the nation must undergo a radical revolution of values. We must rapidly begin to shift from a thing-oriented society to a person-oriented society…. When machines and computers, profit models and property rights are considered more important than people, the giant triplets of racism, materialism, and militarism are incapable of being conquered.” The context in which Martin Luther King made this comment was a pivotal point in his own career. This is his “Beyond Vietnam” speech, after which virtually all of his former allies turned against him. He was isolated after giving this speech. The beginning of the speech basically is, one cannot remain silent. He says this in the title of this talk, “A Time to Break Silence,” which he did.

This is when he made a very public transition from simply, not simply, but from exclusively working on civil rights, to working on issues of poverty and societal change. Over the next several weeks, we are going to take a look at the relationship between a political economic system, that is late-stage industrial capitalism, and some of its weightiest consequences. The relationship between capitalism as a political economic system, and militarism, between capitalism and environmental catastrophe, and between capitalism and the effects produced from its globalized financialized form. But before we examine those connections, we have to have a clear understanding of what capitalism is (and must be) as a way to organize the political economy of society.

In the presentation that I’m going to give this evening, I’m talking about capitalism in a kind of idealized sense, in

the best sense in which it presents itself. This is not necessarily the form that it takes in everyday life. This approach is meant to give you a sense of the essential features of a capitalist system. Features without which it is not capitalism, and the reasons why it is then tied to these other consequences, in fundamental and rather necessary ways. That's the purpose of the conversation this evening.

Let's begin to think about how the system works. I want to start with the notion of production, which is the most basic human interaction with nature. It combines human labor, sometimes historically using animal labor and tools, combines that labor with elements of nature to satisfy human needs and wants, which themselves are quite variable categories, of course. What, beyond very basic physiological requirements, defines needs, and what marks the point when we move from needs into wants. This is a very slippery category, one that is quite explicitly exploited by the advertising and marketing fields, whose entire job is to convert wants into needs.

Resources derive from the neutral stuff of nature. In this case, "neutral" simply refers to unappraised. That is, the neutral stuff of nature only becomes a resource when it's recognized by society, or by individuals, or by small groups as being useful. This recognition depends on the state of knowledge, the state of capability, and whether the materials are accessible. This is clearly then changeable over time, and from place to place, and from culture to culture. Usability and accessibility depend on the state of technology, economic conditions, and so forth.

Something that is a resource at one place or time may not be a resource at another place or time, and vice versa. Something that is not recognized as a resource in one moment may become recognizable and accessible as a resource under other circumstances. The idea of resources are not that they exist, but that they become. The original notion of production, historically, anthropologically, was for use only. That is, the interaction between people and the physical world produced goods that were useful. Most production was by families or small groups.

The means of production, that is the raw materials, and tools, and labor, are at this point held in the same hands. The people who are doing the producing are the people who control both the means of production, and labor. Eventually over time, there is a division of labor, and some specialization. This leads to a surplus, in some circumstances, of particular goods. That is, some production goes beyond immediate needs. So that not everything that's produced is immediately consumed. This is connected to this idea of specialization and division of labor.

This allows then for the trade of that surplus. We are moving from this individuated production for immediate consumption needs, to a system in which there is some surplus, and this fosters the ability to engage in trade. The first kind of trade is barter, that is, one useful thing for another. Usually occurs under face-to-face circumstances, no separation in time and space. The people who are engaged in barter know each other, they interact, this is one commodity or one good for another: C C.

I put that notation there because I'm going to use it again in a couple of minutes. The idea of one good for another. At first, exchange is incidental to production for use. That is, exchange is not the primary intention of production; it's incidental. One question that immediately arises in even barter situations is what is the rate of exchange, how to know how much of one thing to trade for another. How do we equilibrate those things? Whether it's bread for shoes, shoes for wine, and so on.

One measure is the necessary labor time that goes into the production of the good. This is a very rudimentary kind of labor theory of value. That is, what the good is worth is how much time it takes to produce it. That could include the acquisition of the raw materials that are necessary and so forth. It is clearly not perfect, since one producer may be much more or less efficient than another with whom he or she is trading goods. But, it produces a rough equivalence, that is, we know how many pairs of shoes to trade for how much grain for example, or how much bread. This is one basis for thinking about how we make that equivalence.

In Capital, Volume 1, Marx begins with the concept of the commodity. It's the first chapter in the book. It's a very interesting story about how he gets to that. In a previous work called the Grundrisse, which is an outline of his major work on capital, or political economy, he ends the Grundrisse with a little tiny note on the notion of the commodity. He has a little note to himself at the end of this; it is less than a one-page comment that says, "This to be moved forward." Then he begins Capital by speaking about the commodity, which he thinks about as the most basic element of capital.

The commodity includes two components: use value; that is, the commodity has to be useful for someone for

something. Under capital, however, a commodity also has to have this other essential element, which is exchange value. That is, it has to be capable, in addition to it being useful, of carrying something that the society values. We'll talk about what that is in just a minute. The commodity must have these two elements to be useful in a capitalist sense. To perform its function as I say, it has to include both elements.

These elements are reciprocal and antithetical to each other. That is, to operate as a capitalist bearer of value, in an exchange, one has to give up the use value to get the exchange value, and vice versa. That is, if you come to a market with a pair of shoes, but you can't give up the pair of shoes, because you need them, you can't put them into the exchange and get the exchange value. Vice versa, if you come to the exchange with money (which we'll discuss in a moment), you must give up that money to get the use value. These things are embodied in the commodity, but as I say, they are held in an interesting kind of antithetical tension with each other. You must give up one to get the other.

Another word that Marx uses for this is that the commodity must be alienable for you. You must be able to give it up in order to get back what you think it is worth. So let's talk about another issue that becomes very necessary in this sort of formulation. This arises when the division of labor, that is, specialization of tasks, and exchange become more generalized. That is, when they are not simply incidental to production as a little bit of surplus, but when this becomes a dominant part of the pattern of society. When specialization and exchange become generalized, there is a need for something called a universal equivalent.

Under such circumstances, a universal equivalent is a particular commodity in terms of which all other commodities can be valued. It gets very awkward if you have a lot of goods being exchanged, to think about simply talking about the amount of labor time, or average labor time that went into them. Rather than being able to talk in those terms, we need something called a universal equivalent. That universal equivalent we call money. Performing as the universal equivalent is one of the functions, one of the several functions, that money performs, but I'm going to stay just with this one for tonight.

Anything can serve as money. Historically, many things have served as money over time. You know the word salary. Comes from the word salt, and salt at one point was a form of money. For reasons historical, other reasons, reasons of portability, durability, consistent quality, things like gold and silver, and sometimes copper and other precious metals, have served most typically over time as money. The important point to note here is that money performs this function of a universal equivalent. The value of every other commodity can see itself in money.

Let's start now by thinking about how this works. This is the most basic form of commodity exchange: C [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] M [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] C

C, commodity; M, money; C, another commodity. This is selling in order to buy. You come to market with a commodity, say you have a surplus of shoes, but you don't specialize in making bread, you come to market, you sell the shoes, you get money, you use the money to buy bread.

Exchange, rather than use, starts to become the rationale for production. Early in the production cycle, remember, use is the predominant rationale for production. Once we are in this kind of setting, where exchange and specialization have taken over, production for exchange predominates. The item must still have a use value for someone; otherwise, there is no sale. So, one has to keep in mind the usability of the item, even though it's not use for oneself that is the primary rationale for production.

The arrows are bidirectional, because every purchase is always simultaneously a sale, if it's going to happen as a transaction. Once money is in the picture, as opposed to barter, many things change in this kind of setting. The most important of which (and we'll talk about this in a couple of different contexts in a minute) is that there is now a very significant power asymmetry at work. That is, the owner of a commodity must find a buyer for that specific commodity. The owner of money can buy anything that's on offer, or buy nothing at all. You can see that the relationship between the commodity owner and the money owner here is a very interesting and hierarchical one. That is, the owner of money has a significant advantage over the owner of the commodity.

I now want to expand this notion and think about capitalism as a mode of production, rather than just simple exchange. Here we have a formula that we are going to look at a number of times and in slightly different settings each time: M [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] C [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] C' [image

file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] M’.

I want to go over the basics of it. We start with M, which is money, C, which are input commodities, C primed is the output of one cycle of production, and M primed is more money. Start with M, one end, you end up with M primed, you hope, at the other end, and something happens in between.

This, unlike simple exchange, is buying in order to sell, rather than selling in order to buy. This is buying in order to sell. In this model, what capitalists buy is inputs or the means of production, that is, raw materials, plant and equipment, things of that sort, and labor power. So, the M at the beginning is used to buy C, which are, as I say, means of production, and labor power. Those get thrown into the production cycle, produces additional C primed output at the end of one cycle. Then, eventually, hopefully, more money.

In the capitalist mode of production, the means of production are in private hands. This is an essential feature of a capitalist mode of production. So the decisions about what to produce, how to produce it, what to do with the profits, if any, are also in private hands. We simply take these things for granted, this is how the system works. The only thing workers have to sell is their labor power. Let me repeat that, the only thing workers have to sell is their labor power.

I put a note in here, not their labor, and I’ll make that distinction clear in just a little bit. The only thing workers have to sell is their labor power. So, here is an interesting thing. In the labor market, as in other commodity exchanges, there is a tremendous power asymmetry, just like in any other exchange. The owner of the commodity labor power, that is the worker, must find a willing buyer for his or her specific labor. The owner of money, that is, the capitalist, can buy whatever is on offer, or buy nothing at all.

This is something useful to think about when we reflect on Milton Friedman’s piece on this issue of economic freedom, in which the participants enter into this agreement willingly, voluntarily, and on equal footing. This is clearly not the case. The worker coming into this exchange must find a buyer for his or her particular labor skills, abilities, capabilities, and so forth. The person coming in with money can either buy those or buy somebody else’s, or not buy anything at all.

This immediately jeopardizes Friedman’s position on this notion of economic freedom. I’ll examine that in a little bit further detail in a minute. I want to turn now to another related topic. This is the idea of primitive accumulation. It’s going to help us answer a few questions that spring to mind when thinking about these fundamental elements of a capitalist mode of production. The first question is, why are the means of production in the private hands of the few? If an essential feature of capitalism is that the means of production are in private hands, and I didn’t say of the few, but we can infer that easily, why is that the case?

Second, how is it that the capitalists find people ready and willing to sell their labor power, and that’s all that they have to sell? How is that the case? Let’s turn to Karl Marx:

Here is the myth first of all. This primitive accumulation plays in political economy about the same part as original sin in theology. Its origin is supposed to be explained when it is told as an anecdote of the past. In times long gone by there were two sorts of people; one, the diligent, intelligent, and above all frugal elite. The other lazy rascals, spending their substance more in riotous living. Thus it came to pass that the former sort accumulated wealth, and the latter sort had at last nothing to sell, except their own skins. That’s really what happened. From this original sin dates the poverty of the great majority, that despite all its labor has up to now nothing to sell but itself, and the wealth of the few that increases constantly although they have long ceased to work. Such childishness is every day preached to us in the defense of property. (Capital, vol. 1, 873–74)

This is the myth. Does it continue? Do we still have this myth? Here we go. Some of you may recognize senator Charles Grassley. Last year he said, “I think not having the state tax recognizes the people that are investing.” He told the Des Moines Register, “As opposed to those that are just spending every darn penny they have. Whether it’s on booze, women or movies” (December 3, 2017).

Basically the ideas, the myth, have pretty much stayed with us, not disappeared. Again from Marx:

In actual history, it is a notorious fact that conquest, enslavement, robbery, murder, in short, force, play the greatest

part. The process therefore that clears the way for the capitalist system can be none other than the process which takes away from the laborer the possession of his means of production. A process that transforms on the one hand the social means of subsistence in production in the capital. The other, the immediate producers into wage laborers. If you take away from people their ability to provide for themselves, which was done by violent means, you leave them in a state where all they can sell is their labor. The so called primitive accumulation therefore is nothing else in the historical process of divorcing the producer, that is the worker, from the means of production. (Capital, vol. 1, 874–75)

It appears as primitive as Marx says, because it forms, as he argued, the prehistory of capital, and the mode of production corresponding to capital. We are going to complicate that in a minute.

Again, think about this in terms of Friedman's notion of economic freedom. That is, the idea that people simply present themselves as workers, rather than the fact that there's been a very deliberate and ongoing set of activities to separate workers from the means of producing for themselves. So it's a very different picture than is painted. In actuality, primitive accumulation is ongoing. It is not simply a relic of the past. We'll talk about the ways in which this continues to occur.

David Harvey has coined a phrase, calling it "accumulation through dispossession." This can take a whole variety of forms, which we'll talk about in more detail in a couple of weeks, but things like privatization of formerly public goods and services. The theft of intellectual property. The enclosures that are effectuated by things like patents and copyrights. Those are all forms of primitive accumulation, or accumulation through dispossession, and they are ongoing. They are not a relic of the past by any means.

One other crucial element, this is an especially important component of the ways in which people are separated from means of subsistence and production for themselves. This idea of

communal property, always distinct from the state property [which Marx just dealt with in another book], it was an old Teutonic institution, which lived on under cover of feudalism. We have seen how the forcible usurpation of this generally accompanied by the turning of arable land into pastoral land. That is, there were common spaces that were available to people to grow food, to graze their own animals and so forth. People were violently thrown off of that land, so as to not be able to produce for themselves. It begins at the end of the 15th and extends into the 16th century, but at that time the process was carried on by means of individual acts of violence, against which legislation for 150 years fought in vain. Didn't fight that hard, but it tried to prevent these usurpations. The advance made by the 18th century shows itself in this, that the law itself becomes now the instrument of the theft of the people's land. Although, the large farmers make use of their little independent methods as well. The parliamentary form of the robbery is that of the acts of closure of the commons, in other words, decrees by which the landlords grant themselves the people's land, this private property, decrees of expropriation of the people. (Capital, vol. 1, 885–86)

Again, every little opportunity that people might have had to produce for themselves is very systematically foreclosed. I mean, the term enclosure is exactly right. That these things were taken away as public resources to be utilized by the people, and made into private property.

And finally,

it is not enough that the conditions of labor [that is, the means of production] are concentrated in the mass in the shape of capital at the one pole of society, while at the other are grouped masses of men who have nothing to sell but their labor power. Neither is it enough that they are compelled to sell it voluntarily. Advance of capitalist production develops a working class, which by education, tradition, habit, looks upon the conditions of that mode of production as self-evident laws of nature. The organization of the capitalist process of production once fully developed breaks down all resistance. (Capital vol. 1, 899)

This is clearly the production of the common sense around capitalism. It's not enough that this has happened, but over time, people begin to think of it as natural, inevitable, and unavoidable. This is just how things work. Note also that what Marx is talking about here is extreme concentration of wealth at one pole, the few capitalists, and the separation of that wealth from the other pole, the masses of people. Undoubtedly, a number of you saw the latest Oxfam report, where twenty-six individuals now own as much wealth as 3.8 billion people on the planet.

There is something possibly wrong with that. I don't know any of the twenty-six personally, but I'm sure that they could give up a little bit. Even the role of money in politics is also a significant implication for democracy, which we are going to talk about. Here you can compare the papers by Milton Friedman and Robin Hahnel. Wealthy elites are able to control the government structures in their favor to enhance their own interest, and further this inequality.

Just to bring this up to date a little bit, as Mark Fisher puts it in his book Capitalist Realism, over the past thirty years (and we are going to talk about this in some detail in a couple of weeks), capitalist realism, which is his term for the prevailing common sense, has successfully installed a business ontology, in which it is simply obvious that everything in society should be run as a business. That's what he means by business ontology. The state of the world is a business world. He points out, and this ties back to last week's conversation on common sense, emancipatory politics must always destroy the appearance of a so-called natural order.

It must reveal what is presented as necessary and inevitable, to be a mere contingency. That is, the common sense of what we think about the capitalist world has to be demonstrated to be contingent, not necessary and inevitable. Then, on the other hand, it must make what was previously deemed to be impossible, seem attainable. He puts out a number of examples in the following paragraph to this quote, where he talks about things that just a few years ago seemed impossible, like the privatization of goods and services and so on: in that twenty-to thirty-year period, privatization did become possible.

Then anything contrary to the way things are now looks completely unattainable, even though a few years ago they seemed to be well within grasp. Again, this is the utility of thinking about things from this point of view of a malleable common sense. That is, that things can change if imaginaries are unleashed.

A couple of others before we get back to the system of how it works. This is again from Marx:

The discovery of gold and silver in America, the extirpation, enslavement, and entombment in the mines of the aboriginal population, the beginning of the conquest, and looting of the East Indies, the turning of Africa into a warren for the commercial hunting of black skins, are all things which characterize the dawn of the era of capitalist production. These idyllic proceedings are the chief moments of primitive accumulation. The different moments of primitive accumulation distribute themselves now more or less in chronological order, particularly over Spain, Portugal, Holland, France, and England. In England at the end of the 17th century, they arrived at a systematical combination embracing the colonies, the national debt, the modern mode of taxation, and the protection of system. The concentrated and organized force of society to hasten, hot-house fashion, the process of transformation, of the feudal mode of production into the capitalist mode, and to shorten the transition. Force is the midwife of every old society pregnant with a new one. It is itself, that is force, is an economic power. (Capital, vol. 1, 915–16)

Again, he's making the point that these forms of primitive accumulation are essential forms for capital to have gone through in order to get to where it gets to. These methods depend in part on group force, for example the colonial system, but they all employ, and this is something quite important, the power of the state: this, for Marx, is one of the few statements that he makes about the role of the state. He had a planned volume on the role of the state in capitalist society, but never got to it.

Now let's turn to the formula, talking about accumulation: M [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] C [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] C' [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] M'.

M, money, C, input commodities, one cycle; M prime, more money. What happens in this process to allow M to become M prime, which is the whole point? You wouldn't go through all of this if you ended up at the end with the same money as you started out with at the beginning. M just came out as M. The whole point is to get from M to M prime.

To understand this, we have to examine this peculiar commodity of labor power. As an analysis of how more money emerges from the production process than goes in, Marx first rules out any possibilities of cheating or unfairness. In his analysis of the capitalist system, Marx is in a conversation with, and often in argumentation with, the economists, and political economists who came before them, principally the classical political economists. People like David Ricardo, Adam Smith, and a number of others.

He wanted to make his analysis within their frame of rules, which presents capital in its best light. So that if in fact

he shows it not to produce the advantages that they claim, he will have done it on their terms. One of the things he does is to rule out things like cheating, like buying low and selling high, which is a sort of principal character of mercantilism. The reason he rules this out is, he says, that on balance in society, this doesn't produce any additional surplus value or wealth. It simply redistributes what value or wealth already exists. That it all averages out; if you cheat somebody, you may have gotten something, but they lost something. It's a kind of zero-sum thing. He rules that out. Everything in the process as Marx analyzes it trades at its true value.

The means of production cannot be the source of the additional value. Remember, he's trying to figure out in his process how we get from M to M prime. One of the things that capitalists do is buy means of production. He says, those cannot be the source of additional value. The reasons are this. They either transfer part of their value to the new products, or, for example, you depreciate machinery over time. You can calculate how much of the value goes into a production in each cycle of production. Or the means of production actually end up incorporated into the new product itself, but there is no new value there. So, if you make something, if you make bread out of wheat, it becomes incorporated in the bread, but there is no new value there. It's necessary for the capitalists to find on the market the commodity that produces more value than it itself costs. That's the trick.

This unique commodity is labor power, and is the only element in the process that produces surplus value, which is the source of profit. It's a unique commodity in that regard. How does this work? Fortunately, there is a simple answer. I hate to be bearer of bad news, but this is how it works: exploitation of the worker. How does this operate?

To understand this process, we have to begin by understanding wages, particularly the notion of a prevailing average wage. Such a prevailing average wage can fluctuate around a mean, depending on supply and demand for labor, but is set by how much it takes to enable the worker to reproduce him-or herself on a daily basis. That is at a minimum to feed, clothe, shelter him-or herself, so as to be able to return to work the next day. This is how the wage is set.

This prevailing average wage that is the price of the reproduction of labor is dependent on the cost of a so-called basket of commodities, that constitute a set of reasonable expectations of compensation in a given society, at a given time and place. Marx very problematically used the nation-state as the scale for this. There could be enormous fluctuations within that. You think about what it takes to feed, clothe, shelter, and so forth, a person at a particular time in place. This is sort of the average wage, and it's this basket of commodities. Quite clearly, this average wage varies over time, and from place to place. What is a reasonable set of expectations in the US in 2019 is clearly different than it was in 1950 or 1970, or what it might be at present in Bangladesh or Germany. Just as a side note, average wages in 2019 in the US are about where they were in 1970. We'll come back to that in a couple of weeks.

What is reasonable in one time and place is clearly different than it might be in another time and place, but the mechanism for determining the prevailing average wage remains the same. That is, you determine a wage by calculating the cost of a basket of commodities. What varies from time to time and from place to place is what goes into the basket.

Now that we know how a prevailing average wage is calculated, we can translate this into our understanding of how M' is derived from M in the production process. We begin by asking what does the capitalist buy when he or she buys the commodity of labor power? What is the capitalist actually purchasing? It is the worker's ability to labor. The capitalist gets to decide how that ability will be put to use. This is the difference between buying labor power, and buying labor. If you buy labor, it's already embodied in a good or service. If you buy labor, the worker has already determined how to expend that labor power. If you buy labor power, you, as the capitalist, get to determine how that will be directed and used. The capitalist buys the worker's ability to labor.

Does the capitalist buy the worker's entire life? Certainly not. That would be slavery, which is too expensive for capitalists, because they have to then pay for the upkeep, much better to rent the wage slave, than to purchase the actual slave. The capitalist buys the worker's capacity to work for a specified period, which is the working day. The length of the working day, I should note, has been a longstanding site of enormous class struggle. At the time Marx was writing Capital, an average working day could be sixteen, could be eighteen hours, or even longer. The fight, historically, for what we now typically think about as the eight-hour day, or the forty-hour week, was a long, long struggle. But back to the process, basically what the capitalist is buying is the worker's capacity to work, but for a specified period of his working day.

From the capitalist's point of view, this working day is, of whatever length it turns out to be, divided into two parts.

This is from the capitalist's point of view, although the capitalist doesn't think about it this way, either. I'll say something about that in a second. Part of the day is what's called the necessary labor part of the day. That's the part of the working day in which the worker reproduces his or her own cost, and for which he or she is paid through the wage.

The basket of commodities that constitutes the prevailing average wage has a value. A worker has to work so long in a day to produce that value in goods and services. That's the necessary part of the working day. If that part of the working day coincided with the entire workday, there would be no surplus whatsoever. That's clear. If the working day was sixteen hours, but it took sixteen hours to produce the value of that basket of commodities, there is no surplus.

The other part of the working day, called the surplus labor part of the day, is the part in which the worker continues to produce goods or services, but for which she or he is not paid. This is the process that produces surplus value, and it's the source of all of the capitalist's profits. The working day, let's say it now consists of eight hours, but if the worker reproduces him or herself in anything less than that time, then everything above that is surplus. The capitalist has not paid for it, and so this is the source of surplus value and profit. All of this works behind the backs of both capitalist and workers. Nobody sees the working day in this way.

We have this mythology, a fair day's work for a fair day's wages. In fact, that's not how the working day works at all. If it were, capitalism would grind to a halt instantly. The time that it takes to reproduce the worker is always something less than the time that the worker works. It's clearly in the capitalist interest to reduce the necessary labor part of the day, that is, the time that the worker is paying for him or herself, as much as possible, and to increase the surplus labor time part of the day as much as possible. If you could go from the necessary working day being three-quarters of the day to one-quarter, you've increased the surplus by that much.

Marx identified two ways in which this could happen. One was called absolute surplus value. That is, you could do this by increasing the length of the working day. Let's say it takes four hours to reproduce the worker, and the workday is only six hours. Well, if you increase the length of the working day to eight or twelve hours, and all else remains equal, that is, it takes the same amount of time to reproduce the worker, you've increased the surplus time. This ability to increase the length of the working day has both biological limits (that is, you can only work for so long before productivity begins to decline precipitously), and now has, in many places, legal limits. Not every place. There are a lot of places where there are no prohibitions on the length of the working day. At some point the biological constraints do begin to play a factor. You can't do this continuously.

And so another way to increase the surplus part of the day is what Marx called relative surplus value, and this you can do by increasing the intensity of the labor process. Through things like reorganizing the labor process, so there is more cooperation, more efficiency, your throughput becomes quicker, you can speed up the line in a manufacturing setting. At the turn of the last century, there were all these time and motion studies that were trying to actually anatomize each work process to make it as efficient as possible. All those are things that you can do to increase the intensity of the work process, and, importantly, for which the capitalist pays nothing. So again, this is another way to increase the surplus part of the day.

Let's return to this formula one more time: M [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] C [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] C' [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] M'.

We now know where M prime comes from. It comes from exploitation of the worker. If at the end of each cycle the capitalist simply spends the surplus, that is, the M prime, on his or her own consumption, or simply hoards it, sticks it in an offshore account, or something like that, and spends it all up, this is called "simple reproduction," and does nothing to add to economic growth. It's a very uninteresting part of all of this. If, on the other hand, part of the surplus is thrown back into the production process for another cycle of production, by buying more means of production, and/or buying more labor power, this is called "expanded reproduction," and this is what leads to economic growth.

Engaging in this process means that some decisions have to be made. In expanded reproduction, at the beginning of each cycle, the capitalist must decide how much to reinvest, and interestingly, how to divide that reinvestment between labor power (i.e., living labor), called variable capital, and means of production, which are called constant capital or dead labor. The reason they are called that—if you think about tools, and equipment, and raw material—

they have labor embodied in them, but they don't have living labor in them. You take a machine, it has labor in it, but that labor has already been expensed. It's called constant capital or dead labor.

At the beginning of each new cycle of production, then, capitalists divide their reinvestment between means of production and labor power. There is a decision to make, how much to reinvest, and how to divide that reinvestment between these two components of capital investment. These decisions are based at least in part, and often in large part, on how the production process is being modified by the capitalist's competitors. Capitalists do not operate in a void typically. That is, they are in a segment of capital, or in a segment of the market, where they have competition.

The decisions that other competitors are making compel capitalists to keep up in one way or another. Under the compulsion of this constant competition, capitalists constantly revolutionize the production process to stay one jump ahead, and thereby maintain, and maximize, their own profits. Others must then either follow them, innovate on their own, or go under. This is why Marx thought of capitalism in very admiring terms in many ways as this revolutionary system. That is, if all of this kind of constant innovation could be turned to other ends, and not simply profit maximization for the few, this had some real promise. Marx was quite admiring of this potential.

The only escape for individual capitalists from this constant competition is monopoly. Over time, this is a trend in capitalism: the big eat the small. When we look at media consolidation, or we look at consolidation in other sectors, this is the driver. The only way in which capitalists can escape this constant competition is by developing a monopoly control over their market segment. This is why they strive for mergers and acquisitions to rule out their competition. It means they can get off of this sort of revolutionizing treadmill.

For a variety of reasons, mostly having to do with the need to control the vagaries of living labor, capitalists tend, over time, to increase the amount they invest in constant rather than variable capital. That is, they tend to put more money into the means of production than into labor. A lot of this has to do, as I say, with a living labor force being somewhat problematic.

One common form of this phenomenon that we see all the time now is automation; that is, replacing living labor with dead labor (machines). This has several important effects. Some of which are social, some of which are economic. Skill is invested in the machines, and the workers become deskilled machine minders. This is a very useful thing for capitalists. It doesn't mean that as you automate there might not be the production of some new jobs that have real value, but in a much more generalized sense, workers are deskilled. They then become quite easily replaceable by other workers.

For example, over the history of technology, in industrial technology, we see women replacing men, children replacing adults. As the necessary strength for a skill gets invested in the machine, or the necessary artisanal skills get put into the machine, you can get much less skilled workers to do the same sort of thing. This has an enormous disciplining effect on existing workers. That is, if you know, not only that there are a number of people waiting to take your job, but that they don't really have to know much, this makes you rather docile in the workplace. Over time, the same amount, or even an increase in production, takes fewer and fewer workers. We are seeing this now. We'll talk about this again in a couple of weeks.

This may also add to a reserve of unemployed labor, or underemployed labor, which is another disciplining effect. We have a very low official unemployment rate in the US now, about 4 percent, or even less.a Many people, though, have either given up looking for work, or are vastly underemployed. We've got to keep in mind that the true unemployment rate is very different than that. Even people who are employed, many of them are not employed in jobs that pay enough to actually subsist. Having that reserve army out there is again another disciplining effect.

This process of investment in constant versus variable capital, that is, in means of production versus living labor, produces two major problems for capital. We are seeing these now. The first problem, since living labor is the only source of surplus value, shifting from living to dead labor may contribute to a falling rate of profit. There are ways in which capital can ameliorate this, but each of these has a cost as well. I'm just going to mention these now, and then come back to what they produced at the end of the 1960s into the 1970s, in a couple of weeks. A falling rate of profit can be ameliorated by a rising rate of exploitation, that is, you can work the existing workforce harder. However, as I said, that has limits, both biological and legal.

If the constant capital that you are investing in itself becomes less expensive, this can also ameliorate a falling rate

of profit. You can depress wages below their value, which is a form of cheating, and again won't last very long if there is any competition, and if there is a greater demand for labor power than there is supply. You can increase the industrial reserve army thereby putting more pressure on existing workers to work and perform harder. All those are ways that you could ameliorate this problem. The problem stems from the fact that you've driven out the investment in living labor, which, as I say, is the only source of surplus value and profit.

There is another problem as well. Again, from replacing living labor with dead labor; that is, investing in constant versus variable capital. Let's return one last time to this formula: M [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] C [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] C' [image file=image_rsrc41Y.jpg] M'.

Now we know how C prime, that is, the surplus product, is produced through the exploitation of the worker. We know that C prime commodity contains both use value and an increased exchange value. That's essential. That's important. For the capitalist to realize that value, however, that is, to actually get the profit, the commodity has to be sold; we have to move from C' to M'.

A capitalist can go through this entire production process, but if s/he doesn't sell the product, s/he can't get the profit. How is this tied to this notion of reducing investment in living labor? For the sale to occur there must be effective demand, which means a buyer with both the desire to buy the commodity and the means to buy it. You can certainly create the demand through advertising, and so forth, but if you've now got people who are either unemployed, underemployed, or underpaid, you don't have the second component of this, the capacity to buy the product.

If each capitalist acting in his or her own self-interest continually lowers his or her own labor cost, for example, through automation, or through lowering wages, or exporting jobs elsewhere, the aggregate effect is to reduce overall effective demand. That's in essence a huge part of what we've been experiencing since the crash of 2008, and is a problem that is sometimes called overproduction, and sometimes called under-consumption. They are not quite the same thing, but I'm not going to go into the differences here. Essentially, it's a capitalist crisis, where you have goods and services going unsold, because there is not enough effective demand to purchase them.

This, then, brings us very briefly to the role of the state in capitalism. We've already seen that the state plays a role in securing the conditions necessary for capitalism to flourish. Things like military conquests, and imperialism and colonialism, through the legal system that gets set up, things like the enclosure movements, protection of private properties, security of contracts, those sorts of things, through the provision of needed infrastructure, which we haven't talked about yet, but all of these capitalist enterprises rely upon an environment in which they can actually operate. Roads, communication systems, research and development.

All of these sorts of things are typically provided by the state, but also the role of the state in a capitalist system is to protect capitalism from capitalists. Left to their own devices, and I just showed you an example of this, the aggregate effect of each one acting in his or her own self-interest could lead to a systemic kind of catastrophe. Just think about FDR's New Deal, which was, in fact, in large part a measure to save capitalism from capitalists. The 2008/2009 bank bailout is another example, as is the minimum wage. Anybody who is against the minimum wage doesn't understand how capitalism works.

Now, I want to make some ties between this political economic system, and the kind of consequences, necessary consequences, we are going to look at in the next couple of weeks. The first one is the set of relationships between capitalism and militarism. Some of the underlying motives, the need for access to labor supplies and markets, as well as access to means of production, both positive and negative resources. That is, things that go into production as well as places to dump the waste, and so forth. That's what I mean by positive and negative resources. Historically, such militarism has taken very different forms: imperialism, colonialism, neocolonialism, neo-imperialism.

There are also numerous connections, as we've seen, to primitive accumulation and accumulation through dispossession, and militarism and force continue to undergird those kinds of activities. Also, militarism is a source of profits in and of itself. The military industrial complex is extremely lucrative, and now I would add in security-industrial complex, and the surveillance-industrial complex. Any number of other things you might want to use to modify that.

It is also important to keep in mind the multiple connections between militarism abroad and militarism at home. These connections are underlain by an evolving of pervasive common sense, which is a fear of dangerous others. This is a common sense that must be constantly reinforced. A part of this element of common sense has to do with the legitimacy of the state. Given a globalized economic system, individual nation-states can't guarantee the economic security of their own citizens in many cases. The decisions that need to be made about the economy are not made by states. And therefore, a new basis of legitimacy (i.e., rather than economic security) had to be found. This now depends on protection from these dangerous others. Targeting of these people is often used to divide the working class against themselves. We see this in the rise of nationalism, populism, so-called, and so forth.

These dangerous others include foreign enemies. This role used to be filled by communists, but this was very difficult to sustain since the fall of the Berlin Wall and the collapse of the former Soviet Union. Communism has, therefore, become much less of an issue, so we've had to switch to a different enemy: the global terrorist, along with immigrants and refugees. We are also constantly reminded to be very afraid of domestic enemies: women, people of color, the young, the old, LGBTQ communities, the differently abled. All of these are constantly targeted as dangers from which we need protection. And that's part of the way in which the state in 2019 establishes its legitimacy, as well as a way to bring militarism home.

The second set of connections is between capitalism and environmental catastrophe. Again, these are necessary connections between a capitalist political economy and its consequences. The underlying motive is the need for continuous capital growth and expansion. Competition drives it in a lot of ways that we'll talk about. Unfortunately, however, we are in a finite world. Some of the results include widespread resource depletion, as well as pervasive environmental pollution, including climate change. Many of these consequences occur because of capitalism's dependence on externalizing (that is, putting the burden on others) any costs that detract from the bottom line—the issue of externalities, which we'll talk about in a couple of weeks. Pervasive common sense that underlies this tension is that quality of life, happiness, and satisfaction must be defined by the acquisition of things. That results in rampant and endless consumerism, novelty, obsolescence, and waste, because these are things that capitalism produces.

Finally, there is a set of connections between capitalism, in its neoliberal, financialized, and globalized form, and a set of consequences resulting from that form. I'm just going to go through these very, very quickly, because we are out of time, but we are also going to cover them in a couple of weeks. The underlying motive for capital to have taken on this form is that, at the end of the previous period, which was roughly 1945 to 1970, capital came up against steeply falling rates of profit. Capital needed a new form, new areas for invasion and accumulation.

Capital, under the right circumstances, is free to roam the globe, depending on the nature and extent of your sunk (or fixed) costs. That is, if you have a lot of investment in a place, and plant equipment, you are not so free to roam. But if you are not encumbered by such investment, as a capitalist you can roam around the globe in search of cheaper and/or more submissive labor, newer cheaper resources, new markets, places to dump pollution, and so forth. Other opportunities for renewed accumulation and profit include the privatization of previously public goods and services. This is a form of accumulation by dispossession—an update of primitive accumulation. Finally, extensions of new intellectual property rights, colonization of indigenous and traditional knowledge can all be used as profit sources.

While capital is free to roam around, labor is held in place. If workers could travel freely to areas of higher wages or better working conditions, this would dampen capitalists' power. This is a large part of the reason we have these incredible controversies about so-called immigrants and refugees. Pervasive common sense underlying this neoliberal form is the market or business ontology that I discussed before: markets good, government bad.

Finally, there is a relationship between all of these effects and the resistance and response that the issues generate. There are labor movements, peace movements, environmental movements, social justice and equality movements, civil rights movements, identity politics movements, and on and on. However, they are often disconnected from each other. A crucial point of the lecture, and the course more generally, is to demonstrate that these varied movements should be bound together, because all have the same underlying structural systemic causes. I will stop with that.

Chomsky Lecture, January 24, 2019

I'll start with some good news, or at least not awful news. As maybe you've seen, the Doomsday Clock was set this

morning, and contrary to many people's fears, mine included, it was not moved closer to midnight. It's staying at two minutes to midnight, which is as close as it's been to terminal destruction since it was set. The original setting in 1947 was seven minutes to midnight. It reached two minutes to midnight in 1953 when the United States and the Soviet Union set off thermonuclear explosions, informing the world that humans, in their magnificence, had achieved the ability to destroy everything. Since then, the minute hand has oscillated, but it never returned to two minutes to midnight until January 2018 after Trump's first year in office. And that's where it stays today. My personal guess is that the analysts felt that if they moved it closer to midnight, within a year or two we'd reach the limit (goodbye), so they're holding back.

Well, let's turn to our current topic: hegemonic common sense, particularly as shaped and reflected in the intellectual domains, including the political and social sciences. Research in these areas is quite hard, for many reasons. One is that you can't set up controlled experiments the way you can in the hard sciences. But occasionally, history obliges and constructs a pretty good one for us.

Actually, that happened for market fundamentalism, the Friedmanite market fundamentalism that Marv was talking about in our last meeting. It happened in 1973 in Chile, when the Pinochet military coup overthrew the social democratic parliamentary government of Salvador Allende, instituting a vicious dictatorship. That was another chapter in the plague of repression that swept over the hemisphere from the early 1960s that I alluded to before, and that we'll return to later from its interesting origins on.

There is a background to this, which is worth a couple of minutes' reflection. From the late 1950s, the CIA was running one of its major operations in Chile to try to prevent Allende from being elected. It included massive electoral interference and numerous other forms of subversion (rather normal, hence unremarked). There was also large-scale economic support for the effort from the US corporate sector, the US government, the World Bank, all doing everything they could to make sure that this catastrophe didn't take place. It worked until 1970, when Allende was elected.

Note incidentally that the CIA is not a "rogue elephant," as sometimes claimed—a convenient evasion. It is an agency of the executive branch, which regularly follows orders and provides "plausible deniability" to those who issue them in the White House.

Allende's election set off a frenzy in Washington, first for the CIA, whose huge investment had collapsed, but quite generally. The US cut off foreign aid. The president of the World Bank, Robert McNamara, formerly Kennedy-Johnson secretary of defense, banned all World Bank loans, in opposition to the advice of his advisors, who wanted an accommodation with the new government. There was a sharp increase in subversion of all types, including media, which are so far to the right in Chile that you need a strong telescope to find them.

The US government itself set up what it called two tracks, a soft track and a hard track. The soft track was to destroy the economy. The phrase that was used in internal documents was "to make the economy scream," to try to crush the society so that in desperation people would throw out the government. That was the soft track.

The hard track was to prepare a military coup. There are very good sources on this, mainly a book called The Pinochet Files, edited by Peter Kornbluh, a Latin America scholar. It's essentially a collection of government documents that describe very carefully, lucidly, what was going on.

The central figure in all of this was Henry Kissinger, Nixon's national security advisor, then also secretary of state. The Files contain a report that CIA covert operations led to the assassination of the commander of the armed forces, René Schneider, who was supporting the government. The CIA thought that might be enough to set off an uprising, but it didn't. It failed to stop Allende's inauguration on November 4, 1967.

After the failure, Kissinger lobbied President Nixon to reject the State Department's recommendation that the US seek a modus vivendi with Allende. In an eight-page secret briefing paper that provided Kissinger's clearest rationale for regime change in Chile, he emphasized to Nixon that "the election of Allende as president of Chile poses for us one of the most serious challenges ever faced in this hemisphere [and] your decision as to what to do about it may be the most historic and difficult foreign affairs decision you will make this year."

Remember, this was right at the peak of the Vietnam War and many other things, but overthrow of the Allende

regime was of transcendent importance.

Kissinger goes on to say that not only were a billion dollars of US investments at stake, but also what he called "the insidious model effect" of Allende's democratic election. There was no way for the US to deny Allende's legitimacy, Kissinger noted, and if he succeeded in peacefully reallocating resources in Chile in a socialist direction, other countries might follow suit. "The example of a successful elected Marxist government in Chile would surely have an impact on—and even precedent value for—other parts of the world, especially in Italy; the imitative spread of similar phenomena elsewhere would in turn significantly affect the world balance and our own position in it."

The "Marxist government" was in reality a social democratic government, but as Dean Acheson had explained much earlier, it's necessary to be "clearer than truth" when seeking to "bludgeon the mass mind of government." As for Italy, Kissinger didn't have to explain. He and Nixon knew why Italy was a problem: there were major left parties and a huge CIA operation had been going on since 1948 to subvert Italian democracy, one of the CIA's major operations. So the Chilean moves toward social change by parliamentary means might well have an effect on Italy and beyond.

A day later, Nixon made it clear to the entire National Security Council that the policy would be to bring Allende down. "Our main concern," he informed them, "is the prospect that he can consolidate himself and the picture projected to the world will be his success."

This "insidious model effect" is actually a leading theme of foreign policy planning rather generally. As Dean Acheson formulated the problem, a rotten apple can spoil the barrel. In Kissinger's version, the Allende government is a "virus" that might "spread contagion." The solution to that dilemma is clear: you kill the virus and you inoculate potential victims, if necessary by violent and repressive military dictatorships.

That's quite conventional thinking. It's often called the domino theory. The US didn't invent it, of course. It's second nature to any imperial power. They just took it over when the US replaced Britain and France, the major international imperial powers prior to the Second World War. The theory had been applied before. One critical case was the revolution that established the first free country of free men in the hemisphere, in Haiti in 1804. The US joined the combined effort by the great powers—France, the imperial power in Haiti, and Britain, the major world power—to crush the Haitian revolution. It was, plausibly, feared that the Haitian revolution would be an insidious model for others, especially for slave states like the United States. Haiti did achieve its freedom, at tremendous cost, but never recovered from the interventions and their aftermath. We'll return to some of the details. Participation in the assault on Haiti was the first example of resorting to the domino theory in US foreign policy.

The domino theory is often ridiculed when the dominoes don't fall, but why don't they fall? Well, because the cure was successful. Policy succeeds, dominoes don't fall, the insidious model is destroyed, the virus is killed, others are protected from infection by military dictatorships or other devices. There are many illustrations of this pattern, including, incidentally, Vietnam. I'll return to this when we discuss imperial policy later on. The Allende example is a striking one.

Though constantly ridiculed, the domino theory is maintained, as it was right through the Cold War. It is quite rational. It makes good sense.

Well, the Pinochet coup set up an almost perfect experiment for market fundamentalism, for Friedmanite policies. There could be no objection to policy decisions. The torture chambers took care of that. To use per capita equivalents, the appropriate measure, the accomplishments of the terror launched on 9/11, 1973, the date of the coup, were as if about 100,000 people were killed in the United States and half a million tortured.

Some food for thought.

I got some sense of the torture when I visited Chile a couple of years ago. I was taken on a visit to the Villa Grimaldi, the main torture chamber. It's been turned into a kind of shrine. I was taken through it by a prominent human rights activist in Chile who was a victim of the torture in the Villa Grimaldi, one of the few who survived. He took me through it step by step. Prisoners were taken through a succession of stages. First, mild torture, then harsher torture, then on and on until, at the last stage, if they'd survived so far, they were thrown into a nearby tower, which few survived. He was one.

He said at each stage there was a doctor present to make sure that the patient didn't die so he could go on to the next and harsher stage. I asked him afterward, "What happened to the doctors after democracy was restored?" He said that they're practicing in Santiago. That's one of the effects of not having a Truth Commission, not having any investigation of crimes of state. I mentioned earlier that that's something that we can think about with regard to ourselves.

In any event, there couldn't be any objections to any of the regime's policies. Furthermore, the dictatorship had huge external support. During the Allende years, as I mentioned, everything was cut off, but as soon as the dictatorship was imposed and the frenzy of murder and torture was underway, the spigot was opened. There was a flood of US aid. The World Bank provided new loans, quite substantial ones. Multinational corporations came in to profit from the grand experiment, and to help maintain the dictatorship. The market model was imposed by students of the doctrines of Friedman and his associates, the so-called "Chicago boys," Chileans who studied economics at the University of Chicago. They were operating with the advice of their neoliberal mentors, Friedman and other leading market economists who visited regularly. And who were much impressed, not just by the economic policies but even by the freedom under the dictatorship. One of the patron saints of neoliberalism and libertarianism, Friedrich Hayek, said, "I have not been able to find a single person even in much maligned Chile who did not agree that personal freedom was much greater under Pinochet than it had been under Allende." Which may tell us something about whom he chose to see.

The Chicago boys and their mentors had the good sense to maintain the highly efficient, nationalized copper producer Codelco, the world's largest. That's, of course, a radical violation of market principles, of neoliberal principles, but worthwhile since the company was the source of much of Chile's export earnings and the basis of the state's fiscal revenues.

In general, it was close to a perfect experiment. It looked like a great success, if you ignored the human costs.

In 1982, Friedman published the second edition of his manifesto, Capitalism and Freedom, celebrating the triumph of the cause. The timing was auspicious. In 1982 the Chilean economy crashed and had to be bailed out by state intervention. The state then controlled more of the economy than it had under Allende. Analysts who had their eyes open called it "the Chicago road to socialism." The prominent OECD (Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development) economist Javier Santiso described the "paradox [that] able economists committed to laissez-faire showed the world yet another road to a de facto socialized banking system" (2006).

Incidentally, the chief economist of the far-right Brazilian government that was voted into office recently, Paulo Guedes, was in Chile during these years working on the miracle and has announced that those are the policies Brazil is going to follow. In his words, "privatize everything," sell off the whole country to investors, most foreign, make some profit in the short term, maybe it can get you elected for a couple years. In the longer term, the country goes down the drain. And maybe Brazil will even achieve the success of the Chilean experiment, even though it lacks the same ideal conditions.

There have been other experiments, not as clear as this one is. It is hard to find something like a controlled experiment in the complex historical world. But there are more complex cases. If we had time, it would be interesting to go through the development of industrial societies, starting with England in the seventeenth century, then the United States, the European countries, Japan, finally the East Asian tigers. There are some striking uniformities. Every single case involved radical violation of market principles. The pattern has not passed unnoticed. Economic historian Paul Bairoch, after an extensive review, concludes that "it is difficult to find another case where the facts so contradict a dominant theory [as the theory] concerning the negative impact of protectionism" (Bairoch), which is only one of the forms of market interference employed by the United States and other developed societies, and far from the most extreme.

There are some societies that did observe market principles, though not by choice: the colonies, where these policies were rammed down their throats. They became the Third World. It's not that they all started off poor. In fact, in the eighteenth century, the most advanced industrial and commercial societies were India and China, and West Africa is described by Africa historians as about at the same stage as Japan at the time of its takeoff in the nineteenth century. India was subjected to what Adam Smith called "the savage injustice of the Europeans." It was deindustrialized. England stole its high technology in the manner that we're now accusing China of doing to us (but by force in England's case). The US did the same thing with England. In fact, appropriating higher technology from others was

one of the major forms of development, now barred by World Trade Organization rules—a process economic historians call “kicking away the ladder”: first use the ladder to climb up, then kick it away so that others don’t do so.

India became India, a deeply impoverished, largely peasant society; England developed. It has continued this way right to the present. That’s a large part of the reason for the division between what’s called the First and the Third World. There’s one interesting exception in the Global South to this process, Japan. It’s the one country of the South that developed, and the one country that wasn’t colonized. Coincidence? Oddly, no lessons are drawn from it, but you might want to think about it.

Let’s go back to Robin Hahnel’s criticisms of Friedmanite market theory in the readings for today. He mostly criticized the economic policies, but he also had some comments on Friedman’s conception that what he calls economic freedom leads to democracy. Hahnel made the obvious comment that it’s a kind of democracy where the number of votes you have depends on the number of dollars in your pocket. You have a million dollars, you have a million votes. If you have no dollars, you have no votes.

Friedman, if he’d bothered, could have put up quite a good defense, namely, that’s pretty much the way democracies operate, so what’s the problem?

There’s very good research on this in mainstream political science. Some is by an outstanding political scientist, Thomas Ferguson, who’s done the main studies of the effect of campaign spending on electability and policy formation. The results are quite remarkable. Both for the executive and for Congress, you can predict electability with astonishing precision just by looking at the single variable of campaign spending. Of course, that affects policies.

It’s not new, though it takes new and more sophisticated forms. In 1895, there was a famous campaign manager, Mark Hanna, who was celebrated for running successful campaigns. He was asked once what it takes to run a successful campaign, and his answer was, “There are two things that you need. The first one is money, and I’ve forgotten what the second one is.” Ferguson’s “investment theory of politics”—the idea that investors form coalitions to control the state—places Hanna’s conclusions from practice on firm ground with a rich historical record, up to the present moment.

That’s just the bare beginning. Campaign spending is overwhelmed by lobbying, which expanded rapidly from the seventies and through the neoliberal period. An effect of these developments is something like Friedman’s concept of democracy: your votes reflect your dollars.

As I discussed earlier, the basic pattern goes back to the first democratic revolution in seventeenth-century England and continues to the second one a century later in the newly liberated colonies, to which we’ll return. But we shouldn’t overlook the fact that however flawed, these democratic revolutions constituted real progress toward democracy and rights. Establishing parliamentary sovereignty in England in 1689 was no small achievement, and the American Revolution opened a new era in functioning democracy. In fact, simply the phrase, “We the people” was a very radical idea, a revolutionary idea, however flawed it was in formulation and implementation.

From the perspective of the powers of the day, the American Revolution was one of those terrifying dominoes. King George III feared that if successful, the American Revolution might lead to erosion of the British Empire by the domino effect, one reason why the British clamped down harshly on the colonies as revolutionary sentiment was brewing. And after its success, the revolution deeply concerned the reactionary powers of Europe. The czar and Metternich feared that “the pernicious doctrines of republicanism and popular self-rule” spread by “the apostles of sedition” in the colonies that had cast off the British yoke might encourage similar “vicious principles” beyond.

A century after the czar and Metternich warned about the domino effect of republicanism, American leaders were expressing similar fears about Russia. Woodrow Wilson’s secretary of state Robert Lansing warned that if the Bolshevik disease were to spread, it would leave the “ignorant and incapable mass of humanity dominant in the earth.” The Bolsheviks were appealing “to the proletariat of all countries, to the ignorant and mentally deficient, who by their numbers are urged to become masters, … a very real danger in view of the process of social unrest throughout the world” (Gardner). President Wilson thought that it might already be happening. A notorious racist, he was concerned that the establishment of soldiers and workers councils in Germany would inspire dangerous

thoughts among “the American negro [soldiers] returning from abroad.” Already, he had heard, negro laundresses were demanding more than the going wage, saying that “money is as much mine as it is yours.” Among other disasters, Wilson feared that businessmen might have to adjust to having workers on their boards of directors if the Bolshevik virus were not exterminated (Gardner 1987).

The threat of Bolshevik appeals to the “ignorant and mentally deficient” working class was so dire that the US and other Western powers were entirely justified in invading Bolshevik Russia in self-defense against “the Revolution’s challenge … to the very survival of the capitalist order” (Gaddis 1987). That is the judgment of John Lewis Gaddis, the most highly regarded historian of the Cold War, which actually began in 1917, he argues, with the Bolshevik call for social reform and institutional change and the Western response in defense.

It was no less important to defend the civilized order against the popular enemy at home. Force must be used to prevent “the leaders of Bolshevism and anarchy” from trying to “organize or preach against government in the United States,” Lansing explained. The Wilson administration recognized the threat and launched the most severe repression in US history, which successfully undermined democratic politics, unions, freedom of the press, and independent thought, as usual, with the general approval of the media and elites, all in self-defense against the ignorant rabble. Much the same story was reenacted after World War II under the pretext of a communist threat, and a few years later once again as the civil rights movement and other miscreants threatened properly functioning democracy, matters to which we will return.

There’s nothing original about the regular resort to the domino theory in US post–World War II planning, in the international arena and at home. Viruses can indeed spread contagion.

I mentioned earlier the second modern democratic revolution, the one that should primarily concern us, particularly the formation of the Constitution. It’s worth some elaboration.

During the 1780s, there was an impressive level of activism, discussion, debate, and popular meetings. There was a very lively pamphlet literature, meetings, all kinds of groups and associations. And rebellions, including a major rebellion in Massachusetts, Shays’ Rebellion, in 1786 and ’87—farmers who were protesting economic injustice at about the time that the Constitutional Convention was meeting. The rebellion enhanced the concerns of the Framers about the dangers of democracy, and was part of the reason for the “Framers’ coup’’ that established the Constitution. The best source on these matters is the scholarly study by Michael Klarman, with that title (2016). It provides a very revealing record of the popular discussions, debates, and interchanges that were going on in the background, and also of what actually transpired at the Constitutional Convention.

The Framers themselves were comparatively wealthy, the elite. Poor farmers couldn’t make the long trek to Philadelphia and spend several months there; remember, there was almost no transportation. So fairly wealthy people from the thirteen colonies gathered in Philadelphia to revise the earlier Articles of Confederation, and found themselves, to the surprise of many, constructing a radically new political system with a strong federal structure that many feared and disliked. Almost thirteen; Rhode Island didn’t send any delegates, partly because of such concerns.

The discussions and the debates were sophisticated and impressive, fascinating reading. One of the main concerns all the way through was how to suppress popular pressures for liberty and democracy, all somewhat reminiscent of the first democratic revolution in England a century earlier, which established the English constitutional system in 1689, according sovereignty to Parliament.

The most influential of the Framers, James Madison, captured the dominant theme when he instructed the Convention that the government must “protect the minority of the opulent against the majority.” He presented an interesting argument, referring to England, which was the model that everybody had in mind not only because they were English but because it was the most democratic society of the day.

Madison observed that “in England at this day, if elections were open to all classes of people, the property of landed proprietors would be insecure. An agrarian law would soon take place”—meaning land reform, undermining the rights of property owners, not a tolerable outcome.

The problem Madison posed was an old one, tracing back to the first classic of political science, Aristotle’s Politics. Of the variety of systems he surveyed, Aristotle found democracy “the most tolerable,” though of course he had in

mind a limited democracy of free men, much as Madison did two thousand years later. Aristotle recognized the flaws of democracy, however, among them the one that Madison presented to the Convention. The poor "covet their neighbours' goods" and if wealth is narrowly concentrated, they will use their majority power to redistribute it more equitably, which would be unfair: "In democracies the rich should be spared; not only should their property not be divided, but their incomes too … should be protected…. Great then is the good fortune of a state in which the citizens have a moderate and sufficient property; for where some possess much, and others nothing, there may arise an extreme democracy" that does not recognize the rights of the rich, perhaps deteriorating to tyranny as democracy might in Aristotle's view—with unpleasant resonances today.

Aristotle and Madison posed essentially the same problem, but drew opposite conclusions. Madison's solution was to restrict democracy; Aristotle's, to reduce inequality by what amounted to welfare state programs. For democracy to function properly, Aristotle argued, "measures therefore should be taken which will give [all people] lasting prosperity [and] the proceeds of the public revenues should be accumulated and distributed among its poor" to enable them to "purchase a little farm, or, at any rate, make a beginning in trade or husbandry," along with other means, such as "common meals" with costs defrayed by "public land."

The issues remain alive, in many ways.

The Madisonian conception of the constitutional structure, which largely prevailed at the Convention, established the Senate as the most powerful branch of government, and the principle that it "ought to come from and represent the wealth of the nation," the "more capable sett [sic] of men." The Senate was not directly elected at the time, in fact not until 1913, when there was an amendment to elect senators by popular vote. The Senate was selected by the state legislatures, which it was assumed could be under elite control. Madison proposed other devices to limit democratic aspirations, including very large electoral districts, which would prevent people from assembling at a time when one could not easily travel very far. The public would therefore not have close supervision and control over their elected representatives, who would be free from popular pressures.

In defense of Madison's stand, we should recall that his mentality was precapitalist. He assumed that the people who would run the country, those who had the wealth of the nation, would be "enlightened gentlemen," people who have the good of the society at heart, not their own fortunes. They would be like the mostly mythical Roman noblemen who were an image for the Framers, even providing the names for the pseudonymous pamphlets of the intellectual elite.

Adam Smith had a sharper eye. As I quoted last time, he understood that the "masters of mankind," the merchants and manufacturers, would make sure that their own interests are cared for no matter how grievous the effect on others and would follow their vile maxim: all for ourselves, nothing for anyone else. Madison didn't see things this way at the time of the Convention, though it didn't take long for him to gain a more realistic understanding of the world. Already by 1792 he recognized that the Hamiltonian developmental capitalist state would be a social system "substituting the motive of private interest in place of public duty," leading to "a real domination of the few under an apparent liberty of the many." In a letter to Jefferson he deplored "the daring depravity of the times [as the] stockjobbers will become the pretorian band of the government—at once its tools and its tyrant; bribed by its largesses, and overawing it by clamors and combinations."

Not an unfamiliar picture.

One prominent issue in the debates at the Constitutional Convention was paper money. During the Revolutionary War, the individual states assumed enormous debts. They had to borrow to pay for the Continental Army and to keep their societies running. The debts were owned by rich men, often speculators, who wanted to be paid. The states were creating paper money, which devalued through time. The public favored that. They were the debtors and wanted the value of money to decline. One of the major issues throughout the Constitutional Convention was whether states should be permitted to print money, paper money, instead of gold and silver, the currency of the federal government. It was a major battle, a class issue: the debtors versus the creditors and speculators. The latter won. Article I of the Constitution bans paper money.

It's a complicated story, but in general it is fair to conclude that the Framers did manage to carry out an elite coup against the democratic aspirations of the general population. As Klarman concludes, the Constitution was a "conservative counterrevolution [against] excessive democracy" (2016). That is not a novel interpretation as he

points out, though he provides a much more detailed, nuanced, and substantiated account than anything that preceded.

The Framers were quite frank about the coup that they were implementing. The leading figures were Alexander Hamilton and James Madison. Hamilton explained that the Constitution was designed to be a "defense against depredations which the democratic spirit is apt to make on property," which, as was generally agreed, "is certainly the principle object of society." Madison elaborated in rich detail. The Constitution was designed to secure "the permanent interests of the country against innovation," the "permanent interests" being property rights, and innovation any threat to them. It was for that reason that effective power was to be placed in the hands of "the wealth of the nation," the "responsible men" who have sympathy for property and its rights and recognize that government must be "so constituted as to protect the minority of the opulent against the majority."

As explained succinctly by the president of the Continental Congress and first chief justice of the Supreme Court, John Jay, "The people who own the country ought to govern it."

The Convention had to deal with many other issues besides preventing excessive democracy. It had to deal with slavery, which was a huge issue; almost all of the leading figures were slave owners. It had to deal with a developing urban-rural conflict: the urban, mostly the wealthier manufacturing and commercial areas, versus the backcountry, where individual farmers lived. Also, the large states versus the small states, and quite a lot more.

It's an intriguing story. There are plenty of ramifications to the present. One of them is the radically undemocratic structure of the Senate, with inhabitants of small states having far greater voting power than those of the larger ones. That arrangement was a necessity. There was no other way that the small states would ratify the Constitution. A very serious matter today, to which we'll return.

All of our discussion so far has dealt with one aspect of government, political government, though class conflict lurks close to the surface. Political government is usually understood to exhaust the concept of government. But that's a conceptual error. There are also private governments alongside the formal government. An interesting book recently appeared about this topic by political philosopher Elizabeth Anderson, critiquing hegemonic common sense. You might want to take a look at it. It's very readable. Anderson discusses something we are all quite familiar with, but do not "see": the fact that in reality the great majority of the population is governed for most of their waking lives by private governments, more accurately, private tyrannies (2017).

When you rent yourself to some concentration of capital in the private sector—that's what taking a job is—you're giving your life over to a dictatorship, in fact, an extreme form of dictatorship that reaches far beyond political dictatorships. The tyranny to which you are handing yourself over to has almost total control over you. It controls every minute of your working day: what you wear and are allowed to say, when you're allowed to get a bathroom break, how your hands and legs move, whether you smoke cigarettes at home. Just about everything in your life is controlled by this extreme dictatorship, which goes far beyond any totalitarian dictatorship in the degree of control it exercises.

That raises some questions. One is whether a socioeconomic system is legitimate if it subjects people to extreme forms of tyranny for most of their lives. And that leads to the next question, whether the wage labor contract is itself legitimate. The argument in favor of legitimacy is that the contract is freely undertaken—in the sense of Anatole France's remark that the rich and poor are equally free to sleep under the bridge at night. In the real world, the contract is accepted under duress. You accept it or you starve, conditions exacerbated under increasing monopolization, as Marv discussed in our last session. There are very few options.

Even if there are options, questions arise about the legitimacy of a system in which people have to rent themselves to dictatorships to survive. Does such a system violate rights, inalienable rights of human beings, like the right not to be a slave, for example, or the right not to be property: to be a person, not property?

It's worth bearing in mind that the right not to be property was denied to women until quite recently. The founding constitutional system adopted British common law, in Blackstone's formulation, according to which a woman is not a person but property: the property of her father, later handed over to her husband. That lasted quite long, in some respects as late as 1975 when the Supreme Court finally determined that women are peers, not property. They have a right to serve on a federal jury.

Anderson draws an interesting analogy. She points out that in the political sphere, we regard Mussolini as a dictator even though people were free to emigrate, to leave Italy. It's rather like Friedman's concept of freedom: you're free to leave the job, so the enterprise that employs you is not a dictatorship. She also points out that we regarded Kremlin-run Eastern Europe as a dictatorship, even though people were free to go from one country to another. You could take a job in Poland or the Ukraine, very much as you can leave a job at GM and—if you're lucky—find one at Ford. Well, we didn't regard that as freedom.

The analogy to the private economic system is close, which again raises questions about the legitimacy of private governments. Actually, these questions are not new. They were central to the tradition of classical liberalism, which, Anderson argues, regarded wage labor as a violation of inalienable rights. That perspective lasted pretty much through the mid-nineteenth century, when the Industrial Revolution and capitalist hegemony fostered "common sense" of a sharply different kind.

In earlier days, advocacy of free markets was a progressive doctrine. It was upheld by the rascal multitude and the radicals of the English revolution. The idea was that free markets would eliminate hierarchy and subordination to authority. They would free people from autocratic systems, from state, church, landlords. Free markets would enable them to become self-employed, self-ruled. That was the ideal for John Locke, Adam Smith, Thomas Paine, Abraham Lincoln, other classical liberals.

All of that crashed with the Industrial Revolution of the nineteenth century. Everything changed, but it's very important to understand the classical liberal reasoning, which has considerable resonance right to today. Take Adam Smith again. All people have "an equal right to the earth," he held, and it's absurd to claim that land ownership should be restrained by "the fancy of those who died perhaps five hundred years ago." Great estates should be broken up and sold equitably.

Smith also gave an argument for markets. If free, he argued, they would tend toward equality. Commerce, manufacturing, small-scale enterprises, should be run by independent artisans and merchants. His model for efficient division of labor was a pin factory, with a handful of workers, who might participate in some ways in its governance.

Smith, as you know, did value division of labor. You've all heard about the butcher and the baker and so on—all enjoying self-rule. He's famous for that. But he's less famous for his harsh criticism of division of labor when the principle of self-rule is violated. In Wealth of Nations, he wrote that a person who keeps to repeated simple operations under division of labor becomes "as stupid and ignorant" as a person can possibly be, but that will be "the fate of the laboring poor" under a regime of division of labor for those who rent themselves to survive. It's a fate he said that must be prevented by government intervention in any civilized society. That's not exactly what you learn about Smith and division of labor in courses and texts.

Actually, in the standard scholarly edition of Wealth of Nations, the University of Chicago Bicentennial edition, this passage is not even cited in the index under "division of labor."

There's more to say about how Smith is generally interpreted, but I don't want to run too far over. Just take his most famous phrase, "invisible hand." Everybody's learned about the wonders of the invisible hand, but it's very unlikely you've learned how Smith used the phrase. Actually, he almost never did. He used it twice in any relevant context, once in Wealth of Nations, once in his second major book Moral Sentiments.

In Wealth of Nations he uses the phrase "invisible hand" in what in effect is an argument against neoliberal globalization. He observes that if the merchants and manufacturers of England imported from and invested in foreign countries, they might make more profit but it would be harmful to the people of England. Fortunately, however, they have a "home bias." Their concern about the people of England is such that they won't care about making more profit and will invest and purchase at home. So as if by an invisible hand, the people of England will be spared the ravages of what we now call neoliberal globalization. The other major founder of modern economics, David Ricardo, was even more outspoken about this. He's famous for the theory of comparative advantage, but he wrote that he hoped that the merchants and manufacturers of England wouldn't follow it but would instead be concerned with their own people.

The other example of Smith's use of the phrase "invisible hand" is in an interesting argument in Moral Sentiments.

England was then, of course, mostly an agrarian society. He considers the possibility that one landowner would obtain almost all the land, a sharp concentration of wealth. Smith argues that it won't matter much. Because of his sympathy with other people (whatever its roots), he would divide his wealth in such a way that as if by an invisible hand, its distribution will be relatively egalitarian.

That's the totality of Smith's relevant use of the phrase.

The idea that wage labor is basically a form of slavery and becomes tolerable only if temporary, lasting only until you become independent, was widely held well into the mid-nineteenth century. Abraham Lincoln, for example, was a strong advocate of that position. In fact, it was a slogan of his Republican Party. Wage labor was regarded as essentially the same as chattel slavery except insofar as it's temporary, a step toward freedom. The ideal is self-rule. Other contributors to the classical liberal canon went much further.

More significant, similar ideas were upheld by working people in the early Industrial Revolution. In the United States in the nineteenth century, in the early days of the Industrial Revolution in eastern Massachusetts, there was a lively labor press written, edited, and produced by the men and women who worked in the factories. Many were women, called "factory girls," young women coming from the farms to work in the mills. Their writings are very interesting. There's good work about them, the first major work on American labor history, by Norman Ware (1924). The original documents are available in a publication edited by Philip Foner.

The independent labor press condemned what it called "the blasting influence of monarchical principles on democratic soil." Working people recognized that the assault on elementary human rights in the capitalist industrial system, including wage labor, will not be overcome until "they who work in the mills [will] own them" and sovereignty will return to free producers. Then working people will no longer be "menials or the humble subjects of the foreign despot," the absentee owners, "slaves in the strictest sense of the word [who] toil … for their masters." Rather, they'll regain their status as "free American citizens." The Knights of Labor, the first major labor organization, had essentially the same ideas.

The capitalist Industrial Revolution instituted a crucial change from price to wage. When the producer sold his product for a price, Ware writes, "he retained his person. But when he came to sell his labor, he sold himself," and lost his dignity as a person as he became a slave—a "wage slave," the term commonly used (1924). Working people in New England implicitly adopted the insight of the great humanist Wilhelm von Humboldt, the founder of the modern research university, that if an artisan produces a beautiful work on command, "we may admire what he did but we despise what he is"—a slave in all but name, not a free human being.

In the late nineteenth century, a populist movement developed. It was nothing like what's now called populism. It was a major popular movement of independent farmers, starting in Texas and spreading to Kansas and most of the Midwest. Farmers wanted to free themselves from the control of Northeastern bankers who lent them money to plant and then gouged them to pay it back. They established and ran their own cooperative enterprises for banking and marketing. For a time, it seemed as if the Knights of Labor and the agrarian populists might unite, bringing about a real radical democratic revolution. But it was not to be. Both the workers' and farmers' movements were beaten down with plenty of state-corporate violence.

The US has an unusually violent labor history, well into the twentieth century. Labor historian David Montgomery writes that "Modern America had been created over its workers' protests, even though every step in its formation had been influenced by the activities, organizations, and proposals that had sprung from working class life" (1989), not to speak of the hands and brains of those who actually did the work.

Ware reports the thinking of skilled workers in New York 175 years ago, who repeated the common view that a daily wage is a form of slavery but warned that a day might come when wage slaves "will so far forget what is due to manhood as to glory in a system forced on them by their necessity and in opposition to their feelings of independence and self-respect" (1924). They hoped that that day would be "far distant."

It's taken a long time to beat the ideas of workers and farmers out of people's heads, but they do keep breaking through, including recent strikes that we'll come back to. The demand for independence, self-respect, personal dignity, and control of one's own work and life, like Marx's old mole, continues to burrow not far from the surface, ready to reappear when awakened by circumstances and militant activism.

One way in which it's breaking through right now is the idea that workers should have a voice in the governance of enterprises, apparently a very widely held belief according to recent polls. Thanks largely to the remarkable success of the Bernie Sanders campaigns, these ideas are reaching the political arena. Elizabeth Warren introduced legislation requiring that in large corporations, workers should elect 40 percent of the members of the board of directors. Something similar has existed for a long time in Germany, a system called codetermination.

But then the question is why stop there? Why not go back to the belief of American workers in the early days of the Industrial Revolution that those who work in the mills should own and manage them? In fact, that's happening in the old Rust Belt and other places, with very important efforts to develop worker-owned, worker-managed enterprises, cooperatives, and other forms of mutual aid. There's important work on these initiatives particularly by Gar Alperovitz.

There are quite successful models along these lines. The most famous is in the Basque country in Spain, Mondragón, a substantial enterprise that's been flourishing for sixty years, including manufacturing and banks, housing, hospitals —all worker-owned. In the last decade, Mondragon's been linking up with the US Steelworkers Union to try to form worker-owned cooperatives in the United States and Canada. Very important, and not as well known as it should be, is the Landless Workers Movement (MST) in Brazil, arguably the largest popular movement in the world, poor farmers who take over unused lands and have developed an extensive network of self-managed and often flourishing cooperatives. They received some support from the progressive government of Lula da Silva, who is now the most important political prisoner in the world. The likely winner of the 2018 elections, he was blocked by an ongoing right-wing coup that jailed him right before the elections on highly dubious charges and barred him from making any public statements. Under the harsh and repressive far-right government of Jair Bolsonaro, the MST is under severe threat, but it has sunk deep roots.b

All of these and many other initiatives are ways to follow the advice of the anarchist pioneer Mikhail Bakunin, who urged that activists should create the germs of a future society within the present one.

a As ofJune 2020, the unemployment rate was at approximately 11 percent, a decline from an earlier peak of 14 percent due to the Covid-19 pandemic. (See Afterword for additional analysis.)b Lula da Silva was released from prison, pending the outcome of his various legal appeals, in November 2019.Chapter 3

CAPITALISM AND MILITARISM

Waterstone Lecture, January 29, 2019

Tonight's topic is the set of relationships, multiple and complicated, between capitalism and militarism. I want to think very carefully about some of the essential qualities of capitalism historically and contemporaneously in terms of the way in which it's related to militarism, colonialism, and conquest.

I'm going to start by drawing on some material from Andrew Bard Schmookler's book The Parable of the Tribes, which came out in the early 1980s. In the book, he is assessing underlying conditions for either peace or conflict among groups, and it will help us understand some of the dynamics involved in tonight's topic. He begins this assessment by inviting readers to "imagine that there is a group of tribes living within reach of each other. If all choose the way of peace, they all may live in peace. But what if," he asks, "all but one choose peace and that one is ambitious in some ways for expansion and conquest." He's setting this up as a way to think about what are the possible reactions to this situation.

He lays out four possible responses. The first is, if there is sufficient space, the groups that are threatened by the aggressor can simply withdraw. They can move out of that sphere, if that's possible. Again, it depends on whether or not there's any place to withdraw to. A second possibility is destruction of subordinate groups by the aggressor. This occurs when the subordinate groups, or the weaker groups, have something that the aggressor wants but the aggressor doesn't want those populations, simply wants what they have, so destruction is a possibility.

A third possibility is when the weaker groups have something that the aggressor wants, but when the aggressor also is interested in the population in some way, and so therefore engages in activities that result in some degree of absorption but certainly some degree of subjugation. This is a third possibility. The fourth possibility is the idea of resistance, that is a group can resist the aggression, but as Schmookler makes clear, that resistance is already an acknowledgment of the relationships of power, and has to occur in some form through some kind of emulation or imitation of the aggressor's behavior.

As Schmookler concludes, in every one of these outcomes, the ways of power are spread throughout the system, and this is what he calls the parable of the tribes. Now, you might imagine that there might be other permutations of this, but this is a good heuristic for thinking a little bit about how power operates in the world. So, a few concluding remarks. In the first three outcomes, the ways of power spread when the mighty expand into areas where the weak have been. If one society in the system develops an important competitive advantage, its neighbors lose the option of continuing their prior way of living. They could either adapt to that new innovation and in some way compete, or they can be, as I said, either subjugated or destroyed.

The course of resistance, that is the fourth response, also requires transformation in the ways of power. It requires the imitation of one's more potent foes. The tyranny of power is such that even self-defense becomes a kind of surrender if one is interested only in peace. Again, these are conclusions from Schmookler. Not to resist is to be transformed or destroyed at the hands of the mighty, and to resist requires that one transform oneself into their likeness. This is the argument that Schmookler puts out. This will become relevant as we move forward. But either way, as he concludes, free human choice is prevented. All ways but the ways of power are blocked once power is unleashed in the world. This is the argument that Schmookler is making, and I'll return to this a couple of times as we think about some specific cases, both historical and contemporary.

Clearly, militarism, imperialism, and colonialism predate capitalism. There have been numerous empires throughout history. There was the age of exploration, which might also be thought of, I think quite legitimately, as the age of extermination around the globe. These activities have most often involved a search for resources, for markets of various kinds, and for labor, often slaves. The endeavors have often been aided by, and in turn have stimulated, changes in both transport and communication over time. Military might has historically provided protection for trade and mercantilism. Even before the capitalist era, we have a lot of adventures around the globe.

Let's now think about how we might explain this, particularly as we begin to move into the capitalist mode of production. In the Communist Manifesto, Marx and Engels said:

The need of a constantly expanding market for its products chases the bourgeoisie over the whole surface of the globe. It must nestle everywhere, settle everywhere, establish connections everywhere. All old established national industries have been dislodged by industries that no longer work up indigenous raw material but raw material drawn from the remotest zones. Industries whose products are consumed not only at home but in every quarter of the globe. In place of the old ones satisfied by the productions of the country, we find new ones requiring for their satisfaction. The products of distant lands and climes. (Marx and Engels 1848)

In 1848, this system was hardly underway, really. In that period, Marx and Engels were already foreseeing what we now think about as a kind of globalized capitalism.

According to Lenin (in Imperialism: The Highest Stage of Capitalism, 1916–1917), an adequate definition of modern imperialism needs to embrace five essential features. The first is when "the concentration and production of capital develops to such a high stage that it creates monopolies which play a decisive role in the economic life." We have already talked a little bit about why monopolies become such a favored form.

The second condition is "the merging of bank capital with industrial capital and the creation on the basis of this finance capital of a financial oligarchy" (1916–1917). Remember, Lenin is actually writing at the very turn of the twentieth century, so this is, again, still quite early on.

The third feature of imperialism is the "export of capital as distinguished from the export of commodities," which becomes extremely important (1916–1917). I'll talk about this a bit later on. Rather than simply moving commodities from place to place, capital was looking for places to realize itself and to valorize itself and, in fact, to foster maximum accumulation.

The fourth condition is when we see the "formation of international capitalist monopolies, which share the world among themselves." And finally, "the territorial division of the whole world amongst the greatest capitalist powers is completed." Again, recall that Lenin was writing this in 1916 and 1917.

Hannah Arendt, contrary to Lenin, called the imperialism that arose toward the end of the nineteenth century the first stage in the political rule of the bourgeoisie rather than the last or highest stage of capitalism. She saw this as a new set of phenomena basically.

There are three periods in this evolving relationship between capitalism and militarism (in its various forms) that I want to cover. The first is a period from 1870 roughly. These are not finite, precise dates but roughly 1870 to 1945, which we can think about as bourgeois imperialism. Second is a period from 1945 to 1970, so immediately post–World War II, when the US began to consolidate its domination (military and economic) over the globe.

The final period, 1970 to 2008 and beyond, neoliberal hegemony, where different forms of domination begin to take center stage. This entails some shifting of emphasis from overtly or exclusively military interventions to the use of varying kinds of financial instruments to exert control over others. But since the threat of military means constantly lurks just under the surface, we might think about this period as the iron fist in the velvet glove. As we'll discuss in more detail in a couple of weeks, since 2008 the gloves are coming back off.

Some of this explanation is based on the very cogent analysis that David Harvey provides in The New Imperialism (2003), a book that I'd recommend highly to people who are interested.

During these periods, the US and the European cases are a bit different. I'll speak about them a bit separately but then bring them back together. Let's think, first of all, about this period, 1870 to 1945, which is called bourgeois imperialism, and let's speak about the European case first.

One of the first major crises of capital overaccumulation, meaning surplus capital with no means to valorize itself—that is, no investment opportunities that were sufficient to entice capitalists—was a European economic collapse from 1846 to 1850. So very early on, capitalists started to experience these kinds of crises. The temporary way out of this crisis was twofold. That is, there were two main venues available for capitalists looking for places to invest, to be able to accumulate surplus value and profit. One of these was internal (i.e., domestic) investments in vast infrastructure projects in transportation, water, and sewage, housing. This is, for example, when Georges-Eugène Haussmann redesigned Paris. There are all these domestic projects where capital could be invested and a return on

capital could be developed. Most of these, of course, involved the cooperation of the state.

The second investment opportunity was outward geographic expansion of capital investment focused in large part on the Atlantic trade, with the US playing a very important role in absorbing some surplus capital. We've thought about this a little bit already, in terms of capital flight when possible.

However, the declining ability to absorb excess capital in internal projects (i.e., these kinds of infrastructure projects) and the interruption of the Atlantic trade by the US Civil War limited the capacity of these mechanisms to solve the crisis. This failure, in turn, produced an enormous wave of international financial speculation and geographically expanded trade on the part of European (and also US) capitalists.

Because these kinds of activities need a safe and secure environment, capitalists required that their nation-states develop a geopolitical rationale for aiding them (militarily if necessary) in opening up new areas and for protecting investment. In other words, capital has a logic that is dictated by its need to maximize profit and return, but that's not always matched by the logic of the state. In this situation, capital needed states to develop a geopolitical logic to accompany its own expansionist logic. But this presented a contradiction that needed to be resolved. Nation-states, which had proliferated in Europe from the mid-1600s onward, had been built primarily on the idea of internal solidarity and sovereignty rather than on foreign engagement. In fact, in large measure, that's what a state is. It's a relatively homogeneous inside population, and separated from a differentiated and heterogeneous outside.

The two logics did not really match up. If capital wants or needs to roam the globe looking for investment opportunity, and it requires the protections that states provide, states at that point didn't really have the rationale to justify these foreign engagements. How then, as Harvey and other analysts have put it, could the problem of overaccumulation and the necessity for a global spatiotemporal fix (i.e., new and different areas for investment and profit seeking—what Harvey means by a fix) find an adequate political response through the mechanism of the nation-state?

This is a problem. In other words, how could national solidarity (up to that point, based largely on internal cohesion) justify foreign adventure? Let's put it briefly. The answer was the mobilization (which is now, I would suggest, more resonant than ever) of nationalism, patriotism, jingoism, and racism to justify such foreign adventures and to legitimate what becomes known as accumulation through dispossession (which I talked about last time when I talked about primitive accumulation). This is another framing of it.

This is one of the ways in which these foreign engagements could be justified. Perfectly reasonable, it was argued, to conquer and exploit the barbarians and inferior peoples who could not put their resources to their highest and best uses. This is a paraphrase of a philosophical position from John Locke.

This launched a brutal period of competing racist-based national imperialisms, colonizations, and conquests by the British, French, Dutch, Germans, Belgians, Japanese, and Italians. These adventures were further justified by emerging social Darwinian ideas of the white man's burden. This is the way in which these two logics (capital and state) were brought together.

The underlying contradictions between nationalisms and imperialisms could not be resolved, however, and this resulted in more than fifty years of clashes between nation-states, just as Lenin had predicted. Eventually, all of this devolved into a carving up of the globe into separate spheres of control or influence exemplified, for example, by the grab for Africa. Toward the end of the 1890s, Africa had been only 10 percent colonized. By 1914, it was 90 percent colonized. So just within a couple of decades, we can see the ways in which capital, looking for investment or resources and so forth, began to divide the globe up for itself.

This competition resulted in divisions resulting from the Versailles Treaty after World War I, including arbitrary divisions of the Middle East into newly formed states ruled over largely by Britain and France. We're still living with some of the results of these actions today. That is, many of the countries that constitute the current Middle East were whole-cloth creations that were produced after the Treaty of Versailles, which divided the region up among the reigning powers and often contradicted longstanding historical arrangements.

As violent and racist as all this imperialism and conquest was, it never adequately resolved the problems of surplus capital. This eventually produced the Great Depression of '30s, which was worldwide and underpinned the

catastrophe that was World War II. The same clashes keep coming back, and they're still not resolved.

Now, let me speak a bit about the US case, which is somewhat different, but results in very similar kinds of outcomes in some ways. First of all, the US was bourgeois from the outset. That is, there was no need to overthrow older forms of aristocratic or feudal power. The government represented industrial and upper-class interests, and so was opposed from the beginning to any threats to private property rights or profit maximization.

Secondly, the US was already a multiethnic, immigrant population. Appeals to homogeneous nationalism had to be constructed against non-Caucasians. Of course, the concept or category of "whiteness" is itself an ever-evolving category. So non-Caucasian was a moving target, and the unifying animosity eventually had to be directed against outside others. Historian Richard Hofstadter has characterized this ongoing feature of US politics as the paranoid style, the perennial fear of outside others. And this, we will see, comes back repeatedly to haunt the geopolitics of the US.

Finally, the US, unlike Europe, had enormous possibilities for internal geographic expansion once the inconvenient indigenous population was removed. This was, again, something quite different than the European case with its extensive external colonies. Although there were periods of actual overseas geographic expansion, notably at the end of the nineteenth century and then during the so-called Spanish-American War, when the US did acquire a number of overseas territories. Again, we're living with some of the results still.

The US began to cover its expansions and occupations under the notion of "spreading American values." Seen, of course, as noble and universal and eventually being termed globalization. Rather than conquering territory, as the European nations tended to do, the US was more about spreading democracy, so called.

Now, let's move to this second period, which is 1945 to 1970, so after World War II. In addition to a new phase of imperialism and militarism, this period also produced a number of very significant internal changes to the US and subsequently to the global economy.

The US emerged from World War II as by far the most technologically, economically, and militarily superior nation on earth. The other combatants, whether in the European or Pacific war, were largely devastated. The US's nearest competitor, the Soviet Union, had borne the brunt of the fight against Nazi Germany with enormous losses to both its population and to its productive capacity.

The Allies, interestingly enough, toward the end of World War II, delayed opening a second front in Europe to aid the Soviets, who were fighting the Germans on the Eastern front. The Allies didn't really move heavily in that direction. This inaction may have been a deliberate strategy to weaken Stalin. But one consequence of the delay was that it allowed the Soviets to accumulate and then to keep territory in Eastern Europe, and this becomes very, very important in the postwar, and subsequent Cold War, period.

These Soviet territorial gains and competing military power, combined with the Soviet anti-capitalist ideology that had long grated on US elites, bumped up against the US paranoid style to help produce and sustain the Cold War. The animosities were longstanding. In fact, the US invaded Russia in 1919, two years after the revolutions there, to thwart them, but failed to do so. We had no diplomatic relations with the Soviet Union until 1935. And the alliance between the US, the UK, France, and the USSR during World War II was quickly breaking down.

As a side note and example of this breakdown, Winston Churchill, shortly after the end of hostilities in World War II, gave this very famous speech called the "Sinews of Peace." An interesting kind of juxtaposition: "Sinews of Peace." Anyway, Churchill gave this speech in 1946. I'm just going to refer to it briefly because it has some very interesting elements that carry through basically to the present day.

First of all, he calls attention to what he calls the twin dangers of war and tyranny. "We cannot be blind to the fact that the liberties enjoyed by individual citizens throughout the British Empire are not valid in a considerable number of countries, some of which are very powerful." Interesting at that moment when much of the British Empire still consisted of colonies that were thoroughly and completely repressed by British rule.

In these states, controls enforced upon the common people by various kinds of all-embracing police governments. The power of the state is exercised without restraint either by dictators or by compact oligarchies operating through

a privileged party in a political police…. It is not our duty at this time when difficulties are so numerous to interfere forcibly in the internal affairs of countries which we have not conquered in war. [That's an interesting exception.] But, we must never cease to proclaim in fearless tones the great principles of freedom and the rights of man which are the joint inheritance of the English-speaking world and which through Magna Carta, the Bill of Rights, the habeas corpus, trial by jury and the English common law find their most famous expressions in the American Declaration of Independence. (1946)

These are all quotes from this "Sinews of Peace" speech. The speech also contains the first use of the phrase the "Iron Curtain":

From Stetten in the Baltic, to Trieste and the Adriatic, an Iron Curtain has descended across the continent. Behind that line lie all the capitals of the ancient states of Central and Eastern Europe. Warsaw, Berlin, Prague, Vienna, Budapest, Belgrade, Bucharest and Sofia. All these famous cities and the populations around them lie in what I must call the Soviet sphere, and all are subject in one form or another not only to Soviet influence but to a very high, and in many cases increasing, measure of control from Moscow. Athens alone—Greece with its immortal glories—is free to decide its future at an election under British, American and French observation. (1946)

This is an interesting exception at the end here. I would say that the activities went well beyond observation. In fact, the US and the UK rigged and destabilized the elections, and dislodged what was an incipient leftist, mildly leftist, kind of government structure.

But in any event, we'll let Winston continue for a minute. He also, in his speech, evokes a special relationship between the US and the UK and the English-speaking people of the world.

In a great number of countries far from the Russian frontiers and throughout the world, communist fifth columns are established and work in complete unity and absolute obedience to the directions they receive from the communist center. Except in the British Commonwealth and in the United States where communism is in its infancy [which was actually not true; it was in its death throes through deliberate subversion and extinction], the Communist Party's fifth columns constitute a growing challenge and peril to Christian civilization (1946).

Remember, this is one year after Britain was an ally of the Soviet Union, all of that rhetoric. Immediately thereafter, we have this antagonism.

One other very significant matter is related to this evolving East/West antagonism. Somewhat controversial, but now mostly settled by historians. The use of the atomic bombs in Japan have clearly now been shown to have been militarily unnecessary. Japan would have surrendered. In fact, it sued for peace without an invasion or the bombs. The bombs were dropped in the Pacific War before the Soviets could enter it and possibly acquire more territory in Asia as well as to keep Russia from assisting Mao in the civil war in China (which I'll come back to in a moment). Finally, they were dropped to keep the Soviets "more manageable," as President Truman put it at the time.

This anti-Soviet, anti-communism stance translated into the US foreign policy of containment and encirclement of the Soviet Union. I want to turn now to National Security Council (NSC) Memorandum 68. This was sort of the defining blueprint for how to deal with the world geopolitics following World War II. Most importantly, of course, our relationship with the Soviet Union.

It represents the culmination of a kind of battle of philosophies that can be emblematized by these two figures. One, George Kennan, and the other, Paul Nitze. Immediately after World War II or during World War II and its immediate aftermath, George Kennan's views of containment, which were really a quite passive kind of containment, held sway within US foreign policy circles.

Shortly thereafter, Nitze moved into the foreground and was the key author of NSC 68. He had a very different view of things like nuclear issues and the arms race. He thought that rather than simply passive containment, we should be engaged in an actual, very confrontational engagement with the Soviets everywhere and anywhere that we could. That we should in fact engage them because we had so many more resources and so forth in a kind of arms race, which they would ultimately lose and we would, in fact, come out as much more predominant.

Nitze was a master at two kinds of tactics typically. One, the very scary security memo, of which NSC 68 was a key

example. The other, which I'll talk about in a second, was the production of very, very supportive committees and lobby committees to get those policies pushed forward.

One of the things that was in the NSC 68 memo was the invocation of the Chinese revolution. Then a bit later, the advent of the Korean War and, particularly, the intervention in that war by the Chinese. These were mobilized as extremely alarming kinds of movements forward of the Communist front.

The memo that circulated and, in fact, was taken up as the guiding policy document of this period, had almost immediate effects. Military spending increased by 458 percent between 1951 and 1952. This is rather enormous. In virtually all other previous wars, we demobilized after the war was over. In this case, this set in motion the idea of a constantly evolving military budget. Military personnel increased from 2.2 to over 5 million, so the memo was extremely effective.

In the name of anti-communism and the spread of freedom (usually meaning free markets and the rights of private property), following the Nitze Doctrine, the US bolstered friendly regimes through military aid, trade arrangements, credit, and so forth and opposed or toppled regimes through military confrontation, covert actions, interference in internal politics, regime change, assassination, trade and financial sanctions, and so on. Often using either UN or other military alliances, for example, NATO, as "coalitions of the willing" to cover otherwise unilateral actions. I need not enumerate all of these, but I'll have a few more words about them in just a minute.

At home in the US, this paranoid style of politics meant virulent anti-communist, anti-socialist, anti-trade union, anti-leftist repression. This is how this translated to the domestic scene. McCarthyism, which was overt repression, FBI infiltration, subversion, and assassinations, though often covert, was legitimated as necessary for national security in the face of the Soviet and international communist threat.

Interestingly enough, those of you who have been following the news in the last few days have seen the reemergence of the name Roy M. Cohn, who was the advisor to Joseph McCarthy but also was the advisor early on and mentor to both Donald Trump and to Roger Stone. These things keep coming back around.

Whenever there was a conflict between democracy and order, defined as the protection of elites in capital accumulation, the US came down on the side of the latter. This 1945–1970 period also gave rise to the military-industrial complex (MIC), and the related speech by Dwight Eisenhower warning of the incipient power of the MIC and its ongoing control and influence of US economic and military policy.

To generate profits in that sector, there must be continual and expanding arms sales and therefore the constant proliferation of enemies. In addition to building the power of the MIC economically and politically, this has contributed to the ongoing and dangerous militarization of the planet, including proliferation of nuclear weapons. We can see this ongoing. I'll say more about this in just a minute.

Brief update from the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute. Total arms sales in 2017, and this is just from the top one hundred arms companies. Nearly $400 billion, and the US share of that is nearly 60 percent. I'll say more about these figures in a minute.

The second stage ended around 1970 for several reasons. The costs to contain communism were higher than had been anticipated. The Vietnam War costs kept escalating in every dimension. Lives lost, blood and treasure. Not too much concern for what happened over there. These military costs clashed with the ability to satisfy growing consumerism; a guns-versus-butter issue. To deal with these problems, the US began printing money, which led to a worldwide inflation and the collapse of the Bretton Woods system, which we'll discuss again in the week after next.

At this point, the Nixon administration abandoned the gold standard, which had been in place prior to this, and this led to a whole number of problems that we'll also think about in detail in a couple weeks.

Here's a little side note to connect a few dots. I had said that one of the things that Paul Nitze was very, very good at, in addition to writing these threat memos, these scare memos, was to produce these groups that would then lobby on behalf of those policies. One of the first of these that he was involved in, he wasn't the only one who organized this, was something called the Committee on the Present Danger, which I'm calling Committee on the Present Danger 1.0, which pushed to adopt NSC 68 to prevent another Korea. That was their main rationale, that's what they

were pushing on Nitze's policies.

In the 1970s, Paul Nitze and a number of other people formed another Committee on the Present Danger. It deliberately took the name of the first one, but I'm calling this 2.0. There's now a 3.0, by the way. This included an enormous cast of neocon characters that eventually populated the Reagan administration.

In the 1980s, this group was responsible for many of the atrocities and crimes in Latin America, including the Iran-Contra scandal and so forth. I just put this up here now because just this last week, this character reemerged, Elliott Abrams. If you've been following his career, you might have thought he was a little less active, but he was involved in Iran-Contra. In fact, he was convicted of lying to Congress. He was then pardoned by George H. W. Bush. I put William Barr's name up here, who is the nominee [now confirmed] for attorney general, who presided over Elliott Abrams and five other Iran-Contra convicts' pardons. This stuff comes back around.

This quite clearly ties to issues that are live this week in terms of what's happening in Venezuela. I'm not going to say very much about it, but I'll say just a word or two about it in a minute. The idea that the same cast of characters using the same kinds of rationales has in fact fomented an enormous amount of chaos and disruption in this hemisphere and elsewhere.

Now, the third period, 1970 to 2008 approximately. The year 2008 with the financial crash moves us into a slightly different phase, again, that we'll talk about in a couple weeks. The US moves to a different form of imperialism, which we can think about as neoliberal hegemony.

Still plenty of military adventures, so all through the period 1970 and on up. We've been at war basically since I would say 1776, roughly without interruption. Even in this most recent period that we're considering, there were still plenty of military adventures, but now the US began more dominantly using financial institutions to achieve similar ends. The IMF, the World Bank, the World Trade Organization, NAFTA, many other multi-and bilateral trade arrangements to force open financial markets around the world and continue to exercise US dominance.

I posted a piece by Joy Powers, "Off Target: How U.S. Sanctions Are Crippling Venezuela," talking about the Venezuela situation and financial and economic terms that I hope you'll take a look at. Setting in motion a set of policies that have literally hamstrung the Venezuelan government. It can barely govern because of the kinds of tight constrictions that have been placed upon it, including the ones that have been put in place just in the last day, the Venezuelan oil company. This is an enormous set of constraints and constrictions and underpins much of the unrest that we see on the streets of Venezuela.

One key factor during this period in terms of militarism was the end of the Cold War accompanying the fall of the Soviet Union, beginning with the Berlin Wall coming down in 1989 (at that point, we were against walls), and the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991.

Among other things, that factor meant a need to find a replacement enemy to keep the military-industrial complex in business. Once the Soviet Union fell, this was a little bit of a problem. There was even some talk of something like a peace dividend. Once we didn't really have an enemy, maybe we could start spending these untold millions and billions at home, but that quickly evaporated.

Basically, what we did, we found a new enemy. The global war on terror is the perfect enemy. In fact, it's better than a state-based adversary. It can never really be defeated, but it can (in fact, must) be continually fought.

This period is what Michael Ignatieff in Prospect Magazine called "Empire Lite." It's got a nice ring to it. It sounds good. Says Ignatieff, the new US Empire

is not like the empires of times past, built on colonies, conquest and the white man's burden. We're no longer in the era of the United Fruit Company [another interesting choice given what happened in Guatemala in this period], when American corporations needed the Marines to secure their investment overseas. 21st-century imperium is a new invention in the annals of political science, an Empire Lite. A global hegemony whose grace notes are free markets, human rights and democracy enforced by the most awesome military power the world has ever known. (2003)

“Lite” right until you need something heavier, in other words, “the most awesome military power the world has ever known.” In fact, just for the record, and contrary to these claims, Ignatieff’s New York Times colleague, Thomas Friedman, openly proclaimed in his column, March 28, 1999, at the time of the bombing of Yugoslavia, that it takes the military contractor McDonnell Douglas to ensure the safety of McDonald’s around the world. Slightly different view of Empire Lite.

Now, I want to start thinking a little bit about the consequences of all of this kind of imperialism. We’ll leave aside for the moment the European case and just concentrate on the US for now, but we’ll come back to the European case the week after this.

William Blum, who died in December 2018, was an incredibly interesting activist, analyst, and had some things to say about US interventions, principally in a publication called Third World Traveler:

The engine of American foreign policy has been fueled not by a devotion to any kind of morality but rather by the necessity to serve other imperatives, which can be summarized as follows: Making the world safe for American corporations. Enhancing the financial statements of defense contractors at home who have contributed generously to members of Congress. Preventing the rise of any society that might serve as a successful example of an alternative to the capitalist model. Extending political and economic hegemony over as wide an area as possible as benefits or befits a great power. This in the name of fighting a supposed moral crusade against what Cold warriors convinced themselves and the American people was the existence of an evil international communist conspiracy, which in fact never existed, evil or not. (1999)

Finally, the United States carried out extremely serious interventions into more than seventy nations in this period, and we’re still very busy. This captures, I think, Hofstadter’s notion of the paranoid style. Although John Ehrlichman under Richard Nixon made the famous comment that even paranoids have real enemies sometimes, that wasn’t the case here.

Let’s now consider some of the other consequences of US imperialism, for example, lives lost. Estimating these kinds of numbers is extremely difficult. It’s difficult partly in terms of the analytics, how to count direct and indirect fatalities, but the source that I’m using (Lucas 2020 [2015]) actually makes an attempt to do this, and it specifies very clearly the methodology that it used, with which you can agree or disagree, but it gives you some interesting kind of outer boundary of this.

In this worst-case scenario, and they described this as a worst-case scenario, the US has killed more than 20 million people in thirty-seven victim nations since World War II. Even if they’re off by a factor of 10, an order of magnitude, this is still an enormous number of fatalities. This is a quote from this study:

The causes of wars are complex. In some instances, nations other than the US may have been responsible for more deaths, but if the involvement of our nation appeared to have been a necessary cause of a war or conflict, it was considered responsible for the deaths in it. In other words, they probably would not have taken place if the US had not used the heavy hand of its power. The military and economic power of the United States was crucial. (Lucas)

Another consequence of US imperialism, the proliferation of US bases. People are just not aware of this. It doesn’t get covered very much. The definition of what constitutes a base is also very difficult to pin down, but again, this is the sort of best estimate. This is according to Dave Vine, who was writing in The Nation in 2015, but this has just been updated:

While there are no freestanding form bases permanently located in the United States, there are now around 800 US bases in foreign countries. Seventy years after World War II and 62 years after the Korean War, there are still 174 US “base sites” in Germany, 113 in Japan and 83 in South Korea, according to the Pentagon. Hundreds more dot the planet in around 80 countries…. Although few Americans realize that the United States likely has more bases in foreign lands than any other people, nation or empire in history.

Rarely does anyone ask if we need hundreds of bases overseas or if at an estimated annual cost of perhaps $156 billion or more, the United States can afford them. Again, this doesn’t really come up very much in conversation, but is an existential fact.

Rarely does anyone wonder how we would feel if China, Russia or Iran built even a single base anywhere near our borders, let alone in the United States. (2015)

The presumption behind these installations is itself very interesting. That the US has a largely undisputed right (as the indispensable nation) to install these anywhere, while the notion of another country doing so is largely unthinkable. Well, there was one interesting counter-case. This was reported in Reuters in 2007:

Ecuador wants a military base in Miami. In fact, Rafael Correa said Washington must let him open a military base in Miami if the United States wants to keep using an airbase [the Manta base] on Ecuador's Pacific Coast.

Well, have you seen Ecuador's base in Miami? Okay. It didn't really get there, but the Manta base did close. You could see how preposterous this seems that we would even begin to entertain the idea that another country might install a base here. Just not possible.

Finally, the cost of the bases, in addition to the economic costs that I already mentioned, about $156 or $157 billion annually. There's also a human toll exacted by these activities. There's a tremendous strain on military families. There's an enormous amount of sexual violence around US military bases. There is a tremendous amount of environmental damage in the host area from the bases and so forth.

They also become targets of anti-American activity and animosity, just the emplacement of them. For example, the US military presence in Saudi Arabia was an overtly stated motive that Osama bin Laden gave for the 9/11 attacks. There was an installation of the barbarians in the Holy Land.

These emplacements also make foreign wars more thinkable, and thus make the world more dangerous. That is, as we have people positioned in place, we think about a military solution to a particular kind of issue.

Finally, I urge you to look at this report and then an update, a very good update, by Nick Turse, entitled "Bases, Bases, Everywhere…Except in the Pentagon's Report."

In addition to the factors I've just discussed, there are also the extravagant monetary costs of militarism. US military spending is higher now than at any time other than the height of the Iraq War, adjusted for inflation. The 2019 budget is $716 billion. That's just the amount shown on the books.

According to the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute, the US outpaces all other nations in military expenditures. World military spending totaled more than $1.74 trillion in 2017 and was up 1 percent from the previous year. The US accounted for 35 percent of that total.

US military expenditures are roughly the size of the next eight largest military budgets around the world. A recent article on "overmatch" by Michael Klare indicates that we have now diverged from simple containment, which was the policy basically post–World War II, to now being the preeminent power everywhere all the time, and whatever it takes to achieve that in terms of blood and treasure, we will apparently expend. By we, I mean you and I. Remember, this is taxpayer funded.

In terms of the share of world military expenditures, at 35 percent of the total, the US is vastly predominant. I would guess we are overmatching. By contrast, the UN was created after World War II with leading efforts by the United States and key allies, with a commitment to preserving peace through international cooperation and collective security. That is, nonmilitary means to deal with each other, through diplomacy and so forth.

Yet, the UN's entire budget is a fraction of the world's military expenditure. It's approximately 1.8 percent of what we spend on the military, so we can see where the priorities really are. Yet, having that enormous expenditure on the military means that that's where we look first and foremost for solutions to problems. We have the investment there, we might as well use it.

The military budget has increased substantially under the Trump administration. Trump ordered the military in his very first few days in office to prepare for world war. One week into his term, he said, "I'm signing an executive action to begin a great rebuilding of the armed services of the United States."

The military order directed now-departed defense secretary James "Mad Dog" Mattis, who was sworn in at the

ceremony, to complete a thirty-day "readiness review" designed to prepare for the destruction of ISIS in Syria and Iraq, along with "other forms of Islamic terror." The order further instructed Mattis, in the words of the Washington Post, "to examine how to carry out operations against unnamed near-peer competitors," a group that US officials typically identify as China and Russia.

This was signaling an enormous policy change. In the previous decade or so, the focus had been on combating global terrorism. Now, all of a sudden, in this document, we start to see the appearance of this phraseology "near-peer competitors." We're reinvoking the Cold War, essentially.

The order unmistakably threatened the use of nuclear weapons. Section 3 called for a nuclear force "to deter the 21st century threats" and menacingly, "to achieve presidential objective should deterrence fail."

He further called for a plan to achieve "readiness objectives" for the use of the nuclear arsenal by 2022. It's a few years from now, so practice your duck-and-cover maneuver. This would include the modernization of the US nuclear force (which was already begun under the previous administration of Obama). It would also include a greatly expanded missile defense system, an increased emphasis in cyber warfare, which aims to cripple the retaliatory capacity of major adversaries by targeting their digital and telecommunication structures prior to an American strike. What could go wrong if forces of our adversaries can't communicate with their military? Nothing really could happen.

The executive action did not put a price tag on new military spending, but media speculation indicated that the figure could approach an additional $100 billion per year, which it has. Combined with a promise of tax cuts at the top, this additional spending will come at the expense of Social Security and Medicare, Medicaid, education, health care, and infrastructure, and so on.

Then just to put this in another context, the military budget now consumes 60 percent of discretionary spending in the US budget. All the kinds of things that we might do otherwise are consumed by this budget.

Here's a little bit of an update. On January 19th of 2018, then secretary of defense Mattis provided a summary of new directions, which are themselves quite troubling. These are quotes from Mattis's summary of the 2018 national defense strategy of the United States:

Again, this is a national defense strategy, but what it really is, ladies and gentlemen … This is an American strategy. It belongs to you. You own it. We work for you tirelessly. It's a pleasure to be at a school named for the gentleman that this one is named for. Oh, Paul Nitze. And I bring this up because National Security Council document or report 68 was a guiding light during the Cold War. In this time of change our military is still strong, yet our competitive advantage has eroded in every domain of warfare. Air, land, sea, space and cyberspace and is continuing to erode [given the amount we spent on it, how could this be?]. Though we will continue to prosecute the campaign against terrorists that we are engaged in today, but great power competition, not terrorism, is now the primary focus of US national security. We face growing threats from revisionist powers as different as China and Russia are from each other. Nations that do seek to create a world consistent with their authoritarian models…. Rogue regimes like North Korea and Iran persist in taking outlaw actions that threaten regional and even global stability. Oppressing their own people and shredding their own people's dignity and human rights, they push their warped views outward. Ladies and gentlemen, we have no room for complacency and history makes clear that America has no preordained right to victory on the battlefield. Simply, we must be the best if the values that grew out of the Enlightenment are to survive. We're going to build a more lethal force. Investments in space and cyberspace, nuclear deterrent force of missile defense, advanced autonomous systems. Resilient and agile logistics will provide our high quality troops what they need to win. Of course, we never redefine winning. To those who would threaten America's experiment in democracy, they must know if you challenge us it will be your longest and your worst day. Work with our diplomats, you don't want to fight the Department of Defense. (2018)

The bottom line, President Trump's new budget is $716 billion for 2019, an increase of 7 percent over 2018. Finally, interestingly enough, he had criticized the $700 billion budget. He thought it was crazy, so he offered $750 billion. This is the proposed budget for next fiscal year. He previously called for a cut, but now he's been talked out of that.

There are some troubling trends here, including continuing and escalating the global war on terror. This is something that we continue to do. We are also increasing tensions with Russia and China along with North Korea and Iran,

Venezuela, Cuba, and so forth.

We are increasing dependence on drone warfare and special operations and targeted assassination. The US public is quite clearly not maintaining a healthy appetite for US casualties, and so we are moving to these other forms of warfare that don't require as much personnel. We are expanding the US basing program but relying on smaller and more numerous bases called lily pads.

There is also the proposed $1 trillion nuclear weapons upgrade to include tactical and low-yield nuclear weapons. These are extremely dangerous. The idea that you have a low-yield nuclear weapon. These are weapons that presumably have the explosive capacity of about five Hiroshima bombs, rather than three hundred Hiroshima bombs per warhead. The idea that you want to somehow make nuclear weapons more thinkably usable is an extremely dangerous idea. We are also at the same time lowering the conditions or the circumstances under which we will contemplate using nuclear weapons, so, for example, in response to a cyber attack. This is an extremely dangerous moment.

Another ongoing feature of continued militarism is the use of racial, religious, xenophobic, nationalistic rhetoric to keep the public in a constant state of fear. This is part of the way in which we maintain and justify this militarism abroad. But another consequence is that this militarism comes home. There's a pervasive common sense, fear of dangerous others. This is the sort of a Hofstadter model, the paranoid politics on steroids, dangerous others. This fear must be constantly reinforced, and we see it all the time in discussions of the border wall or any number of these other characterizations of these caravans of dangerous people coming to invade us.

Some analysts have renamed the welfare state, which obtained basically from about 1945 until in the 1970s, the garrison state. State legitimacy now depends on protection from these threats by targeting of dangerous others. I'll say more about this in two weeks, but just to repeat what I indicated last week, the idea that the globalized form of capitalism means that decisions about the economic security and welfare of citizens are no longer within the hands necessarily of nation-state governors. To preserve their legitimacy as governors, they need to find a new basis for legitimation. Some people are arguing, and I would agree with much of this, that this is the new basis. The protection from dangerous others. We have endless enemies.

Foreign communism morphed into terrorism. We now have a tremendous fear of immigrants and refugees. Witness the recent ban orders, the deportations, the detentions, the demonization of others. We have domestic enemies, people of color, the young, the old, LGBTQ communities, the differently abled, and along with that the militarization of the police and the criminalization of protest, which we'll talk about in the last couple of weeks. Where is all of this headed? The Pentagon has a very bleak view of the future (see "Megacities: Urban Future, the Emerging Complexity: A Pentagon Video"), which views urban areas (both foreign and domestic) as basically breeding grounds for instability, unrest, and chaos. To think about the kind of underlying view of humanity this way I think comes naturally in some sense out of this very long history of militarization. That is, if you think of yourself as military, then everybody outside is an enemy.

This is also what becomes part of the problem of militarizing the police. As the police become increasingly militaristic, the people that they supposedly protect and serve begin to look more and more like the non-police, like the enemy. This is, I think, an extremely dangerous kind of trend that we're seeing.

The forecast that this is the way in which the military will sort of reproduce itself by now being able to respond to these kinds of future threats where the mass of humanity is either an enemy or is in a witting or unwitting cloak for enemies. It's extremely dangerous. One we should think very carefully about, but this is the Pentagon's view largely of what that future looks like, and it is, in fact, urban, militarized, and dangerous. Okay. I'm going to stop with that for now.

Chomsky Lecture, January 31, 2019

In the last few lectures, among other things, I've been discussing elite attitudes toward democracy. I sketched a line from the first democratic revolution, with its fear and contempt for the rascal multitude who were asking for ridiculous things like universal education, health care, and democratization of law, wanting to be ruled by countrymen like themselves who know the people's sores, not by knights and gentlemen who just oppress them. From there to the second major democratic revolution establishing the US Constitution, which was, as discussed last

time, a Framers' Coup, the title of the main scholarly work, a coup by elites that the author describes as a conservative counterrevolution against excessive democracy.

On to the twentieth century and such leading progressive theorists of democracy as Walter Lippmann, Edward Bernays, Harold Lasswell, and Reinhold Niebuhr, and their conception that the public has to be put in its place. They're spectators, not participants. The responsible men, the elite, have to be protected from the trampling and the roar of the bewildered herd, who have to be kept in line with necessary illusions, emotionally potent oversimplifications, and, in general, engineering of consent, which has become a gigantic industry devoted to some aspects of the task, while responsible intellectuals take care of others.

The men of best quality through the ages have to be self-indoctrinated, as Orwell discussed. They must internalize the understanding that there are certain things it just wouldn't do to say. It must be so fully internalized that it becomes as routine as taking a breath. What else could anyone possibly believe?

As long as all of this is in place, the system functions properly, with no crises.

This picture, I think, captures crucial features of thought control in the more free societies, but it is misleading in essential ways. Most importantly, it largely omitted the constant popular struggles to extend the range of democracy, with many successes. Even in the last generation, there have been quite substantial successes. Such successes typically lead to a reaction. Those with power and privilege don't relinquish it easily. The neoliberal period that we're now enduring, long in planning, is such a reaction. We'll come back to details.

It's also misleading because there have been significant elite exceptions to this dominant tendency. During the Constitutional Convention, the most respected of the delegates was Benjamin Franklin, who objected to what was going on. He expressed his "dislike of everything that tended to debase the spirit of the common people" and reminded his colleagues that "some of the greatest rogues he was ever acquainted with were the richest rogues" (Klarman, op. cit.)—rather like some of Adam Smith's reflections.

Franklin was a lone voice at the convention. Thomas Jefferson expressed somewhat similar sentiments, but he wasn't there. He was then ambassador in Paris. In any event, the coup did proceed on course with consequences to the present, though there was plenty of conflict in the country at the time—hence "a coup"—and in the years that followed, to the present.

The twentieth century also had important exceptions in elite opinion. The most prominent was John Dewey, the most respected American social philosopher of the twentieth century. Most of his work—and also activism—was devoted to democracy and education, along lines very much opposed to the doctrines of "manufacture of consent" and marginalization of the "bewildered herd."

By democracy, Dewey meant full-blooded democracy, with active participation of an informed public. His democratic theory was linked closely to his educational philosophy, which was designed to nurture creativity and independence of thought, for one reason as preparation for participation in a democratic society. It worked. I was lucky enough to go to a Deweyite school from about age two to twelve, and it was very impressive.

Dewey was at first a typical responsible intellectual, joining the self-adulation of intellectuals during World War I for their stellar role in directing the stupid masses to wartime enthusiasm. That was, however, not unusual. The capitulation to power of the intellectual classes during those years, on all sides, is astonishing to behold, and of the few who didn't swim with the tide, the best known ended up in jail: Bertrand Russell in England, Eugene Debs in the US, Karl Liebknecht and Rosa Luxemburg in Germany.

Shortly after the war, Dewey changed and became a sharp and incisive social and media critic. Increasingly through the years, he came to regard "politics as the shadow cast on society by big business." Reforms are of limited utility: "The attenuation of the shadow will not change the substance." The substance is that the very institutions of private power undermine democracy and freedom. "Power today," he recognized, "resides in control of the means of production, exchange, publicity, transportation and communication. Whoever owns them rules the life of the country," even if democratic forms remain. In a free and democratic society, workers should be "the masters of their own industrial fate," not tools rented by employers. Industry must therefore be changed "from a feudalistic to a democratic social order," based on control of production by the workers themselves, much as working people

demanded in the early days of the Industrial Revolution, flames never extinguished and frequently fanned since, again today.

The system of actual power in the country, Dewey continued, is "business for private profit through private control of banking, land, industry, reinforced by command of the press, press agents and other means of publicity and propaganda." That is the system of actual power, the source of coercion and control, and until it is unraveled, we cannot talk seriously about democracy and freedom. Dewey also condemned the "unfree press" for yielding to commercialism and deplored its impact "upon the judgment of what news is, upon the selection and elimination of matter that is published, upon the treatment of news in both editorials and news columns." He suggested a "cooperative system" controlled "in the interest of all," rather than commitment by the media to "romanticize … profit motives" (Westbrook 1993).

This is not the voice of a wild man in the wings, but of one of the most respected and influential of twentieth-century American intellectuals.

In brief, it oversimplifies to speak of elite attitudes without qualification, though the near uniformity is often impressive.

Dewey's condemnation of wage labor is reminiscent of the stand of Abraham Lincoln and other leading figures of classical liberalism, and of working men and women, as we've seen. And his critique of the media should remind us of a progressive feature of the Constitutional Convention that has an instructive history in the years that follow, with important lessons for today. I have in mind the way the Founders interpreted the First Amendment, specifically, freedom of press.

It is a common practice to distinguish negative from positive rights. Negative rights reduce in essence to "Don't tread on me." Positive rights involve enhancement of welfare and opportunities, what economist Amartya Sen calls "capabilities."

The current prevailing interpretation takes the First Amendment to confer negative rights on the media: the state should not interfere with their work. Even that is a fairly recent innovation, dating back to an important 1964 case involving the civil rights movement (New York Times v. Sullivan). The negative-rights interpretation is a sharp departure from the perspective of the Founders, who interpreted the First Amendment more liberally, as conferring positive rights, matters discussed in penetrating work by media critics Robert McChesney (2007) and Victor Pickard (2020). The Founders wanted media to be free, vibrant, independent, not the "unfree press" that Dewey condemned for its subordination to owners and advertisers. And varied; the press of the day was often sharp and adversarial. For the Founders, this was not just a rhetorical commitment. They believed that the government should be directly engaged in fostering a truly free press. The method used was, essentially, subsidy. The US Postal Service was designed as a substantial subsidy to independent media, providing widely available distribution at very low rates. The large majority of postal traffic in the early years was newspapers.

As already discussed, the Founders were in crucial ways precapitalist in mentality. But the US soon turned into a business-run society, to an unusual extent. Accordingly, hegemonic common sense came to oppose positive rights, which typically infringe on prerogatives of private capital. And over the years, the Founders' liberal interpretation of the First Amendment has been narrowed to the negative-rights interpretation of today. The matter was highly contested through the twentieth century, first with the advent of radio, then television, finally the internet. In the 1930s, there was strong public opposition to the government decision to hand over the public airwaves to private enterprise, with only the most marginal concern for the positive rights of the public to information, free discussion, and public service. In the late 1940s, a similar debate took place over the decision to hand public assets to private enterprise for television rights. The issue arose again in the mid-1990s, when the neoliberal Clinton administration passed the Telecommunication Act of 1996, handing the internet—public property and largely publicly created—to private ownership, furthermore deregulated and soon converging in the usual manner to monopolization, contrary to the predictions of advocates and most economists but as anticipated by critics and a regular feature of the neoliberal call for deregulation and market worship.

As a consequence, the US is alone among formally democratic societies in lacking major public media that are not subject to the pressures of Dewey's "unfree press"—though the neoliberal assault has taken its toll elsewhere, notably on the BBC, quite visibly since Thatcher and her TINA doctrine: There Is No Alternative to neoliberal

orthodoxy.

The “common sense” preference for negative over positive rights has broad policy consequences. In social justice measures, the US ranks near the bottom of the thirty-six members of the OECD—the richer countries—alongside of Greece and Turkey. It is also exhibited clearly in elite attitudes on many issues. One notable case is the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UD), initiated by the US in its more liberal days and adopted by the UN General Assembly in 1948 as “the foundation of freedom, justice and peace in the world.” There were eight abstentions: South Africa, Saudi Arabia, Russia, and several of its satellites. Otherwise, unanimous assent, including the United States.

The UD has three components, of equal status: political, socioeconomic, and community rights. The second and third components are basically positive rights. Most of the signers approve in words while disregarding many of their commitments in practice. The US differs: it even disapproves in words. Positive rights are rejected. Community rights are considered too ridiculous even to reject openly, but socioeconomic rights (to health, decent jobs, etc.) are rejected with scorn. Reagan’s UN Ambassador and foreign policy adviser Jeane Kirkpatrick dismissed this section of the UD as “a letter to Santa Claus,” seconded by Russia’s Andrey Vyshinsky.

The same stand was elaborated by Paula Dobriansky, assistant secretary of state for Human Rights and Human Affairs in the Reagan and Bush I administrations. She dispelled such “myths” about human rights as the so-called “economic and social rights” entrenched in the UD, which just obfuscate human rights discourse. The same view was expressed in 1990 by the US representative to the UN Commission on Human Rights, Ambassador Morris Abram, explaining Washington’s solitary veto of the UN resolution on the Right to Development, which virtually repeated the socioeconomic provisions of the UD. These spurious claims “seem preposterous,” Abrams declared: such ideas are “little more than an empty vessel into which vague hopes and inchoate expectations can be poured,” and even a “dangerous incitement.”

US practice is unusual in the same way. Other countries ratify General Assembly conventions on human rights, but often ignore them. The US refuses to ratify them, apart from a few that it ratified but with reservations exempting the US. The rejection of international conventions goes beyond the positive socioeconomic rights of the UD, extending even to the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights, “the leading treaty for the protection” of the subcategory of rights that the US claims to uphold, to quote Human Rights Watch and the American Civil Liberties Union. The Convention finally was ratified after a long delay, but only with provisions to render it inapplicable to the United States.

In interpreting debate over government decisions and public debate over such matters, we can usefully distinguish rationales, pretexts, and reasons. Rationales are what are offered in defense of choices. We regard them as pretexts if they are too absurd to take seriously. Actual reasons are what we seek to discover by analysis of the historical and documentary record, and by attending to the principle of law that predictable consequences are a good indication of motives. Not surprisingly, we commonly find the reasons to be rather different from the rationales.

To take an uncontroversial case, eighty years ago Hitler invaded Poland. The rationale was defense against the “wild terror” of the Poles, instantly assigned to the category of pretexts outside Nazi Germany and its sympathizers. The reasons were to acquire Lebensraum for the superior Aryan race and to eliminate the tens of millions of Untermenschen who occupied the territories and who were appropriating the resources that properly belonged to their superiors. If analogies come to mind in American history, and elsewhere today, it is not mere accident.

Let’s turn to another case that is uncontroversial within mainstream opinion in the US: the US wars in Indochina. The rationale, sampled earlier, is expounded by the most respected voices of the establishment Left: “blundering efforts to do good” (Anthony Lewis), defense against “aggression” by Communist North Vietnam (historian and Kennedy adviser Arthur Schlesinger), defense against “internal aggression” (Kennedy’s UN Ambassador and liberal icon Adlai Stevenson, referring to the aggression of South Vietnamese peasant-based guerrillas against the US-imposed dictatorship), and similar pronouncements by numerous others. The wild men in the wings dismissed these as mere pretext, joined by a large majority of the public, who regarded the war as “fundamentally wrong and immoral,” not “a mistake,” as we have seen; irrelevantly, with no voice in the mainstream.

To discover the reasons, we can investigate the rich internal record from the early days when the basic decisions were made in the late ’40s and early ’50s. To some of the wild men, the record reveals the usual imperial concern

that the “virus” of an independent Vietnam would “spread contagion” throughout Southeast Asia, reaching as far as Japan, and seriously undermining US postwar plans for global control. We’ll come back to this later on.

To take another case, consider the major crime of the twentieth century, the US-UK invasion of Iraq, a textbook case of aggression, the “supreme international crime” according to the Nuremberg Tribunal that hanged Nazi war criminals for less, dismissing Nazi pretexts.

In US mainstream opinion, the war was at worst a “strategic blunder” (Obama). The rationale at first was Saddam’s nuclear weapons programs. That was “the single question.” When it was answered the wrong way, the rationale instantly and effortlessly shifted to “democracy promotion.” US media and other commentary quickly adopted the new rationale, though more sober minds warned that the “noble” and “generous” vision may be beyond our reach: it may be too costly, the beneficiaries may be too backward to benefit from our solicitude. Scholarship joined in as well. One of the rare exceptions, Middle East scholar Augustus Richard Norton, observed caustically that “as fantasies about Iraq’s weapons of mass destruction were unmasked, the Bush administration increasingly stressed the democratic transformation of Iraq, and scholars jumped on the democratization bandwagon” (2005).

Some regarded these rationales as pretexts, among them Iraqis, who demonstrated their backwardness in a Gallup poll taken just at the time that the new rationale was eloquently proclaimed in a major address by President Bush. Some Iraqis, it is true, did regard the rationale as valid: 1 percent. Another 4 percent thought that the goal was “to assist the Iraqi people.” Most of the rest assumed that the goal was to take control of Iraq’s resources and to reorganize the Middle East in the interests of the US and Israel—the “conspiracy theory” derided by rational Westerners, who understood that Washington and London would have been just as dedicated to the “liberation of Iraq” if it produced asparagus rather than oil and the center of world petroleum production were in the South Pacific.

As for the reasons, I’ll leave it to you.

The rationale-pretext-reasons distinctions have a critical role throughout history and today. Deregulation, as mentioned above, is an instructive case. And more generally, limited government, allegedly a conservative ideal, though, oddly, government tends to grow under their stewardship, as in the Reagan years, serving primarily the rich.

An early exponent of the ideal of limited government was Andrew Jackson. The rationale was negative rights: citizens of our free society should be free from government intrusion. In his words, the federal government should not be permitted to restrict “human liberty” but should be only allowed to “enforce human rights.” The meaning of these fine words, and their predictable consequences, are spelled out by historian Greg Grandin in his End of the Myth: by “human rights” Jackson meant the right to slaughter Indians without government interference and to own property; crucially for this vicious slave owner, to own human beings as property. The Age of Jackson, Grandin observes, “entailed a radical empowerment of white men [and] an equally radical subjugation of African-Americans,” along with brutal massacres and expulsion of the Untermenschen who were improperly appropriating to themselves what belonged by right to the superior Anglo-Saxon race.

There are innumerable other examples of the utility of these distinctions in analysis of policy, but let’s now turn to one prominent one. A core feature of received common sense is that the United States is committed to promoting democracy and human rights. It’s sometimes called “Wilsonian idealism” or “American exceptionalism.”

I mentioned in some opening remarks that it’s a good rule of thumb to attend to doctrines about complex matters that are reiterated passionately, constantly, but without any evidence. Under such conditions, it’s useful to take a closer look and to see if we’re facing one of those cases where there are things that it wouldn’t do to say, in Orwell’s phrase.

American exceptionalism is one of these cases. In the first place, as soon as we look we find that the doctrine has nothing in particular to do with the United States. It seems to be universal. All imperial powers have had the same doctrine of exceptionalism. France, for example, was carrying out its “civilizing mission” in Algeria while the commanding general was giving orders to “exterminate” the population. That would civilize them properly.

France’s noble mission extended to much of West Africa, with such success that people are dying in the Mediterranean trying to flee the wreckage. Britain was very much the same. If there were time, I’d review some pretty remarkable examples, including even the most distinguished people, like John Stuart Mill.

The same is true even of the states that are the most brutal. Take Nazi Germany. When Hitler took over the Sudetenland, large parts of Czechoslovakia, he was just brimming with concern for the suffering people of the region. The Germans were going to undertake a humanitarian intervention, to resolve ethnic conflicts, to bring the backward population under the wing of the advanced civilization of Germany. We know where that led.

Moving to Asia, when the Japanese were rampaging in Manchuria and North China, with horrendous atrocities, what they were thinking is accessible to an unusual extent. Since they were defeated in the war, their internal records were taken, including counterinsurgency manuals. I'm not sure whether these were released to the public, but in the 1960s a friend at the Rand Corporation sent them to me: Tony Russo, who worked with Dan Ellsberg in releasing the Pentagon Papers. I published some excerpts from them in a memorial volume for the great American pacifist A. J. Muste, reprinted in American Power and the New Mandarins.

They're very interesting. They're very much like US counterinsurgency doctrine except that the rhetoric is more elevated. While they were devastating Manchuria and North China, carrying out the Nanjing Massacre and other hideous crimes, this is what they were saying—talking to each other, no pretense. We're going to create an "earthly paradise" for the people of China, for whom we are expending our lives and treasure to protect from "Chinese bandits," namely, those resisting the Japanese humanitarian intervention. We'll protect the people of China and bring them under the wing of the advanced civilization of Japan. Very elevated.

In fact, if we had records from Attila the Hun, I suspect we'd probably find the same thing. It's hard to find an exception in the entire history of imperialism. That aspect of American exceptionalism is not at all exceptional. It's the norm. Everyone's the same who has any power.

The second thing it wouldn't do to say about American exceptionalism is what the facts are, some of which we've been discussing. It's particularly instructive to see how the historical record is dealt with by really serious scholars, the best scholars, people who are not experts in legitimation. Take Hans Morgenthau. He's one of the founders of realist international relations (IR) theory, the dominant tendency in IR theory, which dismisses sentimental talk about Wilsonian idealism. Morgenthau was much too good a scholar to have any of that. He was a hard-headed realist.

In his 1964 book The Purpose of American Politics (a phrase worth pondering), Morgenthau writes that America is unlike other countries because it has a "transcendent purpose." Other countries just have national interests. The US has a transcendent purpose: "the establishment of equality in freedom in America," and indeed throughout the world, since "the arena within which the United States must defend and promote its purpose has become worldwide."

An honest and competent scholar, Morgenthau recognized that the historical record is radically inconsistent with America's transcendent purpose. But that should not mislead us. We should not "confound the abuse of reality with reality itself." Reality itself is the unachieved "national purpose" revealed by "the evidence of history as our minds reflect it." The actual historical record is merely the "abuse of reality," hence of only secondary interest. Those who confuse "reality" with "the abuse of reality" are committing "the error of atheism, which denies the validity of religion on similar grounds." Again, a thought worth pondering.

One of the highly admired elements of American exceptionalism is our longstanding commitment to democracy promotion. Here, too, there is good scholarship. The major scholarly study of democracy promotion is by another serious scholar, Thomas Carothers, then director of the Democracy and Rule of Law Project at the Carnegie Endowment.

Carothers was in an unusually favorable position to study this leading rationale for US foreign policy, reinvoked by Bush in Iraq when the search for weapons of mass destruction went sour. Carothers, who describes himself as a neo-Reaganite, had served in the Reagan State Department in the democracy promotion programs in Latin America, so he had an insider's view of what was going on.

Reviewing the record, Carothers concludes that the democracy programs were "sincere," but a failure, in fact, a systematic failure, failure everywhere. Where US influence was least, in the southern cone of Latin America, progress toward democracy was greatest, despite Reagan's efforts to impede it by "trying to embrace the fading right-wing dictators that Carter had shunned on human rights grounds." Where US influence was strongest, in the

regions nearby, progress was least.

There was a reason: Washington sought to maintain "the basic order of what, historically at least, are quite undemocratic societies" and to avoid "populist-based change in Latin America—with all its implications for upsetting economic and political orders and heading off in a leftist direction." Therefore the US would tolerate only "limited, top-down forms of democratic change that did not risk upsetting the traditional structures of power with which the United States has long been allied" (Carothers 1991).

That's what actually happened: "abuse of reality." Reality is that the programs were "sincere." I'll leave to you an analysis in terms of rationale, pretext, and reasons.

These matters pose a painful dilemma for policymakers, lamented at the extreme dovish end of the spectrum by Robert Pastor, Latin American specialist of the Carter administration, which was derided by Reaganites and many others for its excessive devotion to human rights. Defending US policy, Pastor explains that "the United States did not want to control Nicaragua or other nations in the region, but it also did not want to allow developments to get out of control. It wanted Nicaraguans to act independently, except when doing so would affect U.S. interests adversely" (Pastor 1987, his emphasis). In short, Nicaragua and other countries should be free—free to do what we want them to do—and should choose their course independently, as long as their choice conforms to our interests. If they use the freedom we accord them unwisely, then, naturally, we are entitled to respond with violence in self-defense.

Carothers and Pastor are discussing Latin America, but the pattern is worldwide. Let's turn to W. Bush and the Bush doctrine (every president has to have a doctrine, to put his stamp on history). The Bush doctrine is defined simply in the most extensive scholarly study of "the roots of the Bush doctrine," by Jonathan Monten in the prestigious journal International Security: "The promotion of democracy is central to the George W. Bush administration's prosecution of both the war on terrorism and its overall grand strategy." The article appeared in 2005, when Iraq was descending into total chaos after the US invasion. The sentiment was unsurprising. By then it had reached the level of ritual. Why just then? Perhaps because just then the official rationale for the war had shifted from what had been the "single question"—Saddam's nuclear weapons programs—to "democracy promotion," Matters already discussed.

Let's turn to another interesting example, Winston Churchill. In our last session, Marv discussed some of Churchill's noble phrases about our common magnificent history and intentions in his famous 1946 Iron Curtain speech. But Churchill was no fool. He had some other things to say about these matters at the same time, in his history of World War II:

The government of the world must be entrusted to satisfied nations, who wished nothing more from themselves than what they had. If the world-government were in the hands of hungry nations, there would always be danger. But none of us had any reason to seek for anything more. The peace would be kept by peoples who lived in their own way and were not ambitious. Our power placed us above the rest. We were like rich men dwelling at peace within their habitations.

Rather ample habitations.

That's 1945 in his history of World War II (vol. 5). But in fact, that's an old position of Churchill's. Shortly before World War I, he gave a speech in Parliament in which he explained that "we are not a young people with an innocent record and a scanty inheritance. We have engrossed to ourselves an altogether disproportionate share of the wealth and traffic of the world. We have got all we want in territory, and our claim to be left in the unmolested enjoyment of vast and splendid possessions, mainly acquired by violence, largely maintained by force, often seems less reasonable to others than to us" (Ponting 1994).

Churchill didn't allow this to be published at the time. It was published with the italicized phrases omitted. The original was discovered recently. Churchill is unusual only in his honesty: recognizing the facts and willingness to express them. With this background, let's take a look at how the world has been organized from World War II.

As soon as the war began, the State Department and the Council on Foreign Relations (CFR) established a war-peace study group that was to determine what the shape of the postwar world would be; the CFR is the leading nongovernmental institution concerned with foreign relations, mostly people in and out of government and corporations.

The analysts took for granted the United States would emerge victorious. That was not really in question. For several years they assumed that the war would end with two major power blocs, one dominated by the United States, the other dominated by Germany. In the early stages of the war, Germany was achieving remarkable successes.

The area to be dominated by the United States they called the "Grand Area." The Grand Area was to include at a minimum the entire Western Hemisphere, the Far East, and the former British Empire, which the US was taking over, displacing Britain, which had been the leading global power for a long time before. So that's the minimum of US domination. The rest would be the German-dominated world.

By about 1942, 1943, after the battle in Stalingrad and in particular a huge tank battle at Kursk, it was clear that the Russians were going to defeat the Germans. The conception changed; Grand Area expectations were modified in character and scale. Now it would be the Russians, not the Germans, who would be the adversary. The Grand Area would include everything I just described, plus whatever part of Europe and Asia the United States could take over. At the very least, Western Europe, which is the industrial heartland of the European continent. So that's the expanded Grand Area.

It was understood that in the Grand Area the United States would reign supreme. Long before the war, the United States had been by far the richest country in the world, and it gained enormously from the war. Manufacturing practically quadrupled, while other industrial states were severely harmed or almost destroyed. The prominent statesman George Kennan, head of the early postwar State Department Policy Planning Staff, estimated that the US had half of the world's wealth. Very likely an exaggeration; statistics weren't very good at the time. But probably not by much.

Grand Area planners determined that US domination must be firmly established. In their own words, they planned for a world in which the US would "hold unquestioned power," ensuring "the limitation of any exercise of sovereignty" by states that might interfere with its global designs. The planners therefore sought to develop an "integrated policy to achieve military and economic supremacy" for the United States in the Grand Area, which was to expand as much as possible.

When the war ended, these conceptions were formulated in internal planning documents. The plans were then implemented where possible. The general idea was to impose what is commonly called "the US-led liberal economic order"—now under threat by Trump. There were a number of guiding principles.

The basic principle was that the new economic order should be an open system, which means freedom for investors, for movement of capital, for extraction of resources. Not, of course, for movement of people. And it must be a level playing field; everyone is equal. So the United States would be part of the system, Grenada would be part of it, all perfectly fair and equal.

There was nothing novel in this stance. In fact, the US was replaying what Britain had done a century earlier. Britain became a leading industrial power just as Churchill said, by force and violence, and also by stealing higher technology from other countries: India, Ireland, the countries that are now Belgium and Holland. By the mid-nineteenth century, Britain had become far and away the most advanced society, with more than twice the per-capita capitalization of any other country. It was far enough ahead in the competition to begin to toy with the idea of advocating free trade, assuming it would do quite well in the competition. That was 1846.

Free trade, however, had some qualifications. Britain never really agreed to it fully. India, that's all of South Asia then, was under British control. Before the European onslaught, India and China were the richest, most advanced countries in the world. But imperialism took care of that. India was deindustrialized by the British occupation, but it was still a rich prize—closed off despite free trade pretensions, and barred from real development.

Later Britain abandoned the free trade game altogether because it could no longer compete with Japan. It therefore closed off the empire. Holland, which had a substantial empire in East Asia, did the same, the US as well. That's a large part of the background for the Second World War in the Pacific. The Japanese reacted to the closing of the entire region by the imperial powers, blocking their access to essential resources. They began to carry out aggressive acts, which finally led to war.

The US recapitulated the British experience a century later. Until well into the twentieth century, the US was a

leader in protectionism. Economic historian Paul Bairoch described the US as the "the mother country and bastion of protectionism," from its origins (Bairoch, op. cit.) The US also resorted to other forms of large-scale state intervention in the economy, some truly extreme, like slavery, which was the basis of much of the modern economy. But by 1945, the United States was far ahead of anyone else. So it was a good time for free trade, an open global system.

But just like Britain before it, there were qualifications. One of the US principles for the postwar liberal world order was that regional alliances were to be dismantled. There should be no more imperial preference systems in which the imperial power had special control and could keep others from entering it on equal terms. With one exception. One regional system was to remain. Henry Stimson, one of the leading US statesmen, when discussing the elimination of regional systems, explained that all must be eliminated except for "our little region over here which has never bothered anyone," the Western hemisphere (Kolko 1968).

So the Western hemisphere, rather like India under the British, would be under US control. But the rest would be open to everyone.

The meaning of open global systems is sometimes articulated quite honestly in internal documents. The most important commodity in the world at the time, still today, was oil. The United States, of course, had a petroleum policy. It was spelled out in a 1944 State Department document entitled The Petroleum Policy of the United States. The document called for "the preservation of the absolute position presently obtaining [in the Western hemisphere], and therefore vigilant protection of existing concessions in United States hands coupled with insistence upon the Open Door principle of equal opportunity for United States companies in new areas."

In brief, what we have, we keep, closing the door to others; what we do not yet have, we take, under the principle of the Open Door.

In "our little region over here," it wasn't too difficult to implement this principle. Long before World War II, the US had expelled Britain from Venezuela when major oil reserves were found there, imposing its own rule. The Middle East, where the main resources of easily accessible oil were and still are, was more complex. Prior to World War II, the region was largely under British control. To implement the petroleum policy, the US, relying on its far superior power, compelled Britain "to accept an arrangement that reserved a privileged position for the U.S. domestic oil industry while exposing all of Britain's oil production, which was in other countries, to the competition of the powerful U.S. international oil companies" (oil industry specialist David Painter, 1986). French interests were dismissed even more easily, by declaring France to be an enemy state, under German occupation, hence forfeiting its rights.

The vast energy reserves of the Middle East, included in the Grand Area, were not important for the US itself, which then, and for many years after, was the world's major petroleum producer (as it is becoming again today). But they were important as a means of world control. The industrial centers of the Grand Area were shifting to reliance on oil, under US influence; much Marshall Plan aid for Europe was dedicated to the purchase of oil, hence moving from one US bank to another. Furthermore, US control over this increasingly essential resource provided the US with "veto power" over its allies, George Kennan explained.

Kennan was referring specifically to Japan. At the time, Japan's development to a major industrial power was considered a remote contingency, but still a potential concern, especially if Japan were to seek an independent role in world affairs. In that case, the "veto power" could become an important tool of diplomacy. These conceptions persisted into the post–Cold War years. The influential planner Zbigniew Brzezinski was not enthusiastic about the US invasion of Iraq in 2003, but he recognized that it might have a bright side. He wrote that "America's security role," the conventional euphemism for military domination, if extended over the second-largest oil producer in the region, would provide Washington with "indirect but politically critical leverage on the European and Asian economies that are also dependent on energy exports from the region" (National Interest, Winter 2003/4).

Global control requires thoughtful planning.

The Middle East remains of enormous importance. Just open the newspapers. You read about Iraq, Iran, Syria, Saudi Arabia and its war in Yemen (which is destroying the country with US arms and intelligence support), Qatar, Israel. It's a major focus. And the reason isn't obscure. It was explained by the State Department in 1945 when the new

world order was being established. The State Department pointed out that Middle East oil is “a stupendous source of strategic power, and one of the greatest material prizes in world history.” That’s not a small affair. We have to make sure we have substantial control of that.

In Europe the war ended in 1945, with the Russians and Allied (US-UK) forces separated at the Oder-Neisse Line, which was actually a historical fault line. That was where Eastern and Western Europe had begun to divide in about the fifteenth century. Western Europe at that point was beginning to develop. Eastern Europe was falling behind. Historian of Russia Theodore Shanin writes that in the course of this process, “Russia was becoming a semi-colonial possession of European capital” (Shanin 1985). There was some development in Eastern Europe, but it was mostly Western-owned. That changed in 1917. After the Bolshevik Revolution, Russia went on to become a major industrial power, although nowhere near the scale of the West.

After 1945, each side imposed its rule in the areas they had conquered. For the Russians, it was Eastern Europe. That story is familiar—not in Russia, where it was clouded in propaganda, but here we all know about Russian oppression in Eastern Europe. So we won’t have to review it.

For US domains, most of the rest of the world, you have to search the documentary and scholarly record to find out what happened. I talked a little about it earlier.

In Europe and also in Japan, the first task was to dismantle the antifascist resistance and the social and political structures that it had established. The problem was faced in the first country occupied by allied forces, Italy. There the resistance had driven the Germans out of large areas and had begun to construct a new radical democratic order on their own. It was therefore necessary to dismantle what had been constructed and to restore the traditional order, including leading fascists and fascist collaborators. Italy remained a tough nut. The CIA carried out one of its major operations there from 1948, aimed at subverting Italian democracy, continuing at least into the 1970s. There were similar tasks all over Western Europe and Japan. And interventions all over the Grand Area, too numerous to mention. If there’s time we’ll return to some of them.

If we look at the period since 1945, comparing rhetoric and actions, we find as usual two different pictures. The rhetoric was that the United States was defending itself and others from Russian aggression all over the world. The United States was in a posture of defense. To underscore that posture, the Defense Department was established in 1947. The US didn’t have a Defense Department before that; it had a War Department. That was the pre-Orwell period, so a War Department that was devoted to wars of aggression was called the War Department.

In fact from the founding of the country right up until today, there’s hardly been a year when the United States wasn’t at war. A rather unusual history. Just think it through. First there were wars against what the Declaration of Independence calls the “merciless Indian savages” who were brutally attacking peaceful English communities. Then we had to defend ourselves against the Indian nations we were dispossessing and “exterminating,” as the leadership sometimes described the process. Also conquering half of Mexico, including where we are meeting now. Then expanding over parts of the Pacific. Endless intervention mainly in the Americas. There’s no time to go through it. And it continues throughout the Cold War.

Sometimes it’s not direct military aggression, just support of military coups. The most recent is Honduras in 2009, one of the reasons there are so many refugees from Honduras, as we already discussed.

That’s essentially the picture, including the actual Cold War. If you take a look at the Cold War in terms of actual actions, not rhetoric, it’s not primarily a Russian-American confrontation, though that was always in the background. On the ground, each of the two major powers, the grand superpower and the lesser superpower, intervened often forcefully in their own domains. For the Russians, Eastern Europe, for the United States, most of the rest of the world. And each used the pretext of the threat of the other as a justification for intervention. So when the Russians invaded Hungary in 1956, they were defending free Hungary against the fascist forces supported by the West. And whenever the US intervenes anywhere in the world, whatever the facts may be, it’s defending itself and the Free World from Russian subversion or aggression. Even if there are no Russians anywhere in sight, it’s the Russians or their proxies.

Though the two sides are unequal in scale and scope of their violent actions, they have followed rather similar policies. That’s the real structure of the Cold War as long as it lasted, up until the collapse of the Soviet Union.

That's if you look at the actions rather than the rhetoric.

The basic structure was established as the Nazis were defeated. Russia established its harsh and repressive rule in the East, all very familiar. The US and its British ally supported the reconstruction of largely independent state capitalist societies, open to the US multinationals that were then taking their modern form and within the US-run NATO alliance—but only after completing the first task of dismantling the antifascist resistance and its radical democratic aspirations and structures and restoring something like the traditional order.

The task even extended to the Western hemisphere, our little region over here. A conflict arose between two different conceptions of how the hemisphere ought to be organized and developed. One of them was the conception that was dominant throughout Latin America. The other was the conception in the United States. And they were diametrically opposed. As the State Department described the problem, Latin Americans advocate "the philosophy of the new nationalism [that] embraces policies designed to bring about a broader distribution of wealth and to raise the standard of living of the masses." Latin Americans are convinced that "the first beneficiaries of the development of a country's resources should be the people of that country" (Green 1971). That failure to understand "sound economics" had to be stopped in its tracks.

To deal with the problem, the US summoned the Latin American countries to a hemispheric conference in Mexico in February 1945, where the US put forth an Economic Charter of the Americas that called for an end to "economic nationalism" in all its forms. "Sound economics" entails that the beneficiaries of a country's resources should be US investors and their local associates. Not the people of that country.

Given power relations, the US position prevailed.

As usual with free trade rhetoric, there was an exception: the United States. Economic nationalism must be banned throughout the continent, but not in the state that issued the rules. The US followed a policy of state-led industrial development under the cover of the Pentagon, essentially creating the modern high-tech economy. That's why you have your computers and iPhones and the internet and all the rest, mostly thanks to extensive state intervention in the economy, massive taxpayer funding for decades to create the high-tech economy. But other than that, no economic nationalism.

It was recognized that it might take force to eradicate the philosophy of the new nationalism and the heretical idea that people should be the beneficiaries of their own resources. That was understood. Again, let's go to the dovish end of the planning spectrum, to George Kennan. He warned that we must ensure "the protection of our raw materials." They're ours; they just happen by accident to be located somewhere else. And it might not be easy.

"The final answer might be an unpleasant one," Kennan concluded: "police repression by the local government." We should not hesitate to support "harsh government measures of repression" as long as "the results are on balance favorable to our purposes." In general, "it is better to have a strong regime in power than a liberal government if it is indulgent and relaxed and penetrated by Communists" (LaFeber 1983), a term with broad application. It can refer to priests and nuns organizing peasants, labor organizers, human rights activists, a pretty comprehensive notion. That's the dovish end of the spectrum.

It remained a doctrine of American liberalism, reiterated much later in the Clinton doctrine, which held that the US has the right to resort to "unilateral use of military power" to ensure "uninhibited access to key markets, energy supplies and strategic resources." Not a right accorded to others, needless to say.

In accord with these principles, there's a vicious record of intervention. I won't go through it. Hundreds of thousands of people killed, countries destroyed, huge refugee flow. A crucial year in this record was 1962, during the Kennedy administration, an important date to which I'll return.

Elsewhere, it was also necessary to discipline countries that were tempted to "go berserk with fanatical nationalism" by trying to control their own resources. That's the New York Times editors in 1954 (August 6) praising the CIA coup that overthrew the parliamentary government of Iran and installed the rule of the Shah. Repercussions are right on the front pages until today. Incidentally, the New York Times appears to have a near 100 percent record of supporting military coups that are backed directly or supported by the US.

All of this goes back to 1945, when the US was at the height of its power, a kind of power that had never existed in world history. US security was overwhelming. The US controlled the Western hemisphere, both oceans, the opposite sides of both oceans. It had almost half the world's wealth at that time, which is astonishing.

There's a lot of talk these days about recent American decline, but it's worth bearing in mind that the decline began immediately after the war. That level of power could not possibly be maintained. There was a serious decline in American power in 1949, when an event occurred called "loss of China"—an interesting phrase; I can lose my watch but not yours. China's independence was a huge blow to Grand Area planning, and had large effects on international policies, to which we'll return later.

It had a large impact on the domestic scene as well. The question of who was responsible for the loss of China provided a major impetus for the severe McCarthyite repression—which actually began some years earlier with Truman, but was carried forward substantially by McCarthy with effects that have not disappeared.

As decolonization took its agonizing course and other industrial powers reconstructed from wartime damage, the US share of global wealth (GDP) continued to decline, to about 25 percent by 1970—still phenomenal but not what it had been at the peak of US power. By now it's declined further, but these measures are becoming misleading as we enter the period of neoliberal globalization in which national accounts mean much less than they did before. There's a different measure of power that is becoming more significant: the percentage of ownership of the world's wealth by US-based corporations. The answer is an absolutely astounding 50 percent. Today, the statistics are good. They reveal that 50 percent of the world's wealth is in the hands of US-based corporations, even though the national account, GDP, is not anywhere near that. These topics have been explored in depth by political economist Sean Starrs, who also found that US-based corporations are first in just about every category—manufacturing, finance, almost everything else (Starrs, forthcoming).

Nevertheless, global hegemony did decline. The loss of China, as I mentioned, was very serious. In fact, the loss of China was the background for the worst crime of the postwar period, the invasion of Vietnam, which began immediately afterward, with strong US support for France's effort to reconquer its former colony. We'll return to the details, but in the context of our topic tonight, it's interesting to consider how the war is interpreted. Close to universally, across the political spectrum, it is described as a failure, a terrible defeat for the US.

There is, of course, some truth to that. The US did not achieve its maximal goal of conquering Vietnam or even sustaining the regime it had established in the south. But there is more to the story.

One of the good things about the United States is that it's a pretty open society, more than any other that I know of. We have good access to internal records, not everything, of course, but there's a reasonably good record of release of documents. In this case we were helped quite a lot by Dan Ellsberg. The Pentagon Papers (PP) revealed a huge amount of material on the war, soon supplemented by government release of many documents once the dam had been breached. That included quite revealing internal discussions on the reasons for the early intervention in Vietnam in support of France, which set the stage for what followed.

This material has mostly been disregarded. In the New York Times edition of the PP, all that most people have seen, you don't find any of this material. The focus is on the sixties, the failure. But the early reasoning is interesting and instructive. Essentially, our old friend the domino theory. The argument was that if Vietnam carried out successful independent development, it would be what Kissinger later called a "virus" that would "spread contagion." It would be a model that might be followed by others in the region who had suffered the harsh consequences of imperialism. They might want to follow the same course, and the system of global domination—the Grand Area—might seriously erode.

Planners were concerned that the contagion might spread not just through mainland Southeast Asia, but all the way to Indonesia. Vietnam didn't matter much, but Indonesia did. A big country, very rich resources. If the rot spread as far as Indonesia, it might reach Japan—the "super-domino," in the words of the prominent Asia scholar John Dower. If Southeast and East Asia became independent, what we call communist, Japan would be tempted to "accommodate" this bloc of states and become its technological and industrial center.

There's a name for that system. It was called the New Order in Asia that Japanese fascists were trying to establish. In the early 1950s, the United States was not ready to lose the Pacific phase of World War II, which was fought to

prevent Japan from establishing its new order. Obviously, planners weren't going to accept that.

How then do you prevent it? When a virus is spreading contagion, you must destroy the virus and inoculate potential targets. That was achieved. Vietnam was virtually destroyed. It's not a model for anybody, and is by now increasingly integrated into the global system dominated by US-based corporations. In the surrounding countries, harsh, brutal military dictatorships were established, preventing contagion. Indonesia was the most important domino. The contagion was blocked in Indonesia in 1965 by an unusually brutal US-backed military coup that killed hundreds of thousands of people and totally suppressed all dissent. The main political parties were wiped out. The country has yet to recover, even to discover what happened, all effectively concealed.

It was not concealed in the West, which could scarcely contain its euphoria about the "staggering mass slaughter" that was "a gleam of light in Asia" (New York Times), a "boiling bloodbath" that provided "new hope" for the region (the news weeklies).

The domino didn't fall, in fact, was incorporated fully within the US-dominated liberal world order, open to exploitation. US support continued right through the brutal repression and major war crimes. In 1975, Henry Kissinger gave the ruling generals a green light to invade East Timor, where they went on to carry out what appears to be the worst slaughter in per capita terms since Hitler's genocide, always with firm and decisive US support. And admiration. When the dictator, General Suharto, was invited to Washington in 2005, the Clinton administration welcomed him as "our kind of guy."

In later years, McGeorge Bundy, former national security advisor under Kennedy and Johnson, reflected that it might have been a good idea to call off the Vietnam War in 1965, when the "gleam of light" shone and the US had achieved its main goals. No pernicious models, no contagion, Indonesia was rescued, Japan was in our pocket.

Was the Vietnam War a failure, a terrible defeat? True, the US didn't achieve its maximal goal of turning Vietnam into something like the Philippines, a kind of neo-colony, but it did achieve the major goal. The dominoes didn't fall. As I mentioned last week, it's standard in commentary on international affairs to ridicule the domino theory because the dominoes didn't fall as feared. In other words, the remedy was successful. The virus was extirpated, the potential victims inoculated. But as I mentioned, though ridiculed, the domino theory is never abandoned. It's quite rational and has substantial empirical support.

The loss of China was also part of the background for NSC 68 in 1950, excerpts posted for reading this week. The document is widely and correctly recognized as a document of great significance, setting an enduring policy framework. Apart from its substance, the rhetoric is highly illuminating. Remember that this is an internal document, not for the public, not even for most of Congress, only declassified many years later.

The rhetoric is like a fairy tale. On one side there is ultimate evil, on the other, absolute perfection. Each of the antagonists has an essential nature that defines it. The document contrasts the "fundamental design of the Kremlin" with the "fundamental purpose" of the US.

"The implacable purpose of the slave state [is] to eliminate the challenge of freedom" (excerpts from NSC 68, 1950) everywhere. The "compulsion" of the Kremlin "demands total power over all men" in the slave state itself and "absolute authority over the rest of the world." The force of evil is "inescapably militant," so that no accommodation or peaceful settlement is even thinkable.

In contrast, the "fundamental purpose of the United States [is] to assure the integrity and vitality of our free society, which is founded upon the dignity and worth of the individual" (excerpts from NSC 68, 1950)—this at a time of rampant racism, even lynching, federal laws imposing segregation in public housing, and laws against miscegenation so extreme that the Nazis—who took US laws as their model—refused to go anywhere near as far as the US.

And right at the peak of McCarthyism and anti-Communist hysteria, our free society is marked by "marvelous diversity," "deep tolerance," "lawfulness," a commitment "to create and maintain an environment in which every individual has the opportunity to realize his creative powers. [It] does not fear, it welcomes, diversity [and] derives its strength from its hospitality even to antipathetic ideas." The "system of values which animates our society [includes] the principles of freedom, tolerance, the importance of the individual and the supremacy of reason over

will" (excerpts from NSC 68, 1950).

Fortunately, the perfect society has some advantages in this conflict. "The essential tolerance of our world outlook, our generous and constructive impulses, and the absence of covetousness in our international relations are assets of potentially enormous influence," particularly among those who have been lucky enough to experience these qualities at first hand, as in Latin America, which has benefited from "our long continuing endeavors to create and now develop the Inter-American system" (excerpts from NSC 68, 1950).

Latin Americans might have had some thoughts about this longstanding benevolence.

Of course, there can be no accommodation with absolute evil, so we must "foster the seeds of destruction within the Soviet Union [and] hasten its decay." We must avoid negotiations because any agreements "would reflect present realities and would therefore be unacceptable, if not disastrous, to the United States and the rest of the free world," though after the success of a "roll back strategy" we might "negotiate a settlement with the Soviet Union (or a successor state or states)" (excerpts from NSC 68, 1950). That policy is forced on us by the fundamental design of the slave state and its compulsion for world domination.